IF YOU EVER CALL

A NOVEL

BHAIYA AWARE

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are either products of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, or actual events is purely coincidental.

"To the stories that gave me worlds, and the writers who taught me to build my own."

ACT 1:

THE CASE

CHAPTER

01

Stars were glittering in the sky as it was close to midnight. November had already begun, and winter was on the doorstep. I was completely exhausted after making more than a hundred shots. I stopped dribbling the ball and sat down in the middle of the recently constructed basketball court. The entire arena suddenly went silent.

The court was surrounded by nets to prevent out throws, and each corner had a high mast light for night-time play. Sitting in the center, I could see my four shadows. Infinite shadows can be cast by an object, just like a human can have infinite faces. Humans can be compared to anything; just think of something negative in a thing and you will find that feature in humans.

Basketball is enjoyable even when played alone. Whenever I feel lost and lonely, I just shut myself off from the outside world and play this fantastic game until I am completely exhausted. Thereafter, I take a hot bath and fall asleep for hours. Nothing is more relaxing than this. I was planning to do the same when my phone buzzed.

The name of the caller was displayed on the screen.

Sarah was calling.

'Where are you?' she asked instantly as I picked up the phone.

'What for?' I asked.

She usually calls me for drinks around this time. That has only happened twice! Okay, thrice, but we are not drunkards.

'Where the hell are you, Adi?' she asked impatiently.

'I am playing basketball behind my house,' I replied. She knows that I often do this.

'Come to the Riverside Police Station right now,' she ordered.

She is a regular at police stations because she is a crime reporter. I have seen her having tea with constables. And I guess they do pay for it.

'What did you do? Is everything all right?' I asked, concerned.

It was understandable that she was working late at night, but why was she calling me?

'Everything is okay,' she said. Her answer perplexed me.

'Then why are you in the police station at twelve? Playing chess with the cops?'

Sarah is a state-level chess player. She keeps boasting about that. By the way, I have never seen a certificate or a photograph, but she told me and I believed her. She has, however, always defeated me. Like every single time.

'Shut up! Put that sarcasm in your ass and rush here,' she said, irritated. She adores using that A-word. Saying it is probably her favourite way of expressing frustration towards something.

'But why?' I tried to ask.

'You have a case, Mr. Lawyer.'

She hung up.

Did I tell you? I am a lawyer.

Within minutes, I was at the Deccan Police Station. My phone read 1 a.m.

A huge gate welcomed me onto the premises of the police campus. Warm yellow lights tried to show the area's beauty even in the dark. Neem trees covered much of the site, which is rare in Pune. When I thought of a police station, the first thing that came to my mind was parked Jeeps. But I could not find any.

No one stopped me until I reached the main door.

I found Sarah walking back and forth on the police station stairs with her Nikon D750 in her hand. She has a collection of jackets, something she wears in all seasons. That night, it was a rough, paper-white-colored jacket. I knew it was rough because I had touched it so many times before.

She noticed me and approached me swiftly.

'Ayushi Kapadia, a hotel waitress, committed murder and surrendered herself to the police.' She flooded me with words.

Kapadia surname is so cool, isn't it?

'So? What is the problem? A murderer must be punished,' I responded reflexively. I am a lawyer, you know. That's what I have in my head. Indian Penal Code.

'I think she didn't do anything,' she said, taking her gaze away. She knew what my reaction would be.

'Who are you to think? The police will conduct an investigation, and the court will make a decision,' I remarked.

She gave me a disapproving look. Sarah despises my habit of giving her law lectures. You'll understand later why she requires them.

'I am a bloody crime reporter. This isn't the first murder story I am covering. She's surrendered, but I'm quite confident she didn't murder anyone.' She looked straight at me.

'And I want you to handle her case.'

'Me? Murder case? That will be my first case, you dumb! Nope. I don't want to be a medium for hanging someone.' I denied.

Coward! That's what you are thinking, right?

'See, there is no hope either. If you don't take it, she will be punished. No one is with her. No family, no friends, no lawyer.' Sarah said it in a soft voice. Which is unusual for me. I was born for her anger.

'She must have committed the murder then. And what is the sense of hiring a lawyer when the accused has already surrendered? And yes, she will be represented by a government lawyer.'

'Something is wrong with her. She is scared. We will properly question her, and if she has not done anything, we will convince her to plead not guilty before the judge.' She said it with determination in her eyes.

She doesn't discuss. She just tells.

'Wow! Proceed with your plan. But I am exhausted and I need sleep. Good night.'

I took out my scooter keys. Sarah grabbed my hand and pulled me back. I wondered why she was so worried about a criminal.

'She's there inside. The cops will let you meet her as a lawyer. Just talk to her. If you feel she can murder someone, then you should go home and sleep your ass off. I will not stop you.'

She used the A-word again. This is where I always lose. She is a master at persuading me. I just cannot say no to her if she really wants something.

'At least look at my appearance. I'm wearing these sloppy clothes. And you know I don't like cops much.'

I looked like a clown who was fired for not being funny enough.

'Be confident. Sarah is with you,' she replied, pulling me towards the door.

That was enough. I followed her inside.

The local PI was familiar with Sarah, and it is usually a good idea to show the police a recognized face first. Sarah has strong ties to cops, medics, and anybody else involved in criminal situations. When it comes to her reporting job, the entire city of Pune is her arena.

She walked directly towards the inspector's table and signaled for me to wait behind, despite the fact that I am a postgraduate in law. She sat there and indulged herself in a discussion with the PI.

I began scanning the police station. It was quite nicely kept. Clean, undamaged walls.

Furniture with a brown-and-white color scheme. Cement tiles, which were old but tidy. Long iron rods holding fans in place. Switchboards with a mixture of the latest white switches and ancient yellow fan regulators.

A constable was preoccupied with papers and looked unconcerned about our presence. There were no more people around.

'Come here.'

My analysis of the police station was cut short by Sarah. I moved towards them and noticed the nameplate on the desk.

Vaishali Thorat.

A young-looking woman with a perfectly tailored uniform and tightly pulled-back hair sat behind the desk. She had a powerful appearance. Just like a warrior. She glanced at me as if I were her next target to imprison.

'Hello, I am Aditya Chauhan.' I introduced myself.

I did not extend my hand for a handshake. Stay away and be safe.

She motioned for me to take a seat. I jerked the chair a little, and the noise made me seem stupid. Sarah looked at me as if I had done it deliberately. In such cases, she is never supportive. I apologized to both of them.

Vaishali did not seem interested.

'Are you serious about taking this case? This effort is useless. She has already confessed.' Her face was filled with astonishment.

'I'm not sure, but I'd want to speak with her once. If she believes she needs a lawyer, I'm in,' I said. I was stuttering and there wasn't much confidence in my voice. I didn't want to take that case. I simply wanted to go home and sleep my 'ass off'.

'Is he really a criminal defense lawyer?' she asked, shifting her gaze towards Sarah.

She saw no lawyer-like qualities in me. She might have expected a suitably attired lawyer. The inspector's question did wound my ego. And who wears a suit at midnight?

'This will be his first case on his own, and I am confident he will do well,' Sarah said, attempting to support my identity.

But it was too much to cover up.

Yes, this would be my first case on my own. I had been working in several places for the past three years. Finally, when I felt confident in my abilities, I chose to handle a case myself. I was not frightened since I had some of the best lawyers on my side to guide me. And I felt good about myself.

I was waiting for someone to delegate me the responsibility of leading a good case. Apparently, someone had.

‘Anyway, you have one hour. If she says she doesn't want a lawyer after that, you two will be leaving this place,’ the inspector said.

That was what I wanted. But I was supposed to show interest in this. Just for Sarah.

I am a good lawyer. And a great actor.

‘Ma'am, before we meet her, will you please brief us about the crime?’ I asked, making the most innocent face possible.

Vaishali looked at me for a moment. Then she picked up her water bottle.

‘Hmm,’ she replied.

My words and my face both worked.

CHAPTER

02

Vaishali's Account

Every day, between 7 and 9 p.m., I take a break so that I can patrol until midnight. It was about 7:45 p.m., and I was having dinner in my apartment while watching something on my phone. My phone rang. It was Head Constable Damodar Pradhan. He quickly informed me about a murder report and advised me to reach Kamal Hospital as soon as possible. I often receive calls while having meals, so I decided to finish my food first. You need energy to work.

I changed into my uniform and drove to the hospital. The hospital was only a few kilometers from my residence, so I got there soon. The first thing that struck me when I arrived was the parking lot. It was filled with cars, mostly luxury sedans. I went straight into the hospital building. The reception area was crowded with people. A few were crying, while many others stood silently with solemn expressions. Most of them appeared to be in their early forties. The majority were dressed formally. Suits for men and sarees for women. Damodar approached me and directed me inside. We entered the intensive care unit.

A man was lying on a stretcher, covered with a white cloth. Just like we see in movies. The dead man also looked to be in his early forties. Damodar had already gathered some information about the incident, and he explained everything to me.

Mrs. Divya Batra, a renowned psychiatrist in Pune, was hosting a get-together for her school friends. Hotel Blue Rose

was the venue. It is located in Anand Nagar. The entire four-story hotel had been reserved for the gathering. Only Mrs. Batra's guests and hotel employees were supposed to be inside. The party was being held in the function hall on the ground floor. Everything had been normal until they heard a scream from upstairs. Everyone started moving towards the upper floors to find out what had happened. Some went towards the second floor while others continued towards the third. That was when they saw a girl running down the stairs. Ayushi Kapadia. She is a waitress at the hotel. According to the people there, Ayushi ran straight into the kitchen. The hotel staff followed her, but she locked herself inside. Nobody on the second floor knew exactly what had happened. That was the first strange thing.

They had heard a scream, but nobody had actually seen the incident. Some of the guests began saying that the scream sounded like Viraj's voice. Viraj Desai was one of the guests. He was nowhere to be seen. They got scared and went towards the third floor. Viraj was found lying on the bathroom floor. He was unconscious. They tried to wake him by splashing water on his face, but there was no response. Nobody knew what to do. Eventually, they carried him downstairs and took him to the hospital in Divya's SUV. The others followed in their vehicles. They reached the hospital as quickly as they could. But it was already too late. The doctors declared him dead.

After an initial examination, the doctors suspected that Viraj had been struck on the head with a hard object. The hospital owner, Dr Kelkar, suspected murder. That suspicion became stronger when the people accompanying Viraj told him about Ayushi. The police were called.

I listened carefully. At that point, the story appeared simple. A man was found unconscious inside a bathroom. A waitress was seen running away from the area immediately after a scream. She then locked herself inside the kitchen. And now the man was

dead. Simple cases are usually the ones that make you nervous. I have learned that the hard way.

After the body was sent to the government hospital for a proper post-mortem examination, I left for Hotel Blue Rose. I reached the hotel at around nine o'clock. A media gathering was already waiting outside. As soon as I stepped out of my Jeep, almost every camera turned towards me. I absolutely detest flashlights. They are disturbing. Reporters expect us to put our work aside and answer their questions whenever they see us. I ignored them and entered the hotel.

The first thing I noticed was how quiet the place had become. A few hours earlier, it had been full of people celebrating. Now everyone was waiting for the police to tell them what had happened. Ayushi was sitting on a chair downstairs. A lady constable was standing near her. She had apparently remained inside the kitchen until the police arrived. I decided to speak to her later. Mrs. Batra had already filed a complaint, and Ayushi was the primary suspect.

A constable directed me towards the third-floor bathroom. I entered. The room was small. There were broken pieces of glass scattered across the floor. One object immediately caught my attention. A broken perfume flask. I looked at it carefully. It could have fallen from Viraj's coat pocket when he collapsed. Viraj's friends later confirmed that the bottle belonged to him. I instructed the constable to collect every piece of glass from the floor properly. Then I looked around the bathroom again. There was no one there. No obvious sign told me exactly what had happened.

The problem was that there were too many assumptions and very little certainty. We knew Viraj had been found there. We knew Ayushi had been seen running downstairs. We knew someone had screamed. But nobody had actually seen Ayushi attack Viraj. And we still didn't know exactly when Viraj had

entered the bathroom. I made a mental note of it. Then I went downstairs.

Ayushi was still sitting in the same chair. The lady constable gave me a brief account of what she had learned from her. I walked towards Ayushi. She looked shocked. I offered her a glass of water and sat down on a stool in front of her. She gulped it down. Her hands were shaking.

'What exactly happened?' I asked.

She stared at the floor. For a few seconds, she didn't say anything. Then she broke down.

'I whacked him in the head with a beer bottle, and he fell.'

I remained silent for a moment.

'Why did you do that?' I asked softly.

'I was in the washroom. He tried to misbehave with me. I thought he would harm me.'

'Did he touch you?'

She shook her head.

'No.'

Then she started crying again.

I didn't know what to make of her. Sometimes crimes are committed by people who never intended to commit them. But that doesn't make the crime disappear. If her statement was true, she had struck Viraj. If it wasn't true, then I was looking at something else entirely. I asked her a few more questions, but she barely spoke. She seemed frightened. Not angry. Not defensive. Frightened.

I brought her with me to the police station. I informed her that she would be presented in court as an accused. I also told her that if she did not retain legal counsel, the government would provide a lawyer for her. She didn't seem interested. In fact, she didn't seem interested in anything. The only thing Ayushi

requested was an empty room where she could sit alone. I granted her request.

She had been sitting there for almost three hours. I looked towards the clock. Then towards the two people standing in front of me.

A journalist.

And a lawyer.

This was going to be a long night.

CHAPTER

03

Inspector Vaishali stopped speaking and took a sip from her water bottle. Sarah was completely absorbed in her thoughts. And I was unable to comprehend how I felt. What Vaishali had told us made me look at the case from another side. A waitress murdering a guest was unusual enough, but the story itself was too simple.

One thing was certain. This was not a good case to take, especially when it was my first time.

'Is that enough?' the inspector asked. She sounded as if she had just finished giving a presentation.

'Were there any other conversations between you and her?' I asked out of curiosity.

'I have already told you everything. She doesn't speak much,' she replied.

I nodded.

'Can we meet her now?' Sarah finally spoke after a long silence.

'She is inside. You have an hour.'

Inspector Vaishali pointed towards a room. How nice police can be sometimes.

My past encounters with cops had not exactly been pleasant. Once, when I was on a train with some friends, a gentleman from the railway police stopped us and fined us nine hundred rupees for travelling without a ticket. I was once out without a mask

during lockdown for some work, and a traffic cop sent me back home just because I wasn't wearing one. And once...

Okay.

The crux is, either the police have a major problem with me, or I am a problematic person.

We all rose and made our way towards the room. Vaishali pushed open the door but did not enter.

'Here is a lawyer. Just talk to him once,' she told Ayushi.

I was standing on my toes behind Vaishali, trying to get a look inside. She turned around and caught me doing it. She shook her head and went back to her table.

Sarah and I entered the room. An old wooden table stood in the center. Four chairs were arranged around it. Ayushi was sitting on one of them, facing the entrance. Her head was bent. Her posture said everything her mouth wasn't saying.

Grief.

We sat in the chairs beside her. She didn't even look at us. For a long moment, nobody spoke. Sarah and I kept signaling to each other about who should begin. Ayushi knew someone had taken the seat in front of her. She simply didn't give a shit.

'Hello, Ayushi,' Sarah finally said, breaking the silence.

Ayushi slowly raised her head. For the first time, I got a proper look at her. She was one of those people whose face changed completely with their emotions. Pink when happy, red when furious. At that moment, there was nothing of either.

Her complexion was extremely fair, almost like milk. Her eyes were red from crying. She had long black eyelashes and dark hair that fell just below her shoulders, with a slight curl at the ends. A small diamond nose ring caught the light. Her lips were dry and rose-pink.

But none of those things mattered.

Her eyes did.

They looked frightened.

Not the kind of frightened you see when someone is afraid of the police.

It was deeper than that.

For a split second, our eyes met. I had never met this girl before, but there was something about that look that stayed with me. I couldn't explain it. I didn't try.

'I'm sorry, but I don't need a lawyer,' she said quietly. 'And I also don't have the money to pay your fees.'

Her voice made it clear that she had no interest in talking to us. She had made us feel insignificant. But that is what we were to her at that moment. Two strangers.

'We are not here to earn money, Ayushi. We just want to help you,' I replied gently.

Sarah looked at me with astonishment. She had probably never heard me speak so softly to a girl. But that is how I communicate with clients, irrespective of their age or gender.

Yes, it was my first case on my own. But I had spent the previous three years working with some of the best lawyers in the city. I knew how to talk to people. At least, I liked to think I did.

'I have done a crime,' Ayushi said. 'I am a murderer, and I will bear this guilt for the rest of my life. I destroyed everything. Nothing will ever be the same.'

Her voice broke.

Society punishes criminals much harsher than the law does. And I could tell that was one of her biggest fears.

'You did it accidentally,' Sarah said in a convincing tone. 'If you don't defend your case in court, you will only create more trouble for yourself.'

Her use of language was top-notch. She should have been a lawyer instead of me. She knows how to say more with fewer words. Her certainty was on another level. Even before properly listening to Ayushi, she had already decided that it was an accident.

What if Ayushi had done it deliberately?

That possibility could not be overlooked. I had seen cases where people killed others without any obvious motive.

'I no longer care about troubles,' Ayushi said. 'I've had enough of them. My life is a disappointment to everyone around me.'

She lowered her eyes and continued crying.

I was struggling to understand this girl. She didn't fit into any of the categories I usually assigned people. I have gained this incredible talent over the course of my life. When I meet someone, I immediately try to understand what kind of person they are. I put them into specific brackets, and they usually fit like a glove. Somehow, I am almost always correct. Don't call me judgmental now. It's a life skill.

However, Ayushi didn't fit anywhere.

'Don't be afraid. We're here for you.' I said, attempting to cheer her up.

She was clearly not eight years old. She didn't reply with a 'hurray'. She didn't need that kind of motivation.

'I am fine with going to jail,' she replied.

For a moment, I felt like taking her to jail myself and showing her what jails were actually like. It wasn't going to be as easy as she thought.

By the way, I was obsessing about Ayushi way too much. I wanted to persuade her. Something inside me was pushing me to do it. Perhaps it was sympathy. Being a lawyer, I have always had

a soft spot for people who are blamed initially and turn out to be innocent later. So, in her case, I assumed it was just my lawyer instinct. At least, that's what I told myself.

'Think about it again, Ayushi,' I almost requested.

Sarah remained quiet. That was unusual. Normally, Sarah cannot stay quiet for that long.

'Sorry. Please leave,' Ayushi said.

What was going on? What sorry? Was I selling credit cards? Were we really that unimportant?

I badly wanted to show her my degree.

My stomach dropped. Why did this naive girl want to be locked up? She was unaware of how prisons operated. Jail is a hailstorm. There, she would not encounter people like herself.

I thought for a moment, Then I spoke.

'Behind bars, it's the end. This is not a game. Try to understand the situation.'

I raised my voice slightly. But my reprimand was delivered with care.

Ayushi gave me a somber stare. Sarah looked startled. Inside a police station, I was probably not supposed to yell at the PI's favorite criminal.

Oh, sorry, She was not a criminal.

'If Vaishali hears your loud voice, she'll kick you in the ass,' Sarah whispered in my ear.

There was no use trying to persuade Ayushi anymore. You cannot defend someone in court who is unwilling to defend themselves.

'I'm leaving. You handle this.'

I stood up from my chair. I had given up.

I know how I am. Things like this stay in my head for weeks. The trail was already set. I knew I would think about Ayushi for the next several days and follow every piece of news about her.

I offered help, she denied. Not my fault

I am a good person.

I am a good person.

'Are you sure, Ayushi? You don't need a lawyer?' Sarah asked one last time.

Ayushi nodded. There was no hesitation. She seemed completely certain about her decision. Her deadly decision.

'Take care,' Sarah said.

She rose from her chair. The meeting had lasted less than ten minutes. We stepped outside and walked towards Inspector Vaishali's desk. She looked at our faces and understood everything.

'I had already told you,' she said, hiding her disappointment. She too wanted to help Ayushi.

'she is impossible. Anyway, thank you so much, Vaishali, for allowing us to meet her,' Sarah said.

Vaishali?

Sarah was calling her by name? I knew she had good connections, but this close? She said it as if Vaishali were her roommate.

'In case she changes her mind, please call us,' I said. Vaishali looked slightly surprised by my concern.

I was interested in Ayushi.

I mean, I was interested in the case. Even though I knew I wouldn't get paid for it.

For me, becoming a lawyer was never just about money. I come from a privileged background. You can call me rich. My

father has a large restaurant business in Bangalore, a chain of six big restaurants. Moreover, In the previous three years, I had earned more than my expenses. So handling one case without being paid wasn't a huge concern for me.

'I will,' Vaishali replied with a smile. Yeah, they smile too.

I wrote my name and phone number on a blank A4 sheet. A little hope was included in addition to the usual ink and paper. I didn't want this to be my only meeting with Ayushi.

'Can I see her one more time?' I asked.

Sarah and Vaishali exchanged perplexed looks. If something persists in my mind, I just do it. Otherwise, it continues to disrupt my life.

'Sure,' Inspector Vaishali replied.

I turned towards the room before she had even finished the word. I walked forward and opened the door. Ayushi was sitting in the same position, her head down.

'Hey, you.'

She looked up.

'Inspector has my number. Call me if you need.'

I said it loudly enough for her to hear. Then I closed the door.

Later, Sarah and I thanked Vaishali once more and left. I had come to the police station thinking I might be taking a murder case. Instead, I was going home without one.

At least, that's what I thought.

CHAPTER

04

'How did you find out about this?' I asked Sarah.

We were driving home. She enjoys driving my scooter, so she was in charge of it. It was three in the morning, and the night was slowly coming to an end. The temperature had dropped uncomfortably low, and I was squeezing myself into my hoodie. Sarah hadn't even bothered to put on a mask or anything to cover her face. I wondered how she survived Pune winters like that.

'Do you remember Vaishali mentioning the reporters outside Blue Rose Hotel?' she asked loudly so I could hear her. Conversations on bikes are extremely challenging.

'You were also there?'

'The first reporter to arrive there was Sarah.'

She said it proudly. She really enjoys repeating her own name. By doing so, she feels aristocratic. By the way, what kind of pride do news outlets get from being the first to report a crime? I never understood it. For them, being first sometimes seems more important than the gravity of the crime.

'There must have been numerous reporters there. Why did you take such a great interest in Ayushi?' I asked dramatically.

Sarah didn't answer immediately. She slowed down the scooter.

'When I arrived at the hotel, I saw Ayushi.' Her voice became quieter.

'She was crying hysterically. I felt awful for her.' I remained silent.

'Does she look like a criminal to you? She looks like a simple chicken. I doubt she can kill a mosquito.'

I laughed.

'I'm serious, Adi.'

'I know.'

'I understand she's done something wrong. I know it's complicated. I'm not stupid'

'Debatable.'

'Shut up.'

There she was.

'But I Still felt like helping her somehow. Fortunately, Vaishali was in charge. I know her well, and she also thought something was wrong. But Ayushi had already confessed, so Vaishali couldn't do much for her.' Sarah paused.

'Then you were the only person who came to my mind.'

I looked at the back of her head.

'Me?, I would never call me. You could have called an actual lawyer'

She laughed.

'You are an actual lawyer.'

'That's unfortunate.' I said. She accelerated.

'Anyway, nothing worked. She refused your help too.'

'Our help.'

'Yeah. Our help.' She said it reluctantly.

'At least we tried.' I replied.

Sarah wasn't her usual self that night. She wasn't behaving like a reporter chasing a story. She genuinely wanted to help Ayushi, and that side of her was rare. Calm.

Compassionate. Almost innocent. Almost.

'Are you really Sarah?' I asked. 'Girl, wake up and remember who you are. You fight people, you hate children, and you never obey the law. When did you become a good person?'

I patted her on the head. I don't know why, but every time she does something genuinely positive, it makes me proud.

'I was born kind,' she shouted over her shoulder. Then she accelerated the scooter. I held on tighter.

'You were born dangerous.'

'I heard that!'

'Good.' She laughed.

For a few seconds, neither of us spoke. The road was almost empty. Then Sarah said, 'Adi.'

'Hmm?'

'There was something else.' Her voice had changed again. Almost dramatically.

'What?'

'At the hotel.'

I waited.

'The bathroom.'

I frowned.

'What about it?'

'Something didn't feel right.'

'That's not very specific.'

'I know. But there has to be something, I saw the crime scene.'

'A lot of people did, including the police', I pointed. She slowed down, again.

'They saw a dead man and a waitress who ran away.'

I didn't say anything.

'But nobody saw her hit him.' she continued

' Didn't she just confess? And the scream?.'

'No. That's different.' Sara said, her voice firm.

I thought about what Vaishali had told us. The scream. Ayushi running down the stairs. Viraj found upstairs. The bathroom. The beer bottle. Everything seemed to connect. And yet...

'what's bothering you?' I asked. Sarah was quiet for a moment.

'The timing.'

'What timing?'

'I'll tell you tomorrow.'

'Why tomorrow?'

'Because you're tired.'

'I'm awake now.'

'Didn't you want to sleep your ass off?.'

'common don't leave this hanging.'

She laughed.

'Go home, lawyer.' She giggled. I didn't argue

Three years ago.

'Ma'am, my guitar string broke,' Sarah said in a low voice. That was the first and last time I ever heard her speak in a low voice.

'You broke it. It didn't break itself,' the guitar teacher replied. The woman was in her forties and in excellent shape. She was the ideal person to teach guitar. There was a mixture of rage and affection in the way she approached it. In my opinion, people who lack passion or emotion can never truly teach an art.

It was my first day at Pune's Imperial School of Music. I had already obtained my law degree and was working at my first law firm. My father had suggested that I move to Pune. He had completed his higher education here, and he always told me that once you started living in Pune, you couldn't help falling in love with the city.

I didn't have much work pressure at the time. I was just starting out, so most days I was sent around with paperwork, delivering files from one place to another. I worked from seven in the morning until two in the afternoon, which left me with plenty of time on my hands. So I decided to join a guitar class.

I had always wanted to sing and play the guitar in front of a crowd. Unfortunately, the guitar was going to have to do most of the heavy lifting. I sang like a pig.

This particular music school was also the nearest one to me. I had bought a decent black guitar and was attending my first lesson. That was where I met Sarah.

She had a slim build, soft, cream-colored hands, lustrous black hair with a slight brown tinge that fell all the way to her waist, and deep black eyes. Her skin looked healthier than mine, which I found mildly unfair. She wore a black denim jacket that completed the outfit, giving her a look that was somehow both delicate and rugged.

I had always carried this preconceived notion that people who looked like her were usually wealthy.

There were around twenty students in the room. We were learning how to tune our guitars. I had watched several videos

about it beforehand. Sarah had not. She broke one of her guitar strings while trying to tune it.

I tuned my guitar without any help from the tutor. She praised me and asked me to help the others. Sarah was the one most in need of rescue. She looked at me, and somehow, that look made it my responsibility.

I am a good person.

I put down my guitar and walked towards her. She handed it to me, and I examined it like a professional. When you are with someone dumber than you, you are an expert.

Let me tell you something about me first. I am at the peak of introversion. I find it extremely difficult to start conversations with people I don't know. Small talk is one of the greatest punishments invented by humanity. People often think I am rude. I'm not. I just don't know what to say.

My existence revolves around a very small group of people I genuinely care about. Sometimes I feel shitty about my attitude towards the world, but in the end, it is probably the finest way for me to live peacefully.

'I don't know how to tie new strings,' I said as I removed the broken one. Sarah raised an eyebrow.

'What?'

'New string? I don't have one. Can't we just repair it?'

'No. It's broken in the middle.'

She looked at the teacher, then at me.

'So now?'

She had somehow made me responsible for the situation.

'I have an extra string packet. Take this.'

I gave it to her. There was no other packet. It had taken me two hours to find the one I had just handed her.

Why was I helping her? Perhaps it was simply the good upbringing my parents had given me.

She looked at the packet.

'Why do you have so many of these?'

'Because all are different.'

I had gathered some information about guitars before joining the class. Sarah was a true beginner.

She took the broken string to the teacher, and her guitar was repaired. I still remember the smile on her face. It was completely uncontrollable. I had never thought a twentytwo-year-old could smile so beautifully. I used to believe only children smiled like that.

Our smiles change as we get older. The genuine ones require something tremendous to bring them out. The fake ones become so natural that we don't even realize we're doing it.

After an hour, the class ended. I was waiting for a thank you from the guitar girl. Sarah, however, had already forgotten about me. She became busy with her guitar and left without even looking at me.

I was offended. Not seriously. But enough to remember it.

The following day, Sarah arrived late and took the seat beside mine. My attention was divided between her and the tutor. After giving us some basic information, the teacher took a short break and stepped outside.

Sarah immediately turned towards me, as if she had been waiting for the opportunity.

'Hey, thanks for yesterday,' she said with a smile.

I smiled back and continued with my guitar. She did the same. I could see her from the corner of my eye, struggling to place her fingertips on the fretboard. It was too much for her short fingers to handle.

She gave up on the guitar and looked at me again.

'Are you from Pune?'

'No.'

I kept my eyes on my guitar.

She stared at me.

'Why can't you reply in complete sentences?'

She sounded irritated.

You see, I told you people think I am rude. Though I am not. But I liked the way she semi-scolded me.

'I am from Bangalore, and I work in a law firm here. I've been in Pune for a month now. I smiled while saying it to look more polite.

'And your name?'

'Aditya Chauhan.'

'Karnataka has Chauhan's?' She sounded genuinely curious.

'My father relocated to Bangalore. My family is originally from Uttar Pradesh.' She nodded. She knew a lot. I had assumed she was dumb.

I was supposed to ask about her now since I was participating in the conversation.

'And how about you?'

If you're an introvert like me, here's a useful trick: ask questions. When the other person answers one, ask another. Keep doing that. It makes you look interested, while secretly giving you a few extra seconds to figure out what the hell you're supposed to say next.

It may not make your conversations any more meaningful. But it can save you from a lot of awkwardness, uncomfortable silences, and the desperate urge to escape.

'I'm Sarah. I'm originally from Pune. I recently started working for Prime News

Network as a crime reporter after completing my master's in journalism.'

It was simply amazing how she chose her words. And how did she finish her master's degree as a child? I mean, she did not look her age. Sarah appeared at least four years younger than her biological age.

'Wow, crime reporting! Sounds thrilling.'

'well it's not to be honest, right now I'm dealing with really boring and insignificant stuff.' She sounded genuinely disappointed.

'I am a lawyer, so crimes are part of my life too.'

Lawyer, my foot. Back then, I felt like the least important person in my office.

'Oh, so there is a criminal connection here.'

She laughed at her own joke. I liked it.

The tutor returned, and the lesson started again. We were unconcerned with the world of music for the next hour. We continued glancing at each other and smiling.

The following three months were dedicated to our guitar course. Sarah and I ended up getting along despite having completely different inner selves. I was new to the city, so she became my first informal friend. Otherwise, I only knew people from work.

My room was a few kilometers from her hostel. Back then, I had a single rented room to call home. Later, Sarah helped me find a one-bedroom apartment.

I liked her company. She was the first person in my life who made me feel this comfortable. We began meeting after work, sharing meals, and roaming around the city in auto-rickshaws.

Sarah had never left Pune since birth. She had completed everything here, from primary school to her job. A year before we met, her father had voluntarily retired from the Indian Revenue Service, and her parents had moved back to their hometown. Because of her passion for crime reporting, Sarah decided to remain in Pune and pursue her career. Despite having a house in Pune, she stayed in a girls' hostel.

Over time, I realized she was very different from how she appeared. She looked extroverted but was actually an ambivert. She had a tough exterior but a kind heart. She appeared aggressive but was incredibly loving.

Both of us were advancing in our careers. Sarah was giving everything to her work. I was assisting experienced attorneys and trying to pick their brains whenever possible.

Months passed. Our bond kept growing.

Friendship is probably the nicest feeling humans can experience. At some point, being together becomes a necessity. And without realizing it, Sarah had become that necessity for me.

We started spending more and more time at my apartment. She would spend her free days in my drawing room, resting on the couch and watching TV. Three years later, she was still doing exactly the same thing. Only now, she had a camera, a better job, several police contacts, and the ability to drag me into murder cases at three in the morning.

Some things never change.

'Adi.' Sarah's voice brought me back. We had reached my street.

'Hmm?'

'You're thinking about her, aren't you?'

I didn't answer.

She parked the scooter.

'Ayushi.' She said, waiting for a reply as I looked at her.

'Yes.'

Sarah smiled faintly.

'Me too.'

She got off the scooter. For once, neither of us made a joke. Because somewhere between the police station and my house, Ayushi had stopped being just another accused person. And I had a feeling we hadn't heard the whole story yet.

CHAPTER

05

I dropped Sarah at her hostel. It was already late, but hostel timings were never really a problem for her. Everyone knew she was a reporter, and the warden had probably accepted by now that Sarah followed her own clock.

I went straight home. I parked my scooter outside and checked the handle lock twice.

I always did that. I don't know why. Maybe I trusted the lock less than I trusted myself.

Home is always comforting. I washed my face and collapsed onto the couch. For the first few minutes, I tried not to think about anything. Naturally, I thought about Ayushi.

She had refused our help. Fair enough. We had offered. She had said no. End of story. Except it didn't feel like the end of anything.

I closed my eyes and remembered the way she had looked at us. She wasn't angry. She wasn't arrogant. She wasn't even trying to convince us of anything. She just looked tired.

Why were we trying to help her? Was it forced help? What the hell was forced help?

I opened my eyes. I was already arguing with myself, which is never a good sign. Maybe Sarah was right. Maybe there was something wrong with the whole thing. Or maybe I was simply feeling sorry for a girl who had admitted to killing someone. I was a lawyer, not a charity worker. At least, that was what I told myself.

My phone buzzed. Sarah.

I stared at her name for a few seconds before answering.

'What?' I spoke

'Are you sleeping?'

'No.'

'Good. Come tomorrow morning.' Sarah said.

'Where?'

'Police station.'

I sat up.

'Why?'

'We are going to talk to Ayushi again.'

I rubbed my eyes.

'Sarah, she already said no.'

'I know.'

'Then?'

'Then we ask again.'

'That's your brilliant plan?'

'Yes.'

'And what exactly are we going to say?' There was a short silence.

'That's your department, Mr. Lawyer.'

I laughed despite myself. She hung up. I kept staring at the screen.

The first rule of life is to start small, and what I wanted to do was fucking ginormous. I wanted to solve a murder before I had even properly taken the case. But first, apparently, I had to convince the accused to let me defend her.



The next morning, Sarah called again. I was barely awake.

'Get ready.' She ordered.

'Good morning to you too.'

'Ten minutes.'

'Sarah, it's Sunday.'

'Yeah, so?'

'Normal people sleep on Sundays.'

'You are nothing normal.'

She cut the call.

I got ready. Within ten minutes, I had washed my face, brushed my teeth, changed my clothes, had a large glass of milk, switched everything off, and locked the house.

Sarah was waiting outside on her yellow Vespa. She was wearing a white T-shirt, black jacket, and black jeans.

'Did you charge your phone?' she asked.

'Ten percent.' I replied.

She gave me the I-knew-it-fucker look.

'Power-saving mode.' she said, pointing at my phone pocket. I obeyed.

I sat behind her as she started the scooter. She was strangely calm. I wasn't.

As we rode towards the police station, the same thought kept returning. We already knew Ayushi didn't want a lawyer. She didn't want to talk. She didn't even seem interested in defending herself.

So why were we going back? We had other ways to spend a Sunday. Pune had plenty of them.

'How are we going to persuade her?' I asked. 'We know how she reacts. She barely talks.' Sarah didn't turn around.

'I assumed you would have the script ready since you're a lawyer.'

'Not funny Sarah, I'm trying to make a point here.'

'I believe your degree is genuine.'

'I have absolutely no idea what I'm going to say.'

'Relax. Even if we don't succeed, they won't throw us in jail.'

How could she be so unnecessarily calm?

The police station was almost in sight. With every meter, my heart rate increased. I didn't want to meet Ayushi's eyes again. What was the point? I couldn't help someone who didn't want to be helped. Could I?

We entered the police campus. Sarah stopped the scooter, and we got off. She looked at me and smiled. It was one of those small smiles she gave when she knew I was overthinking.

We were just about to enter the station when my phone rang.

Unknown number.

I answered.

'Hello?'

There was silence for a second. Then a soft voice.

'Mr. Aditya?'

I froze.

'Yes?'

'Ayushi here.'

I looked at Sarah. She was staring at me.

'I need a lawyer.'

CHAPTER

06

I immediately ended the call. 'Ayushi called,' I told Sarah. She didn't ask anything. We both ran inside the police station.

Ayushi was standing near the phone table. Her face looked even more exhausted than it had the night before. Her hair was messy, her eyelids were heavy, and there was a red mark on her forehead where she had apparently been resting her head against the table. She looked like she hadn't slept at all.

'What brings you here? She was calling you only,' Vaishali said from her desk.

She was holding a few papers and looked completely fresh. How? We had left this place a few hours ago. She was still here. The contrast between her energetic face and our exhausted ones was almost insulting.

'Sarah wanted to talk to Ayushi once again,' I said.

Sarah's eyes widened. I avoided looking at her. Her eyes could roast me without a fire.

Ayushi continued staring at me. There was something different in her eyes now. Hope, maybe. She looked broken.

'She wanted to talk to you,' Vaishali said. 'I think she has changed her mind. She wants to defend herself, right, Ayushi?'

Ayushi nodded. Sarah walked towards her.

'Relax, Ayushi. Did you eat anything?'

Vaishali answered before Ayushi could.

'She didn't.'

When it came to her investigating officer, Ayushi was probably the luckiest accused person on the planet.

'Can we bring her something to eat?' Sarah asked. Vaishali nodded.

'Go ahead.' Sarah looked at me. That look meant one thing. Go!

I walked outside and had no idea what to get. Eventually, I bought chai and samosas. Even robots would love samosas if you offered them one.

I returned to the room. Sarah and Ayushi were sitting at the same table from last night. I placed the food in front of them. Sarah served Ayushi and pushed the plate towards her.

Ayushi didn't touch it.

'Eat a little,' I said. She looked at me, and her eyes pierced me like X-rays.

'I don't want anything. I just wanted to say something.' Her voice was barely audible.

'What? about the murder?' I asked. She looked down. For a few seconds, nobody spoke. Then she began.

'I killed him.' Sarah went completely still. I didn't say anything.

'But I didn't want to kill him.' Her hands started shaking. She took a deep breath.

'The party was going on normally. I was working in the kitchen most of the time. There were a lot of people, and I was just trying to make sure everything went smoothly,' she said in a single breath.

'Then there was an argument.'

'Argument? with Viraj?' Sarah asked.

'He was drunk. He started saying things to me. I answered him back.' Her voice became quieter.

Sarah glanced at me. I understood what she meant.

'What happened after that?' I asked.

'Mrs. Divya tried to calm him down. Other people did too. I left.'

She wiped her eyes.

'I didn't want any more trouble. I went back to the kitchen. I had decided not to step out at all.'

For a moment, she seemed calmer. Then her expression changed again.

'After some time, I needed to use the washroom.' Ayushi continued

'The third floor?' I asked. She nodded.

'Only the third-floor washroom is allowed for hotel staff.'

That's weird by the way.

I remembered what Vaishali had told us. The third-floor bathroom. The same place where Viraj was found.

'What happened there?' Sara was getting impatient.

'I washed my hands. I splashed some water on my face. I wanted to forget what had happened downstairs.' She said struggling to swallow.

'I was even thinking about apologizing to Divya.'

Then she stopped.

'The door opened.'

Sarah leaned forward.

'Viraj walked in.'

Ayushi's hands began trembling again, as if she had gone back to that moment. I gave her a slight nod, an ineffective attempt at reassurance.

'I was terrified.'

'What did he do?' Sara asked.

'He stepped towards me.' Her breathing became uneven. It was getting difficult for her to keep talking.

'He said something. I don't remember exactly what.'

'Try.' I said.

'I think he said, "You bit..."' She closed her eyes.

'And I panicked.' She looked at the table.

'There was an empty beer bottle near the sink.'

I knew what was coming.

'I picked it up and hit him.'

Sarah's expressions changed.

'Where?' she asked.

'His head.' Ayushi's voice broke.

'He screamed and fell.' She gave up the control abd started crying.

'I didn't know what I had done. There was no blood. I thought he had just passed out.'

I looked at Sarah. She was listening carefully.

'Then?'

'I ran. Downstairs. To the kitchen.' She wiped her face with both hands.

'I stayed there until the police came.' Her voice became almost a whisper.

'I thought I had only hit him. I didn't know one hit could do that.'

She looked at me.

'I killed him.'

This time, she said it like a fact. Not an accusation. Not a confession she wanted anyone to hear. Just something she had already sentenced herself for.

Sarah spoke after a brief pause.

'Ayushi, why didn't you scream? Why didn't you run? Why did you immediately think he was going to hurt you?'

Ayushi looked at her.

'I couldn't stop myself.' She replied shaking her head.

'It just happened.'

Sarah looked unconvinced. There was something uncomfortable about the story. Not because I thought Ayushi was lying. Because parts of it were still missing.

She had hit Viraj. She admitted it. She had run downstairs. She had waited for the police. Everything matched the broad outline we already knew.

But there were still questions.

Why had Viraj entered the washroom? Just because of a small argument? What exactly had he said? Why had he followed her there? What had he wanted from her? And why had he entered the women's washroom at all? Most importantly, what had happened after she hit him and before she ran downstairs? had Viraj entered the washroom? Just because of a small argument? What did he exactly say?

I pushed the questions aside. Not yet. She had finally agreed to let me defend her. That mattered more.

Sarah looked at Ayushi.

'You didn't want a lawyer yesterday. Why today?'

Ayushi stared at her hands.

'I was shaken. I wasn't thinking properly.'

It wasn't a satisfying answer. But I stopped Sarah from asking anything else. This wasn't an interrogation. She had already spent enough time blaming herself. I needed to know enough to defend her, not enough to make her feel worse.

I looked at Ayushi.

'So, Ayushi, do you really want me to take your case?'

She looked at me for a moment.

Then nodded.

'Yes.'

I smiled.

'Okay.'

For the first time since I had met her, Ayushi looked slightly relieved.

'We'll be back in the evening,' I told her. She nodded again. We made sure she ate before leaving.

Sarah barely spoke as we walked out of the police station. That worried me. She was usually the one filling every silence, so when she went quiet, I knew something was going on in her head. And with Sarah, that was rarely a good sign.

We reached a tea shop nearby. I ordered two cups. Then I looked at her.

'Sarah, what happened?'

She stared at her tea.

'I don't know yet.'

That was not the answer I expected.

'Then why do you look like you've solved something?'

She finally looked at me.

'I think we have a problem, Adi.'

'What problem?'

She took a sip of tea.

'Her story makes sense.'

I waited.

'But something doesn't.'

And there it was. The feeling I had been trying to ignore since last night. Something was wrong.

ACT 2:

THE SEARCH

CHAPTER

07

It was twelve in the afternoon. Sarah and I were in the drawing room of my house. She loved my couch. I was lying on the floor mat, staring at the slowly rotating fan. We had been sitting in the same positions for almost twenty minutes without exchanging a word.

'What should we do now?' Sarah finally asked.

'I don't know,' I replied, still looking at the fan.

'Your parents wasted their money on your education.'

'I think the same.'

'Shut up, Adi. We have to do something.'

She got up from the couch, and I finally looked at her.

'I doubt Ayushi will get bail. That's not going to happen.'

Bail was the only thing I had been thinking about since morning. I just wanted Ayushi out of that police station. Seeing her sitting there had started bothering me more than I wanted to admit.

'Not a chance at all?' Sarah asked.

'There is a glimmer of hope.'

She raised an eyebrow.

'How much?'

'One percent.'

Sarah folded her hands.

'Then please speak, Lord Adi.'

I got up from the floor and sat beside her.

'We need to present it as an act of self-defense.'

Sarah stared at me.

'She hit him because she thought he was going to hurt her.'

'Exactly.'

'But he didn't actually hurt her.'

'I know.'

'Then how do we prove that he intended to?'

That was the problem. Viraj had entered a women's washroom while drunk. He had already argued with Ayushi downstairs and threatened her. But threats and intentions were not the same thing in court. I couldn't simply stand in front of a judge and say, Trust me, he was going to do something.

'We don't have to prove that he definitely would have attacked her,' I said. 'We have to establish why Ayushi believed she was in danger at that moment.'

Sarah thought about it.

'And if the judge doesn't buy it?'

'Then we have a problem.'

'Great. Very reassuring.'

'I am being honest.'

'You could at least lie a little. You're a lawyer.'

I smiled.

'If we want Ayushi to have any chance, self-defense is the direction we have to explore.'

Sarah nodded slowly. She wasn't completely convinced. Neither was I. But it was the only direction we had.

'I know it sounds a little dishonest,' I admitted. 'But we're not inventing what happened.

She really believed he was going to hurt her.'

Sarah looked at me.

'And you believe her?'

I paused.

'Yes.'

She nodded.

'Then let's do it.'

That was Sarah. She could question everything for twenty minutes and then make a decision in five seconds. I picked up my phone.

'I should speak to a few senior lawyers.'

'How many?'

'As many as answer.'

I called people I had worked with before and explained the basic facts. Their advice was almost unanimous. Self-defense would be difficult, but it was worth presenting. Nobody promised me anything. That was probably the first useful thing I heard all day.

This was my first case on my own. I knew the law. I knew courtrooms. But knowing something and being responsible for someone else's freedom were two very different things.

I looked at Sarah.

'I'll need you until this gets a direction.'

She smiled.

'I was planning to go to work tomorrow.'

'I know.'

'I can take a break.'

'They won't fire you?'

She made an unnecessarily confident face.

'They won't fire me because, as you know, I'm the best.'

'Wow. Advantages of being the daughter of a civil servant.'

She picked up a pillow and threw it at me. I ducked.

'Hey!'

'Don't bring my father into this.'

I laughed. Sarah was good at her job. Really good. It wasn't her father's influence that had made her successful. It was Sarah. She had a strange ability to walk into places where nobody wanted reporters and somehow walk out with information.

That was exactly what I needed.

She looked at me.

'I am hungry.'

'Of course you are.'

'I had an omelet in the morning.'

'That's practically a feast.'

'And you haven't even offered your guest water.'

'Guest?'

I looked around the room.

'You live here more than I do.'

She smiled.

'I'm cooking.'

I immediately became suspicious.

'No.'

'Why?'

'Because I remember your chicken biryani.'

She laughed. I hadn't eaten chicken for a month after that.

'Shut up. I'll help.'

'Your definition of help is sitting on the kitchen counter and saying "good" every five minutes.'

'Fine. I'll supervise.'

We went into the kitchen. I decided to make pakoras. It was one of the few things I could make without creating a national emergency.

My father had been a chef before he started his restaurant business, so cooking had always been around me. Living alone had also taught me that knowing how to cook was not a hobby. It was survival.

'What do you want?' I asked.

'Stop being a waiter.'

The word waiter immediately reminded me of Ayushi. I wondered whether she had eaten anything after we left. We had practically forced her to eat those samosas. I hoped she would keep eating.

'Fine. I'll make pakoras.'

'Go ahead. I'll cooperate.'

Her cooperation consisted of sitting on the granite counter and occasionally saying:

'Good.'

'Well done.'

'Excellent.'

Thirty minutes later, the kitchen smelled like fried besan and Imli chutney. We carried everything to the dining table.

Sarah looked at the plate.

'Please don't judge me if I eat all of these.'

'I made enough pakoras to feed a starving family. Do your honors.'

She laughed. I took one.

Perfect.

I have read somewhere that only a small percentage of men cook. That needs to change. Anyway, I'm doing my part.

We ate quietly for a few minutes.

Then Sarah asked, 'What are we doing next?'

I wiped my fingers and leaned back.

'I have already called a friend. He'll handle the procedures and paperwork.'

'Who?'

'Rohit.'

'Who is Rohit?'

'He used to work with me at Sinha's office. We started around the same time.'

Sarah nodded.

'And Sinha?'

'He has helped me a lot.'

Jitendra Sinha was one of the most respected lawyers I had worked with. I had spent ten months in his office, watching him handle cases and stealing every useful thing I could learn. He was the one who encouraged me to start practising on my own. He was also the first person I contacted about Ayushi. He had already told Rohit to help me with the paperwork and formalities.

I still didn't call Sinha sir when he wasn't around.

Shame on me.

Sarah took another pakora.

'So what's our actual plan?'

I looked at her.

'Your responsibility is to make sure Ayushi doesn't change her mind again.'

She nodded.

'And you?'

'I prepare for court.'

'What if Vaishali doesn't let us meet her? I mean, I do her but...'

'She will.' I cut her.

'How do you know?'

'Because she cares about Ayushi.'

Sarah gave me a doubtful look.

'And if she doesn't?'

'Then you use your reporter magic.'

'Now you're learning.' She laughed. Her usual devil laugh.

We finished lunch. Sarah left for her hostel, and we decided to meet directly at the police station in the evening.

After she left, I opened my laptop and created a new document. At the top, I typed:

AYUSHI KAPADIA

Underneath it, I began writing everything. What we knew. What Ayushi had told us. What the police knew. What we didn't know. Every contradiction. Every possible argument. Every question.

Writing everything down made the case feel less like a giant mess inside my head.

A lawyer can lose a case. That's part of the job. But running out of things to say in court? That's embarrassing.

I worked for almost an hour. Then I looked at the clock. Three in the afternoon. I was exhausted.

I collapsed onto the couch. Within minutes, I fell asleep.

And then I dreamed about Ayushi. She was standing on top of a huge building, running towards me. Behind her were people I couldn't recognise. They were getting closer. Ayushi reached

me and grabbed my hand. She was crying. I tried to pull her behind me, but the terrace had no railing. The people kept coming. Then Ayushi's foot slipped.

'Ayu!'

I woke up. My heart was racing. I looked around. The room was empty.

'Just a bad dream.'

I slapped myself twice for absolutely no reason. The clock said three-thirty. I had slept for only thirty minutes. I closed my eyes again, but sleep wasn't coming anymore. Something about the dream had stayed with me. I didn't know what it was. I just knew

I didn't like it at all.

At five, my phone rang. Sarah. I answered.

'Where are you?'

'Home.'

'Come pick me up.'

'Give me twenty minutes.'

'Ten.'

'You're impossible.'

'And you're slow.'

The evening was spent at the police station, preparing Ayushi

I grabbed my keys and headed out. We had a case now. And tomorrow, for the first time, I would have to stand in court and defend someone whose life had already begun falling apart.

The rest of the evening was spent at the police station, going over everything with Ayushi and preparing her for court the next morning. She was nervous, and honestly, so was I. There was

only so much preparation we could do. The rest would have to be handled in the courtroom.

I wasn't sure If I were ready but I was going in anyway

CHAPTER

08

The next morning came too quickly. I barely slept. Whenever I'm disturbed, even small things irritate me. That night, everything irritated me. The fan. The clock. My phone. My own thoughts.

I checked my phone. There was no message, so I called Sarah. She answered after a few rings.

'Good morning.' Her voice sounded normal. Too normal. Where's the nervousness?

'You ready?' I asked

'Obviously.'

'You sound tired.' she did

'You sound annoying.' sarah replied. There she was. Unbothered as always.

'Where are you?'

'Hostel.'

'I'll pick you up.' I offered.

'I'm already leaving, booked a cab. '

'Fine. I'll meet you there.'

I got ready. For the first time in my life, I paid too much attention to what I was wearing. I wasn't wearing a suit. It was still early, and I wasn't trying to look like someone who had walked straight out of a television courtroom. But I did want to look like a lawyer.

I picked up the file. Ayushi Kapadia. Her name was printed on the cover. I stared at it for a few seconds. This was no longer something Sarah had dragged me into. She was my client now, and that changed everything.

I reached the court before Sarah. The building was already busy. Lawyers moved around carrying files, police officers spoke to each other, and families waited on benches. People argued about dates, documents and hearings. Nobody looked nervous. Or maybe everyone had simply become good at hiding it.

I saw Sarah walking towards me with her camera bag.

'Why do you have that?' I asked.

'I'm a reporter.'

'Today you're my assistant.'

She laughed.

'Don't get used to it.'

We entered together.

'You remember everything we discussed yesterday?' I asked.

'Yes.'

'And Ayushi?'

Sarah's expression changed slightly.

'She'll be fine.'

I nodded. I wanted to believe that.

We met Rohit near the courtroom. He had already arranged the necessary paperwork.

'Everything is ready,' he said.

I looked at the file.

'Thank you.'

Rohit smiled.

'First case?'

'First one alone.'

'You'll be fine.'

Everyone kept saying that. Nobody had any idea whether I would be.

We entered the courtroom. I had been here many times before, but this time felt different. Earlier, I had sat beside senior lawyers and watched them argue. I could observe, take notes and learn. Today, people would be watching me.

Ayushi was brought in. She looked smaller than she had the previous night. When she saw us, she gave a faint smile. Sarah immediately smiled back.

I walked towards her.

'Morning.'

She nodded.

'You okay?' I whispered.

'Yes.'

She wasn't. But I didn't ask again.

The proceedings began. I listened carefully as the prosecution presented the basic facts. Viraj Desai had died after suffering a blow to the head. Ayushi had admitted hitting him. She had been present at the scene and had run from the third floor to the kitchen. There were witnesses who had seen her immediately after the incident.

On paper, everything looked terrible. I understood why Vaishali had called her the primary suspect.

Then the judge looked towards me.

'Defence?'

I stood. For a second, my mind went blank. This was it. The same courtroom I had watched hundreds of times, except now everyone was waiting for me.

I took a breath.

'Your Honour, the accused has cooperated with the investigation and has not attempted to flee or conceal herself.'

My voice sounded steadier than I felt. I continued.

'She has admitted striking the deceased, but the circumstances surrounding that act are important. The defence submits that this was not a planned act.'

The prosecutor immediately objected to the direction of my argument. I expected it. The judge listened.

I didn't try to perform. I didn't try to become some legendary lawyer overnight. I simply stuck to what we had. Ayushi had not planned the killing. She had no weapon. There had been an argument. Viraj had entered the washroom. She had believed she was in danger, and she had struck him once.

That was our starting point. Not a victory. Just a starting point.

The judge asked a few questions. I answered what I could. For the questions I couldn't answer, I said so. That was probably the hardest part.

When you're young, you think confidence means having an answer to everything. Court teaches you otherwise.

The hearing continued. Sarah sat behind me, and I could feel her watching. Rohit was seating beside her. At one point, I looked back. She gave me a tiny nod. Nothing more, but it was enough.

Eventually, the judge fixed the next date and gave directions regarding the investigation and custody. It wasn't the dramatic courtroom victory I had imagined as a student. No one clapped. No one called me brilliant. Nobody walked up and offered me a film contract.

Then I heard a sound. Something heavy hitting the floor.

I turned.

Ayushi was no longer standing in the dock. She had collapsed.

'Ayushi!'

I jumped up.

She was lying on the wooden floor. For a moment, nobody moved. Then everyone moved at once. Vaishali rushed towards her. I reached her first. I knelt beside her and held her head carefully.

'Ayushi.' I tried to wake her up

Nothing.

Her eyes were closed.

'Ayushi!'

Still nothing.

There was a mark on her forehead where her head had hit the wooden edge.

Vaishali and the female constable came over immediately.

'Move back, Aditya.' Vaishali said, scolding.

I stepped aside.

The judge stood.

'Take her to the hospital. The hearing is over for today.'

The room slowly descended into chaos. Police officers surrounded Ayushi as people started talking around us. Someone from Viraj's side whispered something, but I didn't listen. I was only watching Ayushi being carried away.

The same girl who had once told me she was ready to go to jail was now unconscious on the courtroom floor. She had barely made it through the hearing. And suddenly, the courtroom didn't feel like a courtroom anymore. It felt like a place where people's lives were being pulled apart in front of everyone.

I looked around, trying to spot Sarah. Couldn't find her. I searched the room again. Nothing.

'Where is Sarah?' I asked the air.

My phone rang.

It was Rohit. Yeah, rohit was with Sarah. He knows where she is. I thought

I answered immediately. Almost dropping my phone.

'Where are you guys? Ayushi Just collapsed here'

There was a pause.

'Aditya, don't panic.'

That sentence has never made anyone less panicked.

'Where is Sarah? Give her the phone.'

'I think she's been taken to the police station.'

I froze.

'What? You think what?'

'Matre took her.'

'Why? And who the fuck is matre'

'I don't know why? And matre is matre' Rohit replied.

I looked towards the courtroom entrance. Ayushi was already gone. Sarah was gone too. And somehow, in the middle of my first case, I had gone from worrying about one client to worrying about both people who mattered most to me in this city.

CHAPTER

09

'Where exactly are you?' I asked Rohit, running down the stairs and skipping several steps at a time.

'In a rickshaw, going to the ST Stand police station. That's where they've taken her,' he clarified.

Rohit had become an angel that day.

'I'm coming,' I almost shouted, throwing my files into the boot of my scooter.

'Aditya, wait.'

'What?'

'You gotta go to Ayushi. I can take care of this'

I thought for a second

'I'll handle both.' I replied pressing the ignition button.

He sighed.

'Fine. Come.'

I got on my scooter. On the way, I kept wondering what Sarah could possibly have done. She was a reporter. A stubborn reporter. An extremely stubborn reporter. But she wasn't stupid. At least, not usually.

When I reached the police station, Rohit was waiting outside.

'What happened?'

'Matre took her inside.'

Of course. I already hated this Matre guy.

'Why?'

'He hasn't told me everything. He just said she entered a restricted crime scene.'

I stared at him.

'Sarah?'

'Yes.'

'She wouldn't.'

She definitely would.

Rohit gave me a look.

'You know her better than I do,' he said with a shrug.

We went inside. The place smelled exactly like every police station I had ever visited. Files, dust, sweat and something I couldn't identify but definitely didn't want to.

Matre was sitting behind his desk. The guy was in his late fifties. Ready to retire any moment. He looked up when he saw me. Then he smiled. I didn't like that smile.

'Vakeel saheb?' He knew me. Somehow.

'Where is Sarah?'

'Your friend is fine.'

'Can I meet her?'

'First, sit.' Matre pointed to the the chair before him. The smile seemed permanent.

I sat. Rohit remained standing behind me.

Matre leaned back in his chair.

'You know Ms. Sarah very well?'

'Yes.'

'How well?'

I looked at him. I was irritated.

'Well enough to know she isn't a criminal.' I answered, clenching my teeth.

His smile disappeared.

'Nobody said she is a criminal.' His voice was firm

'Then why is she here?'

Matre opened a file and slid it towards me

'Because she entered a crime scene illegally.' The smile was back. He smiled whenever he felt in control. So he smiled most of the time.

I waited.

He turned a few pages.

'Six months ago, I received a murder case.'

'Okay.'

'The investigation has been going on since then.'

'And?'

'Yesterday, we found something.'

He pulled out a photograph. Then another. Then another.

I looked at them.

They showed a building. An entrance. A corridor. And finally, Sarah.

I stared at the photograph.

'That's her.'

'I know.' My heart sunk.

'When was this taken?'

'Yesterday.'

I looked at him. Yesterday?

'Why was she there?'

'That's what I want to know.' Matre said, resting his hands on his overgrown Belly

I leaned back. For the first time, I didn't have an immediate answer. Sarah had a habit of going places she wasn't supposed to. That was part of being a crime reporter. But this was different.

Matre closed the file.

'The location was sealed. Nobody was permitted to enter.' he said. Was he happy about it? That smirking... Anyway!

'And you have proof she entered' I was just thinking out loud

He tapped the photographs.

'Hidden camera.' She said. Ohh that smile!

I rubbed my forehead. Of all the days, I thought.

'Did she damage anything?'

'We don't know.'

'Did she touch anything?'

'We don't know.'

'Then why are you assuming she tampered with anything?'

Matre stared at me. For quite a while. Finally he spoke.

'Because she entered a sealed crime scene without permission.'

That part was difficult to argue with. I hated that.

'Can I speak to her?'

He remained silent for a few seconds.

'Later.'

'Matre sir.'

'Don't worry. We're not charging her with murder.' he said, looking at the constable who stood beside him, expecting a laugh.

'That wasn't funny.' I was loosing it.

He smiled.

'It wasn't a joke.'

I didn't like him even more after that.

'What murder was this?'

He gave me the case details. A murder from six months ago. An investigation that had gone nowhere. No proper breakthrough. And now, Sarah had appeared inside the crime scene.

That was the part I couldn't understand. Why would she risk this?

Sarah was obsessed with her stories, yes. But she knew the difference between being aggressive and being reckless. Or at least I thought she did.

'Did she tell you why she was there?'

'No.'

'Let me talk to her.'

Matre though for an uncomfortably long moment finally nodded with a sigh.

A constable took me down the corridor.

Sarah was sitting on a bench. She looked up when she saw me. For a second, neither of us spoke.

Then she smiled. The audacity!

'You came.'

'Obviously.'

'How's Ayushi?'

'She's in hospital.'

Her face changed.

'What?' She stood up.

'She collapsed in the court.'

'how? Why? Is she okay?'

'She's stable.' I lied. I had no fucking Idea, how Ayushi was.

She exhaled.

I looked at her.

'Now you.'

She frowned.

'What about me?'

'Why the hell were you inside a sealed crime scene?'

Sarah looked away.

'It wasn't like that.'

'Then what was it like?'

She didn't answer.

I lowered my voice.

'Sarah, I need you to tell me everything.'

She looked at me. For the first time that day, she looked genuinely scared.

'I was following a lead.'

'What lead?'

'A murder.'

I almost laughed. SARCASTICALLY!

'You're going to have to be more specific. Apparently there are several murders in this city.'

She ignored the joke.

'I had information that something important had been missed at the scene.'

'What?'

'I can't tell you yet.'

'Sarah.'

'I said I can't.'

I stared at her. This was not the Sarah I knew. Or maybe it was exactly the Sarah I knew, and I had simply forgotten how far she would go for a story.

'You could lose your job.'

'I know.'

'You could be charged.'

'I know.'

'You could have asked me.'

She looked at me.

'Would you have allowed me to go?'

I didn't answer.

She smiled sadly.

'Exactly.'

That hurt more than I expected.

Matre appeared at the end of the corridor.

'Time.' of course, 'time'. 2 and a half minutes.

Sarah sat back down.

I turned towards him.

'when can she go?'

'Not yet.'

'On what basis?'

'We're still questioning her.'

I wanted to argue. But I knew enough not to start a courtroom inside a police station.

'I'll come back.'

Sarah nodded.

As I walked away, she called my name.

I turned.

'Don't tell anyone about this.'

I stared at her.

'You're asking me not to tell anyone that the police have you?'

'I'm asking you to trust me.'

There are moments when someone you care about asks you to trust them. You either give them that trust blindly, or you don't.

I had spent five years trusting Sarah.

So I nodded.

'Fine.'

I walked out with Rohit. Neither of us spoke for a while.

Then Rohit said, 'What's wrong with her?'

'I don't know.'

'Could she have tampered with the evidence? I mean, obviously, we don't want that.'

I stopped walking.

'No,' I said, firmly enough to convince myself.

'Then what?'

I looked back at the police station.

'I don't know.'

Somehow, Sarah keeping things from me bothered me more than the police arresting her.

CHAPTER

10

The next morning, I woke up with a heavy head. I had barely slept. Yesterday had been a disaster. Sarah had spent the night at the police station, Ayushi had collapsed in court, and somehow, I was still expected to behave like a functioning lawyer.

My doorbell rang at seven in the morning. Nobody comes to a bachelor's house that early unless something has gone horribly wrong.

I opened the door.

A man and a woman stood outside. The man looked to be in his fifties, and the woman seemed to be around the same age.

'Vakeel?' he said, or rather asked. His voice was strangely childish.

'Yes,' I answered, a little confused.

They looked at each other. The woman said something to him in Gujarati. I understood enough to know it was Gujarati. My uncle lived in Surat, and I had been there quite a few times.

The man looked back at me.

'Do you know my daughter, Ayushi?'

For a second, I couldn't process it. And then it clicked.

Of course. Ayushi had a father. Everyone has a father. This one had a name too, Murali Kapadiya.

'Ayushi?' I asked, just to be sure.

He nodded.

'Yes. Ayushi Kapadia.'

Oh.

The woman must be her mother.

I moved aside.

'Please come in.'

They removed their slippers and entered. I suddenly became aware of how terrible my house looked. Anyway, this was not the moment to be judged for housekeeping.

They sat on the couch. The woman looked exhausted, while the man, who I now knew was Ayushi's father, looked deeply uncomfortable.

'When will they release her?' the woman asked.

I sat opposite them.

'We're trying.'

It was the most honest answer I could give.

'We came as soon as we heard.'

Her voice broke.

'She is a good girl, Sahib. She cannot do something like this,' Ayushi's father said.

I didn't know what to say. I wasn't completely sure what had happened either. But looking at them, especially the way her mother was already breaking down, I couldn't bring myself to believe that Ayushi had simply decided to kill someone. Nothing about the girl I'd met at the police station had ever felt that calculated.

'I will do everything I can,' I said.

Her mother started crying.

'Can we see her?'

'She's in the hospital.'

They looked at each other.

'I will take you.' I assured them.

I stood up, but before we could leave, her mother looked at me.

'Can we have some water?'

I froze in shame. I had invited two distressed parents into my house and hadn't even offered them water. Great lawyer. Excellent host.

I went to the kitchen and returned with two glasses. The man gave me a small smile.

'Thank you, Sahib.'

I really needed him to stop calling me that. It made me feel forty-seven.

We left soon after. An auto-rickshaw was waiting outside. The driver stood beside it.

'My friend Ram,' Murali said

Ram greeted me with a respectful nod.

'Namaskar, Sahib.'

There it was again. Sahib! Whatever.

Later , I followed them to the hospital on my scooter.

At the hospital, I spoke to the constable outside Ayushi's room. He called Vaishali, who gave permission for her parents to enter.

Her mother went in first. Her father followed.

Ayushi was lying on the hospital bed, looking much smaller than she had at the police station. Her face was pale, and there were dark circles under her eyes. A thin blanket covered her, and an IV line ran into her hand. She looked exhausted, but the moment she saw her parents, she tried to sit up.

'Ma?'

Her mother rushed to her.

'Easy,' I said.

Her mother held her shoulders while her father stood beside the bed, completely silent. For a few seconds, nobody said anything.

Then he finally spoke.

'Why didn't you tell us?' His voice carried a mix of disappointment and concern.

Ayushi looked down.

'I was scared.'

'Scared of what?' her mother asked. Precisely my question by the way.

She didn't answer. Her mother sat beside her.

'We would have come.'

Ayushi wiped her tears.

'I know.'

'Then why?' Her mother persisted.

She looked at both of them.

'Because I already disappointed you once.'

Her father frowned.

'What are you talking about?' he said.

Ayushi looked at me. There was something in her eyes that made me feel she wanted me to understand what she couldn't bring herself to say.

I didn't. Not yet. And why me?

Her mother held her hand.

'Aishu, you are all we have.'

Ayushi started crying, and so did her mother.

I stayed quiet. Me crying would have made no sense.

After a few minutes, her father looked at me.

'Please save her.' He requested, folding his hands.

I nodded.

'I will.'

It was a simple promise, but I felt its weight.

I looked at Ayushi.

'You needed them, you should have called them'

She hesitated before nodding. And then as she spoke everything started to make sense.

Ayushi speaks.

My father drives an auto-rickshaw, and my mother is a homemaker. We live in Surat, although I moved to Pune six months ago.

Before I was born, my parents lived in the Azad Nagar slums in Surat. Baba worked in textile mills back then. Later, he started driving a cycle rickshaw, and after years of working, he borrowed money and bought an auto-rickshaw of his own. We have never owned a house. We have always lived in rented places. I think I've lived in twelve different houses since I was born.

My parents got married before the legal marriage age and had their first child soon after. My elder sister, Ronak.

I was born in 2000. Some people around us were disappointed when they found out my parents had another daughter. But Baba and Maa never cared whether their child was a boy or a girl. For them, a child was a child. People still tell me that when I was born, Baba threw a feast for the neighbours. He

was apparently so happy about having another daughter that he wanted everyone around him to celebrate too.

That was my father.

He had no idea what his own parents looked like. He had never even seen them. He grew up in a dharmshala and started working when he was only seven. He grew up with almost nothing. The people around him in the slum became his family. They helped him whenever they could, looked after him, and eventually even arranged his marriage.

When it came to his own children, Baba had only two priorities: our education and our well-being. He never went to school. Not even for a day. But he understood the value of education better than most educated people I knew. He knew what he had missed out on, and he didn't want the same thing for us. He wanted his daughters to have the best education he could provide.

He worked eighteen hours a day when I was growing up. Even now, he works more than twelve hours. I remember seeing him wear the same few shirts again and again while spending almost nothing on himself. Whatever money he earned was for us. Looking back, it feels like Baba stopped living for himself a long time ago. He just kept working for us.

God was kind to him in one way, though. In my twenty-two years of life, I don't remember him ever being seriously ill or taking regular medication. He hardly ever went to a hospital. Somehow, he always had the health to keep working.

My mother's name is Kamala, although everyone calls her Kamal. She was fifteen when she got married. Her parents were hesitant about giving their only daughter to an orphan, but they trusted Baba because of his kindness and innocence.

Baba had no family of his own, so Maa had to handle everything after marriage. Life in the slum wasn't easy. She

started working in textile factories along with other women from the area. Maa never had any formal education either, but she was extremely intelligent when it came to everyday life.

At the factory, she did almost everything. Cutting, buttoning, ironing, packaging. She learnt quickly and became very good at her work. Women were paid terribly little, even when they worked harder than the men. Factories could hire and fire them whenever they wanted, so there was hardly any job security.

But Maa never got fired. She was that good. She was equal to two women or three men.

And then there was Ronak.

Ronak means radiance. Her name couldn't have suited her better. She had beautiful, glowing skin and bright blue eyes. She was calm and spoke only when necessary.

Unlike me.

Ronak was the centre of our family. She was the perfect one surrounded by imperfections like me. Sometimes I used to get jealous of her because she was good at everything.

Once, one of her teachers called Baba to school just to praise her. I still remember him coming home and telling us about it.

'I couldn't go to work today because Rona's teacher wanted to meet me. No way, how could there be a problem with Rona? The teacher wanted to tell me about her academic performance. She scores well in all her exams, and she is also the head girl at her school. All the teachers were complimenting her for her good behaviour and marks.'

He was so proud of her.

Ronak was good at everything, especially school. I was the complete opposite. I was a spoilt child who created chaos wherever I went. I went to school mostly for the storybooks. I loved reading, but textbooks were a different story.

Maa and Baba gave both of us whatever they could. They loved us equally, even though, honestly, I was dust compared to Ronak's greatness.

In 2013, Ronak completed her tenth grade and topped her school. She was the district topper in general science and scored a hundred out of a hundred. My parents were amazed. They distributed sweets throughout the neighbourhood, and I made sure I contributed to reducing the quantity.

Everyone congratulated Ronak. Even a local minister promised financial help for her higher education.

On camera, of course.

Meanwhile, I was barely passing my classes. But I did have one thing going for me.

English. Weird, I know.

Good English is considered a sign of intelligence in India. Just say something in English and people will think you're clever. I realised that pretty quickly, so I started working on it.

Speaking English soon became my thing at school. My English wasn't exactly brilliant, but even our English teacher used to say things like, 'I didn't knew.'

So, considering the competition, I was amazing at English.

I became the person who gave speeches in English at school functions. Of course, I memorised every single one of them, but at that age, even pronouncing the words correctly felt like an achievement.

Maa and Baba never forced me to do well academically. I don't know whether marks simply didn't matter to them or whether they had accepted that I wasn't going to become another Ronak. Baba would buy me whatever books I wanted, and I would finish them like sweets.

Ronak, on the other hand, worried about my future. She genuinely doubted whether I would even clear tenth grade. She was much more sensible than me. But I was younger.

The law of nature dictates that older siblings are more mature. Isn't that true?

Every Sunday, Baba would take us out in our own cycle rickshaw. He had plenty of passengers in the mornings, so the evenings were for us. Surat was beautiful. We would eat aloo-puri near the Mahadev temple. It felt like a completely different world. Everything seemed peaceful.

I had everything. Baba found happiness in our happiness. Maa had sacrificed so much for us. Ronak always looked after me. I wished those days would never end.

The king, queen and their two princesses.

It felt like a fairy tale. And now, when I look back, it feels even more beautiful.

After completing tenth grade, Ronak spent her holidays researching what she wanted to do with her career. She spoke to her teachers and read career-guidance books. She had always wanted to become a doctor, and after all that research, she decided that was what she wanted to pursue.

My parents were overjoyed.

I, on the other hand, was just happy that she had stopped studying for a few minutes.

It was a Saturday. I was at home with Maa. Baba had gone out, and Ronak had gone to watch a movie. It was the first time she had ever gone to a theatre. She wasn't interested in hanging out with friends or watching movies. Travelling didn't interest her either. She had left Surat only once before that, for a chess tournament in Gandhinagar.

I have blurry memories of what happened next. Around one in the afternoon, a girl came running to our house. Her expression told us that something was wrong. Maa was standing near the front door. I couldn't see the girl's face at first.

It was Shivani, Ronak's friend. She had insisted that Ronak join them for the movie.

I had a book in my hand and didn't want to put it down. Shivani said something quickly. Then she and Maa ran. Maa didn't even put on her chappals. I threw the book aside and followed them.

Five minutes later, we were at the hospital.

The hospital staff were rushing someone on a stretcher. A nurse stopped Maa from going any further. I couldn't see the person's face, but I recognised the ankle chains.

It was Ronak.

Three girls were standing nearby. Shivani told us that a bike had been speeding outside the theatre and had hit Ronak. The hospital was nearby, so they had brought her there quickly.

But it wasn't enough.

Maa was distraught. She had lost awareness of her surroundings. Her hands were shaking. She wasn't crying. She was horrified.

Ronak died that day.

The doctors came out ten minutes later and told us they couldn't save her. There was silence. Maa couldn't understand what had happened. Her entire life had been destroyed in ten minutes.

I walked towards her. She saw me and broke down. She hugged me and let out a loud cry.

It took a long time for the news to reach Baba because he didn't have a mobile phone then. He came running to the

hospital after someone told him only that there had been an accident.

Maa couldn't speak when she saw him. She just yelled and cried.

That was enough for him.

Baba fell to his knees and cried like an innocent child. His friends tried to console him, but nothing helped. He moved towards Maa and me on his knees, and both my parents held me.

The people around us let us cry. And that's when it really hit me. There was no Ronak anymore. The sweetest era of our lives had ended.

Maa stayed in the hospital for a month after Ronak's funeral. She stopped eating. Baba spent most of his time crying in the lobby, while I tried to console him. It took us two months to return to our routine. One day, Baba cleaned his cycle rickshaw and went back to work. I went back to school.

Everything Ronak owned was preserved. Her geometry box, her blue-eyed doll and her collection of hair clips. We never forgot Ronak. Time healed some of the pain, though.

Things were never going to be perfect again, but we had to look for the good things that were still left. Ronak would have wanted that.

As for me, I continued being terrible at school. I did badly in my tenth and twelfth grades. People mocked my marks because they reminded them of Ronak. Some of them may even have wished I had died instead of her. I often wished the same. If God ever offered me that exchange, I'd be ready.

Eventually, I decided to pursue a bachelor's degree in English literature. During my second year, I started working as a temporary teacher at a small English coaching centre. My communication skills helped. I enjoyed teaching. I got to teach people of different ages, and I liked that. I earned seven thousand

rupees a month for five hours of work every day. It wasn't much, but I was contributing to my family.

After Ronak, my parents loved me even more. They supported me despite my bad results. They celebrated even my small achievements, including that job. I was lucky to have parents like them. But I still felt that I wasn't doing enough for them.

I kept comparing myself to Ronak. I knew it made no sense. But I couldn't stop. I believed I would never be able to do for my parents what Ronak could have done. She would have gone to the best medical college. She would have excelled there. She would have ended my parents' struggles.

It wasn't my cup of tea to repay them. But giving up was never an option.

After my third-year final exams, I started looking for better jobs. In the third decade of the twenty-first century, seven thousand rupees is nothing. I was ready to work harder.

That's when I found an advertisement for Hotel Blue Rose online. They were conducting interviews online. They needed someone who could speak English, had an innocent face, and was willing to work extra hours.

I got selected.

They offered me twenty thousand rupees a month, excluding food and accommodation. I had to take the job.

I told my parents. Maa was okay with it. Baba wasn't. He didn't want me to leave. He gave me a hundred reasons not to go to Pune, but I had already made up my mind.

It took me two days to convince him. Eventually, Baba booked my train ticket. We said goodbye with tears in our eyes.

I was going to Pune to make them proud.

CHAPTER

11

Ayushi stopped speaking. I noticed tears in all three pairs of eyes. I couldn't think of anything to say, so I decided to remain silent. I had just heard a heartbreaking story, and the characters were seated right in front of me. I hadn't seen Ronak, yet somehow I was missing her.

'Aishu is all we have now,' Ayushi's mother said calmly, looking at her daughter.

My body felt a surge of rage for the bikers. Those assholes had harmed an innocent girl and destroyed a happy family. If everything had fallen into place, Ronak would now have been a doctor. She would have paid back everything her parents had done for her. More than anything else, she would have lived a life. I wanted to ask them what happened to the boys later. What punishment did they get? But I stopped myself. What's the point? No one could give them their child back.

'I let them down by doing this, and that's why I didn't want them to know anything,' Ayushi said.

'But that's not how you were going to face things,' I said.

Ayushi lowered her head, accepting her mistake.

'He and his friend helped me a lot,' she said to her parents, mentioning me.

Her parents looked at me. I didn't know what to do with their gratitude. I hadn't done enough to deserve it.

'Where is Sarah?' Ayushi asked.

My heart sank.

'She is home,' I lied.

How could I tell her that Sarah was at the police station? Sarah in jail. Fuck. I hated that thought.

I got up.

'Please do the best you can,' Ayushi's mother said in a requesting tone.

'We will,' I assured her, forcing all my face muscles to smile.

Things seemed to be settling down between the family members, and I desperately needed to leave.

'I will leave now. Don't worry about the constable. You can stay here as long as you want,' I assured Murali and left the place.

Ayushi had sensed something wrong in my behaviour. I could tell from the way she looked at me. I came out of the hospital.

Why do all hospitals have that disgusting smell? I hate it.

I sat on a bench outside and thought about my life. Shit. I got up and sat down three times. Then I found a tea stall and fuelled myself. I couldn't wait to see Sarah.

The good thing was that Matre hadn't filed an FIR against her yet. Whatever was going on was informal. If you go legally, it was illegal for him to put her behind bars without any documentation. But what Sarah had done wasn't very legal either.

I decided to explain things to Matre once more. That was my only option. I needed Sarah out at any cost. I made up my mind and decided to go home to change before going to the police station. How you look really matters while persuading someone.

I flew my scooter towards my house and reached there quickly. From a distance, I saw someone trying to jump in from the main gate of my house. I accelerated the scooter for those last hundred metres. I prayed to God to make my thoughts a reality.

And it happened.

I couldn't believe my eyes.

Sarah?

How is she here?

Was it a hallucination?

No, it wasn't. And why was she trying to jump the gate? Had she gone mad?

'Where is your phone?' she asked while moving towards me as I stopped and got down from my scooter.

'What?'

I couldn't comprehend the situation.

'Where the hell is your phone?' she shouted and slapped my arm.

Why was she beating me? That too outside in the open. But I understood her words. Where was my phone?

My hand went towards my pocket. Nothing in the right pocket, where it was supposed to be. Neither in the left pocket. Where did it go? Did I forget it in Ayushi's room? I mean, the room where Ayushi was admitted.

Shit.

I had left it inside my bedroom. I didn't pick it up when I was leaving my house, and I hadn't even noticed it in the last one hour.

'I am calling you for the last one hour. You are not even at home. It's eight in the morning, and I have been sitting in the

police station for the whole night. I haven't eaten an atom of food in the last sixteen hours, and you are not picking up my calls. You know what? The first thing I did after leaving the police station was call you. Then I came straight from the police station to your house, and you are not here too? How the...'

Before she could speak further, I held both her hands.

'Calm down. Relax,' I said.

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath. Her entire body moved with her breathing. With her eyes closed, she appeared exhausted. Her messy hair made me forget about everything bad for a moment. I was simply overjoyed. I wished the time would stop there.

She blinked her eyes open. I didn't know how she had got out of the police station. But even if she had done it illegally, I didn't mind at that moment.

'Did you listen? I am hungry,' Sarah said.

'I am happy,' I replied.

We immediately went to a small hotel near my house.

Sarah ate four bhaturas with some spicy chhole there. I was extremely happy to see her eating. She didn't even say anything. Her entire attention was focused on the food.

'Tell me now. What exactly happened? Why did they let you go?' I inquired.

'What do you mean?' Sarah asked.

'I mean, how did they let you go?' I corrected myself.

'They must have watched that ridiculous video a hundred times. Then they called my boss to know more about me. Everyone in the office must be knowing about it now. Later, Matre questioned me extensively until his wife called him home. He wouldn't let me go, even though he was convinced I was just a crazy reporter. Instead, he attempted to enlighten me. He told

me that things might go wrong if I don't change my stubborn attitude towards reporting. He eventually returned my phone to me and let me go. They are bad people, by the way. They didn't even ask for a cup of tea.'

'So, you weren't locked up?' I questioned. I had spent the entire night imagining the image.

'Nooo, I would have blown up the police station,' she replied.

'Shut up. When they arrested you, you sank like a tortoise. Not even a word could come out of your mouth,' I teased her.

'I was just shocked. I don't get arrested on a weekly basis,' Sarah stated, clearly denying that she was scared.

I smiled as I dug my teeth into a tea-dipped cookie.

'What Matre told you was right. You should be careful,' I stated solemnly.

'Bullshit. I'll cross international borders for my work,' she said, sounding like a D-rated movie hero.

'They shouldn't have let you go,' I said, shaking my head.

'I knew you were happier with me being at the police station,' she said.

I burst out laughing. She joined me, and we only stopped when people around us began to look at us with disgust. She finished the food on her plate and asked for a mango cold drink.

'You'll get cold. Air is already icy outside,' I warned.

'You act as if you genuinely care about me.'

'Of course I care. You are my responsibility now.'

'Who made me your responsibility?'

'You did. You entered my life without permission.'

She kicked my leg under the table.

'Shut up.'

I laughed. For the first time since morning, things felt a little normal.

After finishing her drink, Sarah got up.

'Let's go.'

'Where?'

'Your place. I need a bath.'

I paid the bill and followed her outside.

Back at my house, Sarah went straight to the bathroom while I sat on the couch. It had been a strange morning. A few hours ago, I was sitting in a hospital worrying about Ayushi while imagining Sarah stuck in a police station. Now Sarah was back. Somehow, that alone made everything feel lighter.

Sarah came out after her bath and sat on her favourite spot on the couch. It had been almost an hour since our brunch, but she still hadn't asked about Ayushi. Finally, she looked at me.

'How about Ayushi? How's she? '

For the next fifteen minutes I updated her on every detail she had missed in the last twenty-four hours. She was relieved to learn about Ayushi's parents.

'I thought she had no family,' she said.

'Same here.'

Sarah sat quietly for a moment.

'So, you just came from the hospital?'

'Yes.'

She looked at me.

'You couldn't get through the day without me.'

'That's true,' I said.

I really couldn't survive without her.

Sarah stood up.

'Let's go to the hospital.'

'We'll go in the evening. You sleep for now. She's with her parents. Don't worry about her.'

'No. Just take me to my hostel. need to pick a few things up'

By the time we were done, the morning had almost disappeared. But at least one thing was clear. Sarah was free. And now, instead of trying to get her out of a police station, I had to take her back to the hospital.

We got on the scooter and started towards Ayushi.

CHAPTER

12

'Aren't we supposed to go to your place or mine now?' Sarah asked as I changed the direction of the scooter.

'No home yet.'

'Are you kidnapping me?'

'Who will kidnap you, and why? You're going to ruin his kidnapping career.'

She punched me in the back. She did that a lot. At some point, I was seriously considering suing her for beating me up all the time.

'Shut up. Where are we going?'

'We're going to Sinha's place.'

'Sinha?' Her voice changed immediately. 'You should have told me sooner. I'm not mentally prepared for this.'

What kind of mental preparation was required to meet a lawyer? You can be blunt around us, that's actually the best thing.

'He called me a few hours ago. He just returned from Delhi and is leaving Pune tomorrow morning. His advice is important, so we have to meet him tonight.'

She was silent for a few seconds.

'All right. I'm ready.'

We continued riding.

We reached Sinha's house around nine. Calling it a house would have been an insult to the house. It was a mansion, palace,

bungalow, whatever rich people called their homes. We could see it from a distance because of the lighting. Sinha must have been paying a lakh a month just for electricity. Our scooter standing in front of that villa looked like a chicken standing in front of an ancient mammoth. The moral of the story is that Sinha was super rich.

Sarah stared at the house as if she had discovered an alien object.

'Have you been here before?' she asked.

'No. First time.'

'All right. Let's feel poor together.'

We giggled.

I parked the scooter near the gate and we walked inside. Our clothes did not match the prosperity of the place. Even the security guard looked better dressed than us.

'Mr. Aditya?' he asked.

'Yes.'

He recognised me. That was probably the proudest moment of my life.

'You're welcome to bring the scooter inside, sir.'

I handed the keys to Sarah. I was special at the time, and parking the scooter myself would have been an insult to my superiority. She accepted this fact and took the keys.

Sinha had created an entirely different world inside those walls. A perfectly maintained lawn covered most of the front yard, with a fountain sitting in the middle.

Sarah looked around.

'Press the doorbell,' I told her.

She gave me a look that immediately made me realise that I had overestimated my importance. So I decided to ring it myself.

Mrs. Sinha opened the door. She recognised me immediately and smiled.

'Hey, welcome!'

'Thank you very much, aunty,' Sarah said, giving her a side hug.

God. Her aunty thing.

Mrs. Sinha didn't look like an aunty at all. She looked like someone who had accidentally walked out of a Bollywood movie from the nineties.

'Thank you, ma'am,' I said.

My smile has different levels. That was probably my biggest one.

'Who is the pretty lady?' Mrs. Sinha asked.

'I am Sarah, a friend of this pretty boy.'

They both laughed.

I faked a smile. Pretty boy? You can't make jokes about me to make other people laugh, Sarah. Nice one, though.

Mrs. Sinha invited us inside and told us to make ourselves comfortable. She went into the kitchen.

Sarah and I sat on the sofa. The moment she disappeared, I picked up a cushion.

'Why do you want to embarrass me in front of her?'

Within seconds, we were behaving like two children who had somehow been allowed into a rich person's house without supervision. We stopped when Mrs. Sinha returned. She looked at us. We looked at her. Nothing happened. Perfect acting.

'Sarah, what do you do?' she asked.

'I work as a crime reporter for Prime News Network.'

'Brave girl.'

Sarah smiled. She genuinely liked being understood.

A few minutes later, the doorbell rang.

Sinha had arrived.

He walked in wearing formal clothes, carrying a black leather bag. He handed his coat and bag to his wife. Sinha was always energetic. I had seen him spend an entire day in court, come back home, work on files until late at night, and still show up at the office early the next morning like he had slept for eight hours. That wasn't energy. That was supernatural activity.

'How are you doing, soldier?' he asked.

I never understood why he called me soldier. Maybe it was because of my short hair.

'Not the best,' I replied.

He looked at me for a second.

'Why do you look so worried, Adi? Relax. Put the case aside. Learn to separate your personal and professional lives.'

'Sure, sir.'

Sarah stood beside me with a fixed smile. I enjoyed seeing her so reserved. Usually, she behaves like a self proclaimed empress.

'Is that Sarah?' Sinha asked.

'Yes, sir.'

'Oh, my goodness. I finally get to see you. I can't tell you how many times I've heard your name.'

Sarah looked at me. I had mentioned her to him many times. Apparently, too many.

'Where are you coming from, sir?' I asked before Sarah had to respond.

'I had some paperwork to finish in Delhi and here. Anyway, give me five minutes to change.'

He disappeared upstairs.

Sarah looked at me.

'Why didn't you tell me we're here for dinner? I thought this was going to be a tenminute talk with your ex-boss.'

'Free food, Sarah. We will get free food. What else do you need?'

She gave me an annoyed look.

I took her hand and made her sit back down. Her mood changed almost immediately. How did that happen? Without even apologising.

A few minutes later, Mrs. Sinha called us to dinner.

The dining table was enormous. There were enough dishes on it to feed an entire cricket team. Matar paneer, rice, rotis, dessert. We hadn't eaten properly in days, so for the first few minutes, nobody spoke. We just ate.

Sinha eventually looked at me.

'So, what is the current situation?'

I put my spoon down.

Finally.

Work.

I told him everything. The court hearing, Ayushi's condition, the next hearing, her statement, the self-defence angle, the problem with the prosecution's version, and the fact that nobody had actually seen Ayushi hit Viraj.

I expected him to immediately give me some brilliant legal solution.

Instead, he listened.

Then he picked up a gulab jamun.

'You had an opportunity,' he said. 'Vohra is a piece of cake.'

Vohra was the judge who had heard the case.

I looked at him. Sarah looked at me. I couldn't tell if Sinha was joking or if this was just how experienced lawyers talked about things that scared the shit out of younger lawyers.

'What else do you recommend, sir?' Sarah asked.

Sinha put down his spoon. His expression changed. The childish Sinha disappeared. The great advocate Sinha arrived.

'I see two possibilities.'

That made me happy. He saw two possibilities. I had gone blind trying to see even one.

'The first thing you can do is talk to the victim's side.'

I frowned.

'They've lost someone,' Sinha continued. 'From their perspective, a young man is dead and a waitress admitted hitting him. You can argue lack of intention all you want, but that doesn't change the fact that someone died.'

I nodded.

'If they believe Ayushi didn't intend to kill him, you may have some room. Try to make them understand that what happened may have been a terrible mistake rather than a planned act.'

'That sounds almost impossible,' I said.

'It probably is.'

I stared at him.

'Then why did you suggest it?'

'Because difficult doesn't mean useless.'

Sarah looked thoughtful.

'But we should try, Adi.' She spoke.

I looked at her. She was serious. Of course she was.

Sinha smiled.

'I've done it before. It won't always work. But sometimes people need to hear the other side before they decide what they want.'

I leaned back. There was something about the way he said it that made me uncomfortable. Not because the idea was bad. Because I realised I hadn't been performing up to the mark.

Sinha picked up his glass.

'And there is another problem.'

'What?'

He looked directly at me.

'You're concentrating too much on whether she intended to kill him.'

Sarah stopped eating.

I did too.

'What else should I be concentrating on?'

Sinha leaned back.

'Why did Viraj die?'

The room went quiet. It was such a simple question. And somehow, I hadn't asked it properly.

We knew Ayushi hit him. We knew he fell. We knew he was taken to the hospital. We knew he died. But between those four facts was a gap. A big one.

I looked at Sarah. She was already looking at me. Neither of us said anything.

Sinha continued.

'Don't build your entire defence around what Ayushi says happened. Build it around what you can prove happened.'

'What if the police version is incomplete?' Sarah decided to shoot, what she had been thinking since day one.

'Then find out where it is incomplete.' Sinha said, impressed l.

'And if Ayushi's version is incomplete?' My doubt

Sinha looked at me.

'Then find that out too.' He answered. This time in a stronger voice.

I swallowed. For the first time since taking the case, I wasn't thinking about how to save Ayushi from a murder charge. I was thinking about the murder itself.

I looked down at my plate. The food suddenly didn't seem as important. Sinha had given us advice, but he hadn't given us an answer. Maybe that was the point. A good lawyer doesn't always tell you what to think. Sometimes he tells you what question you should have been asking.

After dinner, we moved upstairs. Sinha's house was even more ridiculous from the inside. Glass walls, a terrace garden, perfectly maintained grass and enough space to make my entire rented house look like a storage room.

Sarah looked around.

'Everything is fantastic.'

'She is quite creative,' Sinha said, looking at his wife. Mrs. Sinha smiled.

I looked at my phone.

Ten o'clock.

It was late.

'We should leave,' I said.

Sinha looked disappointed.

'What's the rush?'

'You're leaving Pune tomorrow. We've already taken enough of your time.'

He patted my shoulder.

'Don't be so formal. I'm here whenever you need me.'

I had to admit it. I liked the man.

Who else had an ex-boss like that?

Soon, we walked outside.

Sarah put on her helmet and took the scooter out.

I was about to sit behind her when Mrs. Sinha smiled.

'When are you two going to get married?'

We froze.

'I mean separately,' she added.

The Sinha couple burst out laughing.

Sarah started the scooter.

'Good night, uncle and aunty.'

We were about to leave when Sinha stopped me.

'Adi.'

I turned around.

'Don't stress too much about the case. It's your first one. Enjoy it. Ten years from now, you'll have a pile of cases behind you and you'll still be partying somewhere abroad.'

I smiled and imagined myself partying abroad immediately.

'Thank you, sir.' I said.

Sarah accelerated.

The cold air hit my face as we disappeared into the fog. Sinha's words stayed with me. This wasn't just about defending Ayushi anymore. If I wanted to save her, I had to understand

what happened to Viraj. And that meant finding the truth. Whatever it was.

CHAPTER

12

I woke up at six the next morning. For a few seconds, everything felt like a dream. The previous day had been too crowded. The hospital, Ayushi, Sarah, dinner at Sinha's house. My brain had mixed everything together, and I couldn't tell what had actually happened and what I'd only dreamed. Such things keep happening to me.

I hadn't taken a bath in almost forty-eight hours, so I decided that was probably more important than solving a murder.

I switched on the geyser and went to the kitchen, only to discover that my gas cylinder had run out.

Perfect.

I called the gas company and demanded a new cylinder. After a long shower, I felt human again.

Then I realised I was starving. The gas was gone, the electric stove was gone, and my cooking career was officially over.

I ate an apple.

That was breakfast.

I sat on the couch and turned on the television. News channels were doing what they always do. Actors, politicians, thefts, murders, and people shouting at each other. I watched for a few minutes, mostly to criticise them.

My phone rang.

'Hello?'

'I just got a call from Vaishali,' Sarah said.

'What happened?'

'She told me not to keep visiting the hospital so often. It might create problems for her.'

'She's right.'

There was silence for a second.

'We should inform Ayushi's parents,' she said. 'Did you take their number?'

'Yes. I'll send it to you.'

'Why me?'

'How would I?' I counter-questioned.

'Grow some balls, Adi.' She laughed.

'Shut up.'

'Send me the number.'

I did.

She hung up, then called again.

'Hello, Mr Lawyer. At the very least, ask me if I've eaten anything.'

I stared at the phone.

'What?'

'You ill-mannered fool. You never ask.'

'Ms Sarah, what did you eat?'

'No, I haven't eaten anything. I'm hungry, and they made poha at the hostel. I want something fried. I'm coming to your place in fifteen minutes. You have the honour of cooking for me.'

'My cylinder just ran out. I'm hungry too. Let's go out to eat.'

'I'm coming.'

She hung up.

My brain was occupied with two things.

The first was Mrs Batra. She was the person who had hosted the party and filed the complaint. She also seemed to sit at the centre of everything that had happened at Blue Rose. Ayushi had described her as calm and collected. I doubted she'd simply listen to two strangers asking her to reconsider a murder case. Still, there was no harm in trying.

The second thing was something Sinha had said.

Why did Viraj die?

Until then, I'd been thinking like a lawyer. Ayushi admitted hitting him. She said she was frightened and hadn't intended to kill him. So I'd built the defence around that.

But Sinha had forced me to look at the bigger picture.

I didn't know enough about what had happened that night. There were too many gaps in the story, too many questions without answers. And until I understood what had actually happened, I couldn't build a proper defence.

That was a problem.

A very big one.

Ayushi was my client. I had to defend her. But before I could do that properly, I needed facts. Not guesses. Not sympathy. Facts.

Sarah arrived soon after, and we went out for breakfast.

We ended up at a small place called Dish Delicious. I immediately noticed that delicious was misspelled on the signboard. I didn't say anything. Why would I?

Sarah ordered samosa chaat for both of us. For the first few minutes, we ate in silence. We were similar in that way. Give us food, and most conversations could wait.

'So,' Sarah said, putting down her spoon, 'what do you think about talking to Viraj's friends?'

I looked at her.

‘I was thinking the same thing.’

‘I know.’

‘Of course you do.’

She smiled.

‘But who exactly?’

‘That is the problem.’

‘And whether they'll even talk to us.’

‘Exactly.’

She held out her hand.

‘Give me your phone.’

‘Why?’

‘Give it.’

I handed it to her. She unlocked it using her fingerprint.

I stared at her.

‘How do you still have your fingerprint on my phone?’

‘Because you never removed it.’

‘That's a security issue.’

‘You're welcome.’

She started scrolling.

‘What are you doing?’

‘Have you updated your Instagram password?’

‘Yes.’

‘Tell me.’

‘No.’

She looked at me.

‘Tell me.’

I sighed.

‘Iamthebest. All lowercase.’

She burst out laughing.

'What's wrong with you?'

'I knew you were going to laugh.'

She typed it in, and a profile appeared on the screen.

Dr Divya Batra.

Psychiatrist.

Mental health services.

De-addiction.

Anxiety.

Anger and stress management.

Bipolar disorder.

OCD.

I looked at the photograph. I recognised her immediately. It was the same woman who had hosted the party.

'Where did you get this?'

'I was looking for her last night.'

'You've been stalking people?'

'Research.'

'Same thing.'

She ignored me.

'How many followers?'

'Three thousand something.'

'How many does she follow?'

'Thirty-eight.'

I looked at Sarah.

'And what does this tell us?'

'Nothing.'

She took another bite of samosa.

I smiled.

'Excellent investigation.'

'I'm not finished.'

She opened another section of the profile. There were photographs from conferences, mental health awareness programmes, and private events. Nothing suspicious. Nothing useful.

But there was something else.

'Look at this.'

She showed me a photograph from the Blue Rose party. Viraj was standing in the background, Divya beside him, and another man on the other side. There were lots of photographs and lots of people, but one thing was common. Divya was with Viraj in every single one of them. They were clearly close.

My first question was obvious.

'She uploaded these pictures after the bloody murder?'

'She posted them during the party itself, probably before things went south,' Sarah replied.

I looked at the photographs again, for quite a while this time.

I opened my notes and wrote:

VIRAJ DESAI

Underneath it, I started another list.

- People at the party.
- Viraj's friends.
- Divya Batra.
- Timeline of the bathroom incident.
- Cause of death.

Sarah looked at the screen.

'Add Ayushi's version and the police version separately.'

I did.

Two columns.

AYUSHI

POLICE

Sarah leaned closer.

'See?'

'What?' I asked, raising my eyebrows.

'We're finally doing this properly.'

I looked at the list. She was right. Until that morning, I'd been trying to save Ayushi. Now we were going to find out what had happened. Half detectives, I'd say.

I closed the notes.

'First, we talk to Viraj's friends. Especially Divya.'

Sarah nodded.

I didn't know it yet, but that name was going to take us much deeper into the case than either of us expected. For now, though, we had a plan. And for the first time since Hotel Blue Rose, I felt like we weren't simply reacting to what had happened. We were going after it.

Sarah left for her office later that morning. I spent most of the day sleeping and stalking the other people who had been at the hotel that night. Or, as Sarah would have called it, researching.

CHAPTER

13

The next day, Sarah and I were sitting at the same breakfast place. I'd barely finished my tea when she opened her laptop.

'So,' she said, 'where do we start?'

'With Viraj.'

'Very intelligent, Mr Lawyer.'

'Thank you.'

'I was being sarcastic.'

'I know. I still accept the compliment.'

She rolled her eyes.

I opened my notes. We had a list now. Viraj's friends, his business, his family, the people at the Blue Rose party, Divya, and the events of that night.

'We need to talk to someone who actually knew him,' Sarah said.

'His friends?'

'Try being specific.' She gave me a look and turned back to the screen.

She opened Instagram again. Viraj's profile. I'd already gone through it. Private account. I wished we could get into it.

After another twenty minutes, we had several names. Most of them were useless.

Business contacts, old school friends, people who had tagged Viraj in photographs. It's weird how much the internet

can find out about you, especially if you're rich or famous. Or rich and famous.

One name kept appearing more than the others.

Krishna.

From the hundreds of posts we'd gone through, we gathered that he lived in a village. And guess what? Viraj apparently owned a house in the same village. One of his friends had posted something about it. There were photographs. Expensive-ass photographs. All this people were fucking showoff kinds.

'Why does a man like Viraj have a house in a village?' I asked.

'Maybe he liked peace.'

'So he bought peace?'

'Apparently.'

I looked at the photographs for a while.

'What exactly did he do?' Sarah asked.

'Land business. That's what Vaishali told us,' I answered.

'And?'

'And that's not enough?'

She rolled her eyes.

Eventually, we decided to call some of his known contacts.

The first person didn't answer. The second said he hadn't spoken to Viraj in months. The third immediately asked why we wanted to know. Sarah ended that call before I could get a word in.

'Three down,' I said.

'Wonderful.'

'There's one more.'

She dialled. It rang for a while before a man answered. He had a really deep voice, the kind of voice you'd expect from Amitabh Bachchan.

Sarah introduced herself as a reporter, completely changing her tone. She didn't talk like that. Well, nobody did.

His voice changed immediately.

'I don't want to talk about it.'

The call ended.

Sarah looked at me. I looked at her.

'That was interesting.'

'Definitely more interesting than the other three. Maybe he doesn't like reporters. Neither do I, by the way.'

Sarah slapped my arm.

Our investigation was going wonderfully. We had one possible friend, several people who didn't want to talk, and absolutely no idea what we were doing.

'What about the Krishna guy?' Sarah asked.

'Couldn't find a contact,' I replied.

'Apparently, he lives next door to Viraj's village house.'

'Well, apparently.'

I sat back.

That was something, though.

Not much.

But something.

We needed to get to this man.

Sarah looked at the screen.

'What if we get nothing from him?'

'Then we'll find someone who gives us something,' I said, very optimistically.

She smiled.

Then she looked back at Viraj's photograph on the screen.

We knew Viraj was rich. We knew he owned property. We knew he hosted parties. We knew he drank. We knew he'd been inside that bathroom. But none of that told us who he was when nobody was watching.

We hoped someone would.

Sarah closed her laptop.

'I need to make another call.'

'To whom?'

She smiled.

'Someone who knows how to find people. A she-wolf, I'd say.'

I didn't ask. With Sarah, sometimes it was better to wait.

CHAPTER

14

'Hello, queen,' a sweet, girly voice said behind me. I turned around to see a girl standing there in a red dress that ended at her knees. She had thin, golden-framed glasses that looked more like a fashion accessory than something she actually needed. Her hair was just the right length for her face, and she looked younger than she probably was. She was fair, about five feet five, and had a lean frame. The only thing I didn't like was her lipstick. There was too much of it. I wanted to tell her she didn't need that much, but considering we'd only just met, I thought it might be a good idea to keep that opinion to myself. She might punch me in the face.

'Hey.'

I shook her hand. For some reason, my brain stopped working for a few seconds.

'Finally, you have arrived!' Sarah said.

Krishika smiled and sat down beside me.

'Why are you guys standing? Sit.'

I looked at Sarah. Sarah looked at me.

'She's just like that,' Sarah said, laughing.

Krishika looked at me and smiled.

'Don't worry. I'm harmless.'

Both girls laughed. I gave them an embarrassed smile.

'What will you have?' I asked.

'Tea. Less milk, more sugar.'

Very specific. I'd assumed she was a coffee person.

Sarah was about to introduce her when Krishika stopped her.

'My name is Krishika. I'm not from Maharashtra, and I speak terrible Marathi. I work for a loss-making online shopping startup, but they're still paying me well. I graduated from a prestigious college with an engineering degree, and I'm currently one step away from unemployment.'

She paused.

'I smoke but don't drink. I've had six breakups, and I'm currently single.'

I stared at her. She stared back.

'Anything else?' I asked.

'No. You can ask questions later.'

Sarah started laughing. I immediately understood why she'd called this girl a she-wolf. Krishika had the same confidence Sarah had, but somehow, she was even less afraid of being completely ridiculous. And that was exactly what we needed.

We'd already decided that Divya was important. The problem was that we knew almost nothing about her. She was a psychiatrist. She was connected to Viraj. She'd been at the party. She had enough status that people listened when she spoke. But none of that told us what kind of person she actually was.

And I didn't want to walk into her clinic with a lawyer's face and start asking questions about a murder. That would be stupid. Even I wasn't that stupid.

'We need your help,' Sarah said.

Krishika looked at me.

'Is this about the case?' she asked. Apparently, everybody knew about it.

'Yes.'

Her expression changed immediately. Not dramatically. Just enough.

'So what exactly do you want me to do?'

Sarah looked at me.

I explained the plan to her as briefly as possible.

'She's a therapist. We'll schedule an appointment for you. You go there and observe everything you can about her.'

Krishika narrowed her eyes.

'Is she dangerous?'

'No.'

'Like criminal dangerous?'

'No.'

'Then that's easy.'

Sarah interrupted.

'She's smart, Krishika. She's a psychiatrist.'

Krishika smiled.

'So?'

I looked at Sarah. Sarah looked at me. We'd found our person.

'Great,' we both said together.

Krishika laughed.

'What kind of information do you need?'

I thought for a moment.

'Try to understand her. How she talks, how she reacts, whether she's calm or aggressive, whether she avoids certain questions. Anything that feels strange.'

'Basically, you want me to judge her.'

'Professionally,' I said.

'Why aren't you two going?' Krishika asked.

'Because she's seen me,' I said. 'And Sarah is a little...'

I paused.

'Stupid?' Krishika completed.

She gave me a high five. Sarah punched me again.

'Okay,' I said. 'This is getting physically violent.'

'Can you?' Sarah asked, looking at Krishika.

Krishika leaned back in her chair.

'Consider it done.'

That confidence was exactly what I wanted and exactly what worried me. She was confident enough to enter a psychiatrist's clinic pretending to be a patient, but she was also confident enough to believe she could outsmart the psychiatrist. Those two things weren't necessarily the same.

I took out my phone.

'Let's book the appointment.'

We searched for Dr Divya Batra. Her clinic appeared after a few searches. Mind Care Clinic. Her website looked professional. Her profile described her as a consultant psychiatrist. The services included mental health consultations, anxiety, stress, anger management, de-addiction, and several other conditions.

There were testimonials everywhere. People thanking her for changing their lives. People describing how broken they'd been before meeting her. People saying she'd helped them understand themselves.

I scrolled further. The Pune Medical Association had named her the best psychiatrist in 2022.

I looked at Sarah.

'She sounds difficult.'

Sarah nodded.

'She is.'

I looked back at the screen. There was an option to book an appointment.

'What's your name?'

Krishika looked at me as if I'd asked her something deeply offensive.

'You don't know my name?'

'I know your name. I need to spell it.'

'K-R-I-S-H-I-K-A.'

'And surname?'

'Desai.'

I entered it. For the reason for consultation, we found an option that would work.

Internet addiction.

The appointment was booked for five in the evening. Krishika looked pleased with herself. Sarah looked proud. I was the only one who was still slightly worried.

We weren't going to meet Divya as lawyers. We weren't going to accuse her of anything. We weren't even going to mention Viraj. We were sending a stranger into her clinic to observe her. It wasn't exactly legal strategy. It wasn't exactly journalism either. It was simply the best option we had.

And sometimes, when you don't have enough information, you have to find another way to get it.

Krishika stood up.

'I have work. I'll meet you guys in the evening.'

Sarah stood up and hugged her.

'Be on time.'

'I will, queen.'

I shook her hand.

'Don't ruin our case.'

She smiled.

'No promises.'

She walked away. I watched her leave, then looked at Sarah.

'You really trust her?'

Sarah shrugged.

'She's good.'

'That wasn't my question.'

Sarah smiled.

I sighed. This was going to be interesting.

And for the first time since we started investigating Viraj, I felt like we'd finally found a door. We just needed someone brave enough to knock on it.

CHAPTER

15

The next day, Sarah called me before I had even brushed my teeth.

"Good morning."

"That's suspicious," I said.

"What?"

"You said good morning without insulting me."

"I can still insult you if you want."

"I'm fine."

She laughed.

"Krishika is too busy to meet today. I'll go to her room and call you."

"Fine. I want to hear everything."

"Of course you do."

Sarah and Krishika lived in the same hostel. Five minutes later, Sarah called again. Krishika was with her, and the phone was on speaker.

"Good morning, Mr Lawyer," Krishika said.

"Good morning, unemployed engineer."

"I am employed."

"Temporarily."

"Still employed."

"Okay, enough," Sarah interrupted. "Tell him what happened."

There was a short silence. Then Krishika began.

Krishika's version

Aditya dropped me off on time. Before entering the clinic, I was thinking about you two and how funny you both were! I walked up the stairs to Divya's clinic. It was exactly the size I'd anticipated. I made my way over to the attendant. She appeared to have been born irritated, but when I told her I had an appointment, her demeanour changed immediately. Maybe respecting people with appointments was part of her job. Before asking for my ID, she gave me a genuine-looking fake smile. Trust me, babe, I wanted to say. Instead, I showed her my Aadhaar card.

After confirming that I was, in fact, the fucking 'Krishika Desai', she handed me a piece of paper and told me not to mark anything. It was a long list of questions, and I knew I'd need the internet to write so much about myself.

I sat down and began reading the paper. It asked for all sorts of information about medical conditions, family medical history, previous medications, and much more. There were various sections, some with simple yes-or-no questions and others that required me to rate things on a scale of one to five. I decided to give myself a six in the physical health section. I eat grass most of the time and go to the gym for an hour, even on Sundays. I'm not just fit; I'm robust. That's one of the thousand things I have to be proud of myself for.

'Ma'am, you may enter,' the attendant said, smiling again. I was tempted to approach her and tell her how uncomfortable she was making me by smiling more than necessary, but I restrained myself. I walked up to the door and pushed it open. And wow!

Divya's cabin reminded me of a child's room, specifically, a wealthy child's room. She'd chosen the best colour scheme possible. I had no doubt those colours were scientifically supported. The room was stuffed with decorative items, including paper butterflies hanging from the ceiling. I asked God for the same room as soon as I walked in. Before I knew it, I was grinning as I looked around.

'Isn't it lovely?' Divya asked, standing up from her seat.

Her salwar kameez was the best-fitting one I'd ever seen. Why couldn't I find a salwar kameez that fitted me perfectly? Whenever I wore one, it either looked too baggy or felt uncomfortable. I made a mental note to ask her about her tailor.

I could never have guessed Divya was forty-three if Sarah hadn't told me. She had curly hair and looked like an adorable, chubby newlywed in her late twenties. She was in a profession that suited her perfectly. A woman with childlike features could put anyone at ease. I collected my thoughts and remembered why I was there. If I ever needed to see a psychiatrist, Divya would be my first choice.

'Beautiful,' I said. And I genuinely meant it.

'Krishika, how did you get here? I mean, by bus, rickshaw, scooter, or car?' Divya asked.

For a split second, I thought she'd seen me with Aditya and knew everything. Still, I tried to remain calm and hoped for the best.

'A friend dropped me off on a scooter,' I lied. Well, not really. Aditya was my friend, and he'd dropped me off. How could that be a lie?

Divya maintained her smile, though it wasn't nearly as annoying as the attendant's.

I loved her desk. It was a completely white IKEA table with no sharp edges. Everything was organised, and her purple-

coloured iMac 2022 looked amazing on it. She moved her mouse and did something on the computer.

'Okay, Krishika, first, get comfortable. I'm not a doctor,' she clarified.

I knew she wasn't a doctor. I'd never felt so at ease with one.

'I mean, I am a doctor, but not like the ones you visit when you get a viral infection,' she explained with a grin.

Okay, that way, I told myself.

'I'm good,' I replied, trying to sound cheerful.

'Good. Then tell me what the problem is,' she said, leaning forward and resting her elbows on the chair, as if I were about to tell her a story.

Which was precisely what I had in mind, by the way. A story.

'I feel like I've become addicted to my phone and the internet,' I admitted in a low voice. That wasn't my usual demeanour, but I wanted to appear like a tense, worried girl.

'Okay, unlock your phone and show me your data usage,' she said matter-of-factly.

I wasn't expecting that. Was she too brilliant, or was I too stupid? I was a software engineer. I should have thought of that before she did.

I had no choice. I unlocked my phone and handed it to her. She studied the screen for a while before picking up her own phone from the table. She moved her fingers across both screens and then turned them towards me.

'Your mobile data consumption and Wi-Fi usage are both lower than mine,' she said with a chuckle.

She checked my phone once more.

'And your screen time is quite balanced too,' she added.

I went blank.

'Do you mean I don't need any treatment or therapy?' I asked. I couldn't think of anything better to say.

'Okay, open this,' she said, handing me a sheet of paper and a pencil.

She gestured for me to start writing. This was a superior version of the Divya question paper. It contained all sorts of questions, ranging from my friends to my phone usage. I decided to make matters worse. Under the question about which devices I used, I listed my phone, laptop, PC, and tablet. I didn't even own a tablet. I just wanted her to believe I was an online junkie.

I quickly filled out the sheet and handed it back to her. She looked at it for a while before putting it in a drawer. I knew that wouldn't be enough, so I spoke before she could.

'I wouldn't say I use the internet for long periods, but I use it too often. Even on the bus, I use Google Maps to check the route and travel time. I look up everything that comes to mind. I feel like I've stopped using my brain and become completely dependent on my phone. I open the calculator app to do two-digit additions. I feel imprisoned, like I'm not free. Yesterday, I didn't touch my phone for two hours, and those were the worst two hours of my day. I was irritated.'

I kept going. That should have been enough to convince her I needed medical assistance.

'Okay, Krishika, relax,' she murmured, handing me a glass of water.

She was good at hiding her emotions. Even though I'd been behaving terribly for the past five minutes, she remained calm and pleasant. What was I doing there? Trying to read the mind of someone who was an expert at reading minds.

'Listen, Krishika, I think you're overcomplicating things. The problem you're describing is fairly common nowadays. People find it difficult to live without their electronic devices, and

it affects their lifestyles. In a way, we're all addicted to our phones and the internet,' she explained.

'Can't we do something about it?' I asked.

The real question on my mind was, Don't you want more money for treating me?

'Of course we can, but you don't need medication. I'll give you some pointers. Just follow them, and you'll feel better,' she said.

She then spent ten minutes boring me with advice about what to do and what not to do. Any simple chatbot could have done that for me. She ended her lecture by telling me to take things easy.

In a nutshell, I hadn't come across as someone who needed mental health therapy. And Divya wasn't a child. My overacting would only make her suspicious, so I'd avoided taking it too far. She was an experienced psychiatrist, and we couldn't underestimate her ability to spot lies.

Now, let me tell you about her. She spoke in a melodic voice that was relaxing to listen to. She wasn't like most people. She was calm and focused. You couldn't provoke her with a nasty word. She seemed to know exactly what she was doing. Whatever we were planning, it wasn't going to be easy. Convincing her would be extremely difficult. She was observant and intelligent. Manipulating her through conversation would be as difficult as melting an iron rod with a single matchstick.

I checked my watch. Only half an hour had passed. So, I decided to ask her advice about some personal matters, and I think she genuinely helped me. Of course, I'm not going to tell you everything.

Back to Aditya

Krishika finished her story. I'd been secretly recording everything on my phone, so I switched off the recorder. That wasn't wrong. I'd recorded it so I could listen to it again.

'Nice work, Krishika,' I said.

'It genuinely helped me, so thanks to you two,' Krishika replied.

'It's going to be difficult, Sarah,' I said.

Sarah hadn't spoken a single word since the call began.

'We'll figure it out. Don't worry,' she replied.

She'd been especially kind to me since I'd fallen ill the previous night, and I could feel it even over the phone.

'You owe me a dinner treat,' Krishika announced, her voice growing quieter as she moved away from the phone.

'I do,' I said before hanging up.

I brushed my teeth, thinking about Sarah, my parents, Ayushi, Krishika, the case, Divya, and everything else going on in my life.

It was agonising.

CHAPTER

16

I spent most of the morning thinking about Krishika's call. She hadn't found anything concrete. No secret, no confession, no dramatic connection between Divya and Viraj. Nothing we could take to the police and place dramatically on a table. But she'd found something more useful. Divya was difficult to read, and people like that made me uncomfortable.

I sat on the stairs outside my house, replaying Krishika's recording for the third time.

The truth was, I wanted to hear every word again because I'd started thinking about Divya more than I should have. There was one thing I couldn't get out of my head. She'd asked Krishika who had dropped her off at the clinic. It was a normal question. Probably.

I looked at my phone. Divya's number was saved there. I'd got it from the internet, of course. I stared at it for a while.

Then I called.

I fucking called!

Two rings.

I panicked and hung up.

'What the hell am I doing?' I asked myself.

My phone rang.

Divya.

Of course. She was calling back.

I answered.

'Hello?'

'Mr Aditya?'

Her voice was calm. How did she know my name?

'Hi. This is Aditya, Ayushi's lawyer.'

I didn't need to introduce myself. She already knew.

'I know.'

There was no anger in her voice. No surprise either. That made it worse.

'I wanted to meet you,' I said.

'For?'

'I'll explain when we meet. Fifteen minutes. Please.'

There was a short pause.

'Sure.'

I wasn't expecting that.

'Today?'

'Yes. Twelve.'

I checked the time. It was ten.

'Seriously?'

She remained silent.

'I mean, great. Where?'

'My clinic. You know the address?'

'I do.'

We ended the call.

I sat there for a few seconds. That had been surprisingly easy. Too easy, perhaps. I immediately called Sarah.

'Tell me something good?'

'I have something better than good.'

'What?'

'Divya wants to meet us.'

Silence.

Then Sarah's voice grew louder.

'What?'

'Today. Twelve.'

'You called her?'

'Yes.'

'You idiot.'

'Why?'

'You didn't tell me?'

'I am telling you now.'

'Where?'

'Her clinic.'

There was another pause.

'Fine. I'll come.'

I smiled.

'See you.'

I ended the call.

I had no idea what I was going to say to Divya. But I had fifteen minutes. And apparently, fifteen minutes was enough to change someone's life. At least, that's what advertisements for therapy seemed to believe.

At twelve, Sarah and I reached the clinic.

The receptionist looked at us, and her expression changed immediately. I remembered Krishika describing her fake smile. This time, there was no smile.

'You can't go in without an appointment,' she said.

'She's expecting us,' Sarah replied.

The receptionist stared at her. Sarah stared back. I could already see a fight forming.

'Please,' I said.

The receptionist picked up the phone and spoke quietly for a few seconds before putting it down.

'You may go.'

Sarah gave her a victorious smile.

I grabbed Sarah's arm.

'Don't.'

'I didn't say anything.'

'Your face did.'

We entered.

The clinic looked exactly as Krishika had described it. Paper butterflies hung from the ceiling. Everything was clean and carefully arranged, with books everywhere.

Divya was sitting behind her desk. She stood when we entered.

'Please, sit.'

Her voice was gentle.

Sarah and I sat opposite her.

I noticed the bookshelf immediately. Books on psychiatry, psychology, human behaviour, and several other subjects.

'You read a lot?' I asked.

'I prefer reading books outside my field as well.'

She smiled.

Then she picked up the phone.

'Tea?'

Before either of us could answer, she ordered it.

I looked at Sarah. She looked back at me. This woman was being polite. Too polite.

Divya noticed my expression.

'Is something wrong?'

'No.'

'Then why are you looking at me like that?'

I smiled.

'I was expecting you to be angry.'

'Why?'

'Because my client is accused of killing your friend.'

Her expression changed, but only slightly.

'Viraj was my friend. That doesn't make you my enemy,' she said calmly.

She barely blinked.

'How long had you known him?'

'A few decades,' she said with a knowing smile.

They'd been classmates at school. I knew that.

'And you were close?'

This time, she didn't answer.

Why would she?

'See, I don't think I can help you. I know what everyone knows.'

I didn't like that answer. Sarah and I sat frozen in our seats.

The tea arrived.

Divya thanked the receptionist.

Sarah didn't touch hers. Neither did I.

I watched Divya. She remained perfectly calm. No nervous hands, no sudden changes in expression. Nothing.

Krishika was right. She was difficult to read.

Sarah finally spoke.

'You seem very protective of him.'

Divya looked at her. Sarah had clearly crossed a line.

'I am protective of people I care about.'

Sarah's eyes narrowed.

'Even if that person was wrong?'

Divya didn't answer immediately.

Then she said quietly, 'People aren't as simple as right and wrong, Ms Kolan.'

So she knew Sarah too. I wondered if some private investigator was following us around.

'Fifteen minutes. That's what you asked for. Help me understand what you want from me.'

'The truth,' I said, a little too tensely.

Divya smiled.

'Everyone says that.'

There it was. Not anger. Not fear. No answers either. Just control.

I'd come here expecting to find a frightened friend protecting a dead man. Instead, I'd found a psychiatrist who knew exactly how much she wanted to say and how much she didn't.

I stood up. I was disappointed. Divya kept smiling.

Why had she even agreed to meet us?

'Thank you for your time,' I said.

Sarah looked surprised. I ignored her. Divya stood too.

'You're welcome,' she replied, matching my sarcasm.

We were about to leave when Divya leaned back in her chair.

'Before you go, there's something I'd like to discuss.'

Sarah stopped near the door and looked at her.

'What is it?'

Divya smiled and folded her hands on the table.

'You're both intelligent people. I'm sure you understand how difficult life can become when you involve yourselves in the wrong matters.'

So this was a threat.

'Get to the point,' Sarah said.

Divya's smile faded slightly.

'Drop Ayushi's case. Whatever your fee is, I'll pay you twice as much. Consider it compensation for your time and effort.'

For a moment, neither of us spoke.

Then Sarah laughed. There was nothing funny about it.

'Are you seriously trying to bribe us?'

'I'm offering you an opportunity to walk away without any trouble,' Divya replied calmly. 'You should learn the difference.'

Sarah stepped towards the desk.

'Put that money up your ass!' she snapped, so furiously that I thought she was about to slap Divya.

Divya looked at her for a moment before letting out a quiet laugh.

'How noble. Tell me, Ms Reporter, does your salary even cover your monthly expenses? And you, Mr Lawyer, how many cases have you handled independently? Two? Three? You can

barely afford to waste your time on one murder case, yet here you are, pretending to save the world.'

I felt the insult land, but before I could respond, Sarah spoke.

'Yeah, but we'll sleep in peace. You won't.'

Divya's expression hardened.

'People like you mistake stubbornness for courage. The world doesn't reward you for having principles. It simply finds ways to break you.'

'Maybe,' I said, finally speaking. 'But at least we get to decide what we're willing to break for.'

I stood up. Sarah was already at the door.

Divya picked up her pen and turned towards her computer, as though our conversation had become boring.

'You'll regret this,' she said.

Sarah slammed the door behind us as we stepped out.

CHAPTER

17

We went to the hospital that evening. Sarah had been unusually quiet on the way there. That usually meant one of two things: either she was angry or she was thinking. With Sarah, unfortunately, both could happen at the same time.

When we entered Ayushi's room, she was sitting against the headboard with a book in her hands. She looked better. Not completely healthy yet, but better. She smiled when she saw us.

'Hi.'

'Hi,' Sarah replied, sitting beside her.

I took the chair near the window.

'How are you feeling?' I asked.

'Better.'

'Good.'

Sarah looked at her.

'We need to talk about something.'

Ayushi's smile faded.

'What?'

I looked at Sarah, and Sarah looked at me. Neither of us knew how to say it without making things worse.

'We met Divya,' I finally said.

Ayushi went completely still. It lasted only a second, but I noticed.

'Why?'

Her voice had changed.

'Because she knows Viraj.'

'I know.'

'She might know something about what happened that night.'

Ayushi put the book aside.

'You shouldn't have gone.'

Sarah frowned. 'Why?'

'Because she won't help you. These people hate me.'

'That's not the point,' Sarah said. 'We need to find out what she knows, so we have to try.'

Ayushi turned to me.

'Adi, please. This won't help. I've seen the agony in their eyes.'

That was the first time she'd said my name like that. Not like a client speaking to her lawyer, but like someone asking a friend for something.

She looked at me for a moment before speaking again.

'I hit him. He died.'

I watched her carefully. There was something behind her eyes that I couldn't quite put into words. Regret, perhaps. Or something deeper.

'Did you see them talking or arguing at the party? Anything unusual? Anything that might help us understand what happened?'

'No.'

Ayushi's breathing grew slightly heavier.

'I don't want you guys getting into trouble because of me.'

'What trouble?' I asked.

She shook her head.

Sarah sat quietly beside her for a moment.

'Ayushi, relax,' she said softly.

Ayushi nodded, but she didn't look any calmer.

A few minutes later, Ayushi's parents arrived. Her mother immediately started asking about food, medicines, and whether she was sleeping properly.

Normal questions. Normal parents.

For a few minutes, the room felt normal too.

I stood near the window and watched Ayushi smile at them. She looked safe. But I knew better now. Someone didn't have to threaten you directly to make you afraid. Sometimes, knowing what a person was capable of was enough.

On our way out, Sarah stopped beside me.

'She's hiding something. It's as if she knows something. Or maybe she doesn't,' she said.

'Maybe,' I replied.

I looked back into the hospital room. Ayushi was laughing at something her mother had said.

We walked towards the stairs. Neither of us said it aloud, but we both understood that something wasn't right. We were no longer simply investigating Viraj's death. We were trying to understand why Ayushi was so terrified of the people connected to him.

Was it the guilt of having killed Viraj? The fear of facing those people? Or was there something else we didn't know about?

Ayushi's parents left after another round of thank-yous. Sarah and I decided to stay a little longer, hoping we could change Ayushi's mind and get her to tell us something.

Sarah's phone rang. She glanced at the screen and immediately made a face.

'I have to go.'

'Where?'

'My office.'

'Why?'

'Apparently, my office staff can't find a file without me.'

She sounded proud rather than irritated.

'That sounds like a management problem.'

'It is. And unfortunately, I am the management.'

She stood up.

'I'll be back. Give me the keys.'

'Why?'

'Because I'm taking your scooter.'

'Of course.'

She took the keys.

'Stay here.'

'I know how to sit.'

'I'm serious, Adi.'

'So am I.'

She smiled and walked away. I watched her leave, only to find Ayushi looking at me.

'What?'

'You two are very close.'

I smiled. 'We've known each other for years now.'

'Just friends?'

I looked at her. She was smiling.

'You sound like a journalist.'

'I've spent enough time with Sarah,' she said playfully.

'That explains everything.'

She laughed.

Somehow, the conversation had drifted away from the case. It felt good to sit there without worrying about what would happen next.

'Do you live alone in Pune?' she asked.

'Yes.'

'For how long?'

'Quite a while.'

'Do you like it here?'

'I like this city. I might settle here.'

She smiled. 'That would be nice.'

'I have my own house,' I said. Why did I say that?

'Really?'

'My father's house,' I clarified.

She laughed.

'So you're rich.'

'Finally, someone understands me.'

She laughed again.

'How did you become a lawyer?'

'Is this an interview?'

'Maybe.'

I smiled. 'I had a lot of dreams. Then I found law interesting, and my parents encouraged me.' I paused. 'And I love the dress code.'

She looked at my black shirt.

'That's your reason?'

'Partly.'

She smiled.

'You seem very sorted.'

I almost laughed. 'I'm not.'

She raised an eyebrow.

'My decisions change every five minutes.'

'So you're not sorted.'

'Exactly.'

There was a brief silence before she asked, 'Do you have a girlfriend?'

Did she forget about the goddamn murder case hanging over her head? I looked at her. 'Why?'

'Just asking.'

'No.'

'Have you ever loved someone?'

That question was different. I looked towards the window.

'Maybe.'

She waited, but I didn't say anything.

'Who?'

I smiled. 'I said "maybe", and this is getting too personal.'

'You asked me about my life.'

'You're my client. I'm supposed to...'

'And you're avoiding the question.'

I laughed. 'Fine.'

I thought for a moment.

'Her name was Lily.'

Ayushi smiled. 'Lily?'

'Yes.'

'Who is Lily?'

'A girl I knew when I was in eighth grade.'

'Eighth grade?'

'Yes.'

'You fell in love in eighth grade?'

'I think twelve is when you start seeing the world a little differently. Before that, everything seems simple. Then suddenly, you start noticing things you never did before. So, eighth grade sounds about right.'

Ayushi smiled. 'You sound like an old man.'

'I am wise.'

'You were twelve.'

'Exactly. Peak wisdom back then.'

She giggled.

I leaned back in my chair.

'Her name wasn't actually Lily.'

'Then why Lily?'

'Because I don't want to use her real name.'

'Okay, Jack.'

I smiled, and then there was an uncomfortable pause. I obviously didn't want to continue with the story.

'So tell me about Jack and Lily,' Ayushi said, looking curious. Probably an opportunity? Tell her something, get something from her. I decided to play along.

I took a breath. I was back in eighth grade.

Jack and lily

A boy named Jack lived in a lovely small town. He was twelve years old and attended a public school. Jack was a reserved person, not when it came to talking, but when it came to sharing his feelings and expressing himself. He spent most of his time playing with his friends. School was a pain in the arse for him.

It was June, the beginning of a new school year, and Jack, like every year, had resolved to study harder. On the first day of eighth grade, the only thing he heard everyone talking about was the arrival of a new principal at their school. Jack had nothing to do with the new principal unless he decided to ban students from playing during recess. That was Jack's favourite time of the day.

Jack entered the classroom that morning. All the students seemed excited about the new school year. It took them nearly thirty minutes to settle down after fighting over seats. Jack managed to secure the last bench, right in the middle of the back wall. He had always believed it was the best seat in the classroom. He could see everything happening around him, and nobody could see him.

Their teacher entered the classroom soon after. Jack was busy with his small group of friends. When everyone stood up to greet her, he did the same. That's when he noticed that the teacher wasn't alone. A girl stood beside her.

The teacher introduced the girl as Lily, the new principal's daughter. Her eyes were small in proportion to her face, and so were her lips. She looked different from everyone else in the classroom. Jack wasn't sure whether she was Indian. Her face was ruddy, expressionless, and beautiful. Her long black hair was tied into two braids. Jack smiled without realising it as he looked at her, but she was just staring at the crowd.

The teacher told Lily she could sit wherever she wanted. That was one of the advantages of being the principal's daughter.

She walked towards the rows of girls' benches, and every girl seemed to realise that her seat was suddenly at risk. As Lily passed the first two benches, Jack's heart skipped a beat. She continued towards the back until she reached the wall near the last bench. Lily stood between two benches, but the seats on her left were already occupied by two girls. So she sat on the bench to her right, right beside Jack.

Jack was overjoyed. He tried not to stare at her, but she had his complete attention. Lily took a few things out of her bag, and the class began. Jack barely remembered anything else that happened that day.

Lily never changed her seat. Another girl started sitting beside her, and that became their permanent arrangement. Jack began attending school more regularly because he finally had a good reason to go. He started paying attention to his appearance, something he had never bothered with before. He studied harder so he could answer questions in class and even stopped making the loud jokes he was known for. He wanted to look a little more civilised and well-mannered in front of Lily. He wanted her to notice him and impress her.

Lily rarely spoke in class. Her only conversations were with the girl sitting beside her, and even those happened in a very low voice. It seemed as though she had a limit on the number of words she was willing to speak each day. She was excellent at academics, and she also loved music. Once, she played the ukulele at a school function, and Jack was completely mesmerised. She stood on stage with a large group of girls, but Jack couldn't take his eyes off her. Every now and then, he thought she was looking at him, only to realise that she was just staring at the crowd. The image of Lily holding that ukulele stayed in Jack's mind. He was falling more and more in love with her every day.

Lily, on the other hand, never looked at Jack the way he looked at her. They sat barely a metre apart for five hours every day without saying a word to each other. Sometimes their eyes met, and Jack would melt from within. Every day, he tried to find new reasons why Lily might like him. He was doing well in exams. He had the best haircut in class, at least in his opinion, because it was neither too simple nor too fancy. His fashion sense was far better than that of his classmates. Despite being a backbencher, he had a good reputation among the teachers.

'What more does she want?' Jack would think.

Within a few months, Jack had changed almost everything about himself to impress her. Without Lily ever knowing it, she had made him a better person.

Finally, something good happened. Since they both sat on the last benches, they were usually among the last students to leave the classroom at the end of the day. One afternoon, as Jack was packing his bag, Lily called his name.

Jack stopped and turned around, nervous as hell. She walked over and asked if she could borrow one of his comic books. Jack always carried a set of them, and everyone in the class knew about his collection. Without saying a word, he pulled one out of his bag and handed it to her. Lily thanked him, and they went their separate ways. Jack spent the rest of the day thinking about that one minute.

The next day, Lily returned his book, and it immediately became his favourite possession. He spent the rest of the day turning its pages.

That little exchange gave Jack and Lily a reason to start talking. They began having regular conversations about comics, teachers, sports, and other students. Those were the days when Jack felt as though he were walking on clouds. He was getting closer to Lily, and he thought there were signs that she might like

him too. Once, he lent her a novel he was reading. Another time, she handed him her water bottle while he was playing on the ground. For Jack, it was nothing less than the elixir of life.

Time passed, and their mid-semester exams arrived. Jack studied hard, but not exactly for the exams. He wanted to be ready to clear any doubts Lily might have. As luck would have it, her roll number was just before his, so even on exam days, he had a chance to be near her. They could meet after the paper, and she might ask him whether an answer she'd written was correct. For those few moments, Jack felt like the smartest person on the planet.

The exams flew by, and soon it was time for their final paper. Jack was miserable because he knew he wouldn't see Lily for at least a month after the exams. The night before the last paper, he tossed and turned in bed, unable to accept the thought of being away from her. He knew he might find excuses to see her during the holidays, but that wasn't enough for his greedy heart.

Eventually, he decided he would act normal the next day and enjoy their last day together before the holidays. He reasoned that if he looked sad in front of Lily, she might feel sad too. With those uncomfortable thoughts still running through his head, Jack finally drifted off to sleep.

It was an unwritten rule at their school that students could wear casual clothes on the last day before the holidays. Even the teachers had accepted the tradition. Jack put extra effort into looking his best that morning, but when he saw Lily, he realised he should have spent another hour getting ready.

Lily looked stunning. Something about her seemed different that day. Her hair looked so perfectly done that Jack couldn't help wondering how anyone could tie someone's hair so beautifully. She wore a white top with red and blue embroidery

around the neck, paired with light blue jeans. Jack usually disliked net-patterned clothes, but he liked the net sleeves on Lily's top.

As she approached him, Jack found himself staring at her face, trying to take in every detail. His mind went blank. It felt as though an angel had decided to walk straight towards him.

'Jack!'

Her voice brought him back to reality.

'You look beautiful,' he blurted out.

Lily laughed, clearly not expecting the compliment.

They sat down to write their final paper. With Lily sitting ahead of him, Jack struggled to concentrate. Her hair kept distracting him. How did she manage to make it look so perfect? He wanted to meet the person responsible for that masterpiece. It was probably Lily's mother. Somehow, he managed to focus on the questions and finish the paper. Lily finished hers too and glanced back at him with a smile.

After the exam, they waited outside the classroom while Lily finished talking to the girl who usually sat beside her. Finally, she came over to Jack.

'Last day. I'm going to miss this,' she said.

'I'm already missing it,' Jack replied with a smile, though his heart was heavy. He was glad to know Lily felt sad about the holidays too.

'I don't want to leave this place,' Lily said.

'Relax, it's just a month,' Jack assured her, trying to convince himself as much as her.

But Lily didn't look reassured. Instead, she seemed confused, as if she'd just remembered something.

'Oh, Jack, I'm sorry,' she said.

Sorry? For what? Jack wondered. Had she done something wrong? And even if she had, why was she apologising? She had nothing to apologise for.

'Didn't I tell you? My father has been transferred near our hometown, so I'll be continuing my next semester there,' she explained.

It took Jack a moment to understand what she'd just said.

'Oh,' was all he managed.

'Yeah. My grandmother's health hasn't been very good lately. My father had been trying for this transfer for months,' she explained.

Jack nodded. He didn't say a word.

'I'm really nervous about settling into a new school,' she admitted with a smile.

Jack felt strangely warm, as if his whole body were heating up from the inside. He tried to concentrate on the conversation, but it was getting harder by the second. His legs felt weak, and he was afraid he might collapse. That's what emotional pain does to you. It tries to become physical.

'You'll do well,' Jack said, managing a smile.

'I hope so.'

All the other students had left. Only Jack and Lily remained outside the classroom. Jack didn't want to think too much because he knew he might lose control of his emotions. He didn't want to make a scene, and honestly, what would be the point? Who cared about Jack anyway?

'You must be getting late,' he said, desperate for that moment to end.

'Yes, I think I should leave. Keep meeting, bye,' Lily said, holding out her hand.

Jack had become so numb that even the touch of her hand barely registered. It was their first and only handshake, and he couldn't quite process it.

'Bye,' he said with a smile.

Lily walked away, taking longer and faster steps. Jack watched her until she disappeared from sight.

He smiled to himself, though there was nothing funny about any of it. Lily meant something to Jack that he couldn't quite explain, while he had probably been just another classmate to her. He pulled a piece of paper, a letter, from his pocket and threw it into the dustbin beside him. Then he walked away, with nowhere in particular to go.

CHAPTER

18

'What's going on?' Sarah said as she entered the room, and I felt like my mother had caught me with drugs. I scanned her face from every angle, hoping to find the true meaning behind her beautiful smile, but it was all blank. She wasn't angry, and why would she be? I panicked for no apparent reason. Why do I feel this way when Sarah is around?

'Nothing, Adi was giving me prison living tips.' Ayushi said and Sarah got confused, just like I was a few minutes ago, she was unsure whether to laugh or not at Ayushi's comment.

'You may laugh; it is a joke.' Sarah 's confusion vanished as I smiled. She, too, burst out laughing. Laughter, laughter, laughter.

Sarah put down the bag she was holding in her hand and took a seat beside me.

'Neuroscience is easier than finding things in my office; they needed me' Sarah said.

'You came quickly,' I said. slip of tongue.

'He hates me' Sarah said as she turned to face Ayushi. How quickly Ayushi changed the mood of the party from laughing with me to laughing with Sarah

This technique is used by two people who have secrets. One of them mingles with the third person, giving him the impression that he is closer to him, but, in fact, he is closer to the second person. Did you get that?

There was no light of fun now that teacher Sarah had returned. No more jokes. I didn't want the conversation to turn to the case.

'We should leave' I said to Sarah . and as I said that Ayushi's face dropped. It was difficult for her, being so alone. Sarah also realised the same.

'We will return soon; we have a lot to do.' She smiled as she said to Ayushi. What is there to do? I pondered. What were we doing besides failing? I was becoming increasingly despondent. Worst of all, the case was not moving forward. We were trapped.

'We are leaving for Goa in the evening; it's already twelve.' Sarah continued to speak, and my eyes widened. What? Goa? I mean good, goa. But why Goa? This is not the time for trips.

'and who are the "we"?' I asked

'Of course, you and me.' Sarah replied. I knew it was me and her, still I asked for confirmation.

'So, you didn't even know about going to Goa?' Ayushi asked, laughing.

'No, that's not important; madam has the control. She will decide everything without even asking me,' I said in a sarcastic tone.

'Yes,' Sarah said with a devilish smile.

'what yes? Why goa?' I mocked at 'what yes?'

'Viraj has his house there'

'had'

'The house is still there.'

'But Viraj is not there'

'Doesn't matter. By the way, I have never seen someone so private. We got nothing about him."

‘what private? He has over a hundred posts on his Instagram.

‘Which we haven’t seen’

‘Are you sure we should go to Goa for this?’

‘Hundred percent sure’

‘No need Sara, it makes no sense.’

‘Makes sense to me,’

‘We won’t get anything there; it's just a waste of time.’

‘don’t be so pessimistic, even before trying’

‘think again’

‘I am done thinking’

‘Sara…’

‘I am going alone if you are not interested.’

‘All right, let’s go. Goa or wherever you want’

‘Not exactly goa, it’s a small village there ‘Sonarim”

‘hm’

Ayushi was silently listening to our conversation while maintaining a steady smile on her face. What was there to smile? I wasn’t at all convinced about going to Goa.

‘Take care,’ I said to Ayushi as I rose from my chair. I picked up Sarah 's backpack because it is my responsibility to carry her belongings when I am with her—a forced responsibility.

‘We'll be back the day after tomorrow. I will call Uncle and Aunty; they will visit you tomorrow,’ Sarah explained to Ayushi. Ayushi kept nodding like a kid.

‘All the best’ Ayushi said with a smile. We were about to walk out the door when I heard Ayushi's words again.

‘Lily was stupid,’ she acknowledged. I smiled briefly before continuing on my way to the hospital's exit.

'Who is Lily?' Sarah inquired.

'It's a character from a book, Ayushi was telling me a story.' I said.

'I have never been to goa before' I spoke further to change the topic.

'Me neither,' Sarah replied.

'So how is your boss doing?'

ACT 3:

THE SECRET

CHAPTER

19

We reached Sonarim in the morning. I'd expected a proper village road, but the last few kilometres had mostly been dust, uneven roads, and fields stretching in every direction.

Sarah looked out of the window.

'Beautiful.'

'Dusty.'

'Same thing.'

'No.'

She ignored me.

Our train had dropped us at a tiny station in the middle of nowhere. From there, we'd managed to find a truck driver who agreed to drop us closer to the village. He left us on the main road.

'Where now?' I asked.

Sarah checked her phone. 'About ten minutes.'

'Walking?'

'Yes.'

'Of course.'

We started walking. There was hardly anyone around, and the sun was already getting uncomfortable.

'I thought you said ten minutes.'

'It is ten minutes.'

'You said that five minutes ago.'

'So?'

'So your ten minutes is different from normal people's ten minutes.'

She looked at me. 'Stop complaining.'

'I'm not complaining. I'm providing feedback.'

'Keep your feedback to yourself.'

We continued walking until we came across a small roadside shop. Sarah immediately headed towards it.

'Water.'

We bought two bottles and sat down for a few minutes. A middle-aged man was sitting nearby, smoking. Sarah looked at me.

I knew that look.

'No.'

'Ask him.'

'You ask him.'

'You're the lawyer.'

'That has nothing to do with finding someone's house.'

'Still.'

I sighed and walked over to him.

'Kaka?'

He looked at me.

'Viraj Desai's house?'

His expression changed slightly.

'Viraj?'

'Yes.'

'Mumbai man?'

'Yes. Mumbai man, Bangalore man, Pune man. Whoever. Just give me an address.'

He pointed down the road.

'Go straight, towards the fields. There are only two houses there. Krishna's house and the bungalow.'

Finally, an address. And he'd mentioned Krishna, so we were heading in the right direction.

We thanked him and continued walking. A few minutes later, we spotted the two houses. One was clean and occupied. The other was large, locked, and covered in dust.

Viraj's bungalow.

Sarah stopped. 'That's it.'

I looked at the locked gate. 'Looks like he hasn't been here for a while.'

'Obviously.'

A boy and a girl were playing cricket with a small bat and a plastic ball in front of the other house. The younger girl held the bat while the older boy bowled to her. She tried to hit the ball but struggled to swing the bat quickly enough. Sarah moved forward to talk to them.

'Is anyone home?' she asked the boy. He didn't seem happy about us bothering him, but he answered anyway.

'We are,' he said, gesturing towards himself and his sister.

I realised Sarah wasn't the best person to talk to children. She wasn't particularly good with annoying kids, so I stepped in.

'Is there anyone older here?' I asked the boy.

It worked. It always works. God has given me that innocent, trustworthy face.

'My father is just behind the house. Wait, I'll bring him,' he said before heading inside.

The house was ideally located, with the front door facing the village and the back door opening towards their farm. It must have been convenient. The little girl was much sweeter than the boy, with a sugary smile. Sarah took the ball and began playing with her. I watched them, unsure of who was cuter.

Soon, a muscular man emerged from the house. He wore an old T-shirt that looked like his usual workwear. He eyed us suspiciously, and his gaze made me a little uncomfortable. He had the kind of biceps you'd expect from an Instagram fitness influencer, and his stubble made him look even tougher. He walked quickly and took only four and a half steps to reach me. Sarah hadn't even noticed him approaching.

'Ronny, Sweety, go inside,' he said firmly.

But why? We hadn't even said a word.

'Yes?' he asked, trying to sound normal but still looking damn temperamental. He clearly wasn't happy to see us. Sarah, meanwhile, remained unfazed and stared at him with venom.

Why?

'We're from Pune. I wanted to talk to you,' I said.

He raised an eyebrow, clearly unsatisfied with my answer.

'She's a reporter working on a story about Mr Viraj,' I explained.

His expression softened.

'It was bad. He left too soon.'

He seemed genuinely saddened by Viraj's death. That told me he had known him well enough to care. We'd finally found someone who knew something about Viraj, and he had no idea that I was the lawyer defending the person accused of killing him.

'That was the worst thing that happened this year. May he rest in peace.'

I was overdoing it. When a strong man expresses sympathy for someone, you should probably do the same. That's the law of the world. Everyone follows what a strong person does. Strength can be physical, mental, political, or financial.

'Hmm,' he said, managing a weak smile.

Just a minute earlier, I'd been certain this man couldn't smile. Apparently, he could.

'I'm sorry. I thought you were the fake salespeople,' he said.

'What? Salespeople?' Sarah asked.

'Last month, a city boy and a city girl came to Masterji's house pretending to sell packaged papads. They robbed the place at knifepoint. Thankfully, Masterji was unharmed. They took her gold necklace and earrings, along with the school medal she'd received for her long service to the village.'

Mr Krishna explained what had happened. Yes, this was the Krishna the old man had told us about.

Sarah and I looked at each other, wondering if we really looked like people who sold things and then robbed houses at knifepoint. Forget Sarah. Did I look like that?

'We just wanted to talk to you. And we don't have any knives either,' I said with a smile.

Krishna laughed a little.

So, he could laugh too.

'Please come in,' he said.

We felt relieved. Krishna seemed like a decent person, and he was inviting us into his home.

Sarah followed me inside. The hall was enormous. Compared to city houses, it was about the size of a three-bedroom flat, but Krishna had built only one hall, one kitchen, a bathroom, and a toilet. It seemed ideal for a family of four. The

house wasn't painted, but the walls were neatly puttied, and everything was clean.

We sat in a corner of the hall on a massive wooden cot. Krishna brought us water in steel glasses, which we drank. He then pulled up a chair and sat beside us.

'Please tell me how I can help you. I'm sorry, but I don't know how to make tea, and my wife has gone to sell vegetables in the village,' Krishna explained.

He sounded sincere.

'No, no, that's perfectly fine,' Sarah said with a smile, motioning for me to begin.

'Mr Viraj was a famous person. Her channel is going to do a story on him, and we're here to gather information. You live next door to his house, so we thought you might know something about him.'

'I know a lot about him. You can ask,' Krishna said, smiling, apparently happy to help us.

'Sir, we're going to record whatever you say. Is that fine with you?' I asked, taking out my phone.

'No, don't record.'

Sarah and I exchanged a glance. We didn't understand why he didn't want us to record.

'All right, we won't record anything,' I said, putting my phone away. I nodded to Sarah to begin asking questions.

'When did you first meet Mr Viraj?' she asked.

'Five years ago. The land on which the bungalow stands belonged to my family before Viraj sir bought it and built his house. He paid almost double what the plot was worth,' Krishna said.

He seemed straightforward and honest.

'Why build a house in a village? And why pay so much for the land?' I asked.

'He said he needed peace. Rich people prefer living in villages because it's more natural for them,' Krishna replied.

'So, Viraj was quite rich,' I said.

'The richest. He never thought money was difficult to come by.'

Krishna was answering my questions honestly, and I wasn't going to pass up the chance to ask more. We needed every bit of information we could get about Viraj, so I kept going.

'How do you think he made that much money?'

'He was a businessman. Always on the phone.'

'What kind of business did he do?'

'Land. Buying and selling land. Don't you know that?' Krishna asked.

'Yes, yes, we know. I meant, did he have any other businesses?'

'I don't know,' he replied.

'And what about his family?'

'He was alone. He once told me his wife had died of an illness, leaving him all alone,' Krishna said, clearly feeling sorry for Viraj.

'How often would he come here?' I asked.

'Once every few months, for a week or less. Whenever he had the time.'

'Do you think he was a genuine person? I mean, how well did you know him?' I asked.

Krishna paused before answering. That was my sign that I'd asked the right question. I looked at Sarah, but she gave me a blank look.

'Are you really not recording any of this?' Krishna asked.

Sarah and I exchanged another glance and smiled weakly. So much for earning his trust.

'Don't you trust us?' Sarah asked, jumping into the conversation at just the right moment.

In the land of goddesses, a woman is always more trustworthy than a man.

'Okay, let me tell you everything clearly,' Krishna said, taking a deep breath.

'Go on. We're listening,' I replied.

'We used to drink together occasionally. When he got drunk, he'd talk a lot about his life. Please don't tell my wife if you meet her,' Krishna added, making that last part very clear.

'We won't,' Sarah promised with a smile.

Krishna nodded.

'He was involved in selling some kind of drug. He said it was something similar to alcohol, but in powder form rather than liquid.'

Sarah and I exchanged wide-eyed glances.

Shit! Viraj was a fucking drug dealer.

We both had a lot to say, but decided against saying anything. Krishna seemed to think the drug was just like wine. If we overreacted, he might hesitate to tell us anything more. We kept our mouths shut and let him continue.

'He used to earn lakhs every day, and to be honest, he wasn't a clean character,' Krishna added.

'What do you mean?' I asked.

Krishna looked at Sarah, hesitant to say more.

'Don't worry. I'm good at hearing the worst,' Sarah said solemnly.

Krishna smiled, seemingly relieved.

'He'd be with a lot of girls, different girls every time,' he said, gathering his courage. It clearly wasn't easy for him to discuss such things in front of a woman.

'He used to bring them here?' Sarah asked, surprised.

'No, no, no. He'd show me their photos after getting drunk,' Krishna explained.

'Hmm,' we both said at the same time.

'Anything else?' I asked.

'He travelled extensively. He also told me that what he was doing was illegal and that the village was the safest place for him to stay. Coming here was like spring-cleaning for him. He'd come here after finishing one task, rest for a while, and then move on to the next.'

Krishna was giving us the most important information. One conversation with him had changed everything.

'You said he had no family and a lot of money, so why was he still working?' Sarah asked.

I had the same question.

'He stopped working six months ago. Maybe that's why I'm telling you all this,' Krishna replied without hesitation, as though he'd been expecting the question.

'What?' I exclaimed.

'Yes. He said he had enough money to live on for the rest of his life and was going to travel and have fun.'

'Unfortunately, he couldn't,' Sarah said, looking at the floor.

'One more thing,' Krishna said.

Sarah and I turned towards him, curious.

'He was dangerous.'

'Dangerous in what sense?' Sarah asked.

'He carried a gun, and it wasn't fake. I'd touched it. It was heavy, and he showed me the bullets too. I'm telling you, it was real,' Krishna said, almost forcing the words out.

'Okay, it must have been real,' Sarah said, reassuring him that we believed him.

'I told my wife about it for a week, but she didn't believe me. She kept saying Viraj had fooled me with a toy,' Krishna explained.

I wanted to meet this woman who could terrify a giant of a man so easily.

'Is that all, sir?' I asked.

Krishna nodded.

'Thanks. We had nothing on him before this. No photos, no information,' Sarah said.

'Oh, Ronny has a lot of photos of him on his phone,' Krishna replied.

My first question was, 'Does Ronny have a phone?'

'It's his mother's phone, only in name. He uses it all the time. Do you want to see the photos?'

'Yes, yes, of course,' I said.

Goa was shaping up to be a huge success for us. In thirty minutes, we'd gathered a lot of information about Viraj.

Krishna called out, 'Ronny! Ronny!'

A moment later, Ronny appeared. He seemed to have a serious issue with Sarah because he looked at her strangely.

'Show them Viraj uncle's photos. You have some on your phone, right?' Krishna instructed him.

'They're not downloaded on my phone. Those were his Instagram posts,' Ronny said.

Sarah and I nearly jumped with excitement.

'Is he following you back?' Sarah asked.

'He was following me. He's dead now, but his account is still active, and I can still show you the photos,' Ronny replied in a strange tone.

That's the problem with today's kids. But this kid was actually smart. And even more useful.

Okay, useful isn't the right word. I understand.

'When did he follow you, Ronny?' I asked.

It's a good trick with children. Just call them by their names, and they're happy.

'The last time he came here, he followed me. I tell everyone to follow me, and Viraj uncle did it happily,' Ronny replied, far more politely than he had answered Sarah.

'Tell me one thing, Ronny. Why do you ask people to follow you?' I asked.

He seemed to like the question.

'I want to become an influencer. I make interesting reels,' he replied, his eyes lighting up.

'Wow. Then show me your reels and Viraj uncle's account too,' I said with a smile.

Ronny pulled out his phone like a weapon and unlocked it by drawing a pattern on the screen. Even after watching him do it, I couldn't figure it out. It was that complicated.

He opened Instagram, searched for Viraj's account, and handed me the phone. I recognised the profile immediately. I'd seen it at least fifty times before, but it had always felt like a locked treasure, and Ronny had the key.

Sarah moved closer as I took the phone. Viraj's Instagram account was full of posts and highlights. 'I am worth it, baby,' his bio read.

Worth what? I wondered. Selling drugs?

I scrolled down and opened his first post. He was on a yacht, holding a glass of red wine. He wore sunglasses, and the reflection had ruined the shot.

The cameraman gets a zero.

The caption read, 'New York is a beauty.'

Sarah was paying close attention to the posts. I continued scrolling. The next one showed Viraj at the main gate outside Delhi International Airport, with the caption, 'Always hard to leave my land.' It was his last photo before leaving for New York.

I realised he was the kind of person who posted all his activities online, which was ridiculous for a criminal.

'We need all these posts,' Sarah murmured in my ear. She didn't want Ronny to hear that.

I took a deep breath.

'Let's take a look at your videos now,' I said.

Ronny was ecstatic, and I smiled at him.

Then I saw his profile. It was incredible. He was about to reach his first thousand followers. His bio read, 'Life gets easier when you start examining it.'

I started watching his first video. Ronny spoke for sixty seconds about 'Bittrex', then spent another sixty seconds talking about Indian Railway facts in the next one. He'd made over fifty videos on random topics, telling a minute-long story in each. When I checked the views, they were in the thousands.

'You're killing it, man. How do you know so much?' I asked, giving him a high five.

Ronny couldn't stop smiling. I realised I was probably the first person to react so positively to his videos.

'I research things and then make videos. All of them are true. Nothing is made up,' Ronny said proudly.

He was too smart for his age.

'Your phone looks good. It must have a good camera. Why aren't your videos as clear as those made by the big creators?' I asked.

That was the first step of the plan. I knew a little about cameras and photography, and I could tell that the lighting was the problem.

'They use ring lights,' he said.

See? I was right.

'Why don't you use one, then? You'll hit millions,' I said excitedly.

I knew that was probably too much.

'My parents don't listen to me,' he replied.

'Didn't you show them your videos? You're doing really good work. Far better than those dancing videos,' I said.

That was the second step of the plan.

'Six hundred rupees can't be wasted on this. That's what they think. My father doesn't even know what Instagram is. I run his account,' Ronny said sadly.

This kid had opened an Instagram account for his father and was posting things in his name. Excellent!

Perfect. Time to make the offer.

'I can gift it to you and ask your father to let you use it,' I said.

I expected him to jump with happiness, but he looked suspicious instead.

'What do you want in return?' he asked.

'Your account password,' I said plainly.

'You want me to trade my account for a ring light? That's not going to happen,' Ronny said firmly.

'No, no, no. You've got me wrong. I just want your Instagram password for a week. You can change it later,' I explained.

'Why do you want it, then?' he asked.

'See, Ronny, I'm not going to lie. We're reporters looking for more information about Viraj uncle. We can learn a lot from his photographs, and you both follow each other on Instagram,' I said, trying to sound convincing.

At least convincing enough to persuade a kid.

'You're not going to do anything else to my account?' he asked.

I could tell I was winning him over.

'Not even a single story view. I won't even open your chats,' I promised.

He seemed to soften and thought about it for a while.

'Deal,' he said, shaking my hand.

I looked at Sarah. Her expression told me she was impressed.

I intended to keep my promise, so I ordered the ring light Ronny wanted and had it delivered to his address. I also asked Krishna to accept it on Ronny's behalf and tell him that he was doing something good. Ronny was the happiest person in the room when he heard the news.

I returned to him for a few final questions.

'What problem do you have with her?' I asked, pointing at Sarah.

She could clearly hear us. Ronny looked down, bending his neck, while Sarah waited desperately to hear his answer.

My mother watches a TV serial, and the bad woman in that show looks exactly like her. I'm sorry. I shouldn't have behaved that way,' Ronny said, then laughed.

Sarah's eyes widened.

'It's all right, Ronny. I get confused too,' I said.

Sarah moved forward and punched me. She didn't even look at Ronny before going outside to play with Sweety.

Thank goodness Krishna wasn't there.

I continued laughing, and Ronny joined in.

'Just promise me one thing, Ronny. More studying, fewer videos,' I said.

'Deal,' he grinned.

CHAPTER

20

We were walking back to the hotel. The water bottle Sarah had bought in the village was in my hand, and somehow, that had become my responsibility too.

The road seemed much longer on the way back. Maybe because we finally had something to think about.

Sarah had been quiet for almost a minute.

Then she said it.

'Fucking bastard.'

I looked at her.

'You've said that at least ten times.'

'He deserves it.'

'He's dead.'

'So?'

'So maybe stop abusing a dead man.'

She stopped walking and looked at me.

'Adi, do you understand what he was doing?'

'Yes.'

'Do you?'

'I think so.'

'He was selling drugs.'

'I heard him.'

Sarah started walking again.

'I've seen what drugs do to people. I've seen twenty-year-olds destroy their lives. I've seen families lose everything because one person got addicted.'

She was angry. Not the usual Sarah kind of angry, where she'd complain for five minutes and then make a joke. This was different.

'He was making money by selling poison,' she said.

I didn't have an answer.

'He probably didn't care who bought it. He just wanted money.'

'That's how criminals usually work.'

She looked at me.

'Thank you, Mr Lawyer. Very insightful.'

'You're welcome.'

She smiled for half a second, then the smile disappeared.

'People like him deserve to be punished.'

'He's dead.'

'Good.'

I handed her the water bottle.

'Drink some water before you start planning his murder.'

She took it.

'I would have killed him.'

'Great. Then I'd have two clients.'

She laughed despite herself.

We stopped under the shade of a tree. The sun was making both of us sweat.

I looked at the bottle in my hand. Then something came back to me.

'Wait.'

'What?'

'The powder.'

'What powder?'

'The drug Krishna mentioned.'

'Yeah?'

'What exactly was it?'

'Powder.'

'I know that.'

She looked at me.

'I asked him later. Brown powder. Heroin.'

I remembered what Krishna had said. I'd heard the word before, but I wasn't completely sure.

'How do you know it was heroin?'

Sarah stared at me, then smiled.

'I am a drug dealer too.'

'Seriously?'

'No.'

'Then?'

'I've been reporting crime for years, idiot. You learn things.'

She took the bottle from me again.

'Don't write that in your brilliant legal notes as proof that Viraj was dealing heroin.

Krishna didn't identify the substance.'

I nodded.

That distinction mattered. A drug dealer was one thing. Proof was another.

I looked back towards the village.

'Still, this changes things.'

'It changes everything.'

'Not everything.'

She frowned.

'How?'

'Viraj being a drug dealer doesn't tell us who killed him.'

'But it tells us he had enemies.'

'Maybe.'

'And money.'

'Definitely.'

'And people who wanted him dead.'

'Possibly.'

She stared at me.

'You really know how to ruin a dramatic moment.'

'That's my job.'

We started walking again.

Our train back to Pune was in the evening. We'd spent half a day travelling to a village, found a man who knew Viraj, and somehow ended up discovering that the man we'd thought was a rich businessman might have been involved in drug trafficking.

That wasn't exactly how I'd planned the trip.

But the more I thought about it, the more uncomfortable I became.

Viraj had told Krishna that the village was the safest place for him. He carried a gun. He travelled frequently. He was involved in something illegal. And six months before his death, he'd stopped.

Why?

That was the question.

'Sarah.'

'Hm?'

'Why would someone stop a business that makes lakhs every day?'

She didn't answer immediately.

'Maybe he had enough money.'

'Maybe.'

'Maybe he was scared.'

'Of whom?'

She looked at me.

'That's what we're supposed to find out.'

I nodded.

We continued walking.

We reached the hotel. Before entering, I looked back once more at the road leading towards the village.

There was something strange about the whole thing.

If Krishna was telling the truth, Viraj had spent years building a second life that nobody at Hotel Blue Rose seemed to know about.

That made me think about Ayushi.

She had hit him once. The police had found her at the scene. She had admitted it.

Everything still pointed towards her.

But now we knew something the police apparently didn't.

Viraj had a secret life.

And people with secret lives usually have secrets worth killing for.

I didn't know yet whether any of this had anything to do with his death.

CHAPTER

21

We were back in the city.

I woke up at nine the next morning. There were no missed calls from Sarah.

That meant one of two things. Either she was sleeping, or she was ignoring me. Both were possible.

I didn't feel like getting out of bed. The train journey had done a number on my back, but at least my own bed had fixed most of the damage.

My stomach, however, had other plans.

I dragged myself out of bed and headed to the kitchen. I made poha because apparently, I'd become the kind of person who cooked breakfast while investigating a murder.

Life changes quickly.

While I was eating, my phone buzzed.

Sarah.

'up?'

'yes. Slept well?'

'yes. You?'

'really well'

'great. Hospital at twelve?'

'Sure.'

Dr Anshul. Ayushi's consultant had messaged me while we were in Sonarim. He wanted to meet me, so I decided to see him first.

It was probably the sort of thing a lawyer should do.

I planned to reach the hospital early, before Sarah arrived. I wasn't hiding anything. I just wanted to have this conversation on my own.

There was a difference.

I reached the hospital at eleven. By now, I knew my way around the place. The hospital had been a huge help over the past few days, and the nurses and receptionists recognised me. They smiled whenever I passed. Perhaps they wanted to stay on good terms with a lawyer in case they ever found themselves in a situation like Ayushi's.

I knew where Dr Anshul's cabin was, so I went straight there. Through the rectangular glass panel in the door, I could see him working on his computer. I knocked.

'Yes?' he called.

I pushed the door open.

'Oh, Mr Aditya. Please come in.'

He recognised me. How? We'd never met before.

Dr Anshul was in his early thirties and, from what I'd heard, excellent at his job. I'd overheard the hospital staff praising him more than once. Getting that kind of appreciation from your own staff was no small achievement.

His cabin was small and completely enclosed, with no windows. Even on a sunny day, it was dark enough to need artificial lighting. His chair was the room's centrepiece, a white woollen thing that looked ridiculously soft. The table and computer, on the other hand, looked as though they'd been around since the hospital opened. Why a doctor working in such

a huge hospital used such an ancient setup was beyond me. I still don't know.

'I was out of town,' I said with a smile.

'All right, what will you have?' he asked.

No doctor had ever offered me anything while I was sitting in his cabin. They usually asked what I'd had, not what I'd like to have.

'Tea will do,' I replied.

Never refuse complimentary food or drink. It's basic hospitality, and I believe in respecting it.

He picked up the phone and ordered tea. Then he returned to his computer while I waited. When the tea arrived, he finally put his work aside.

'The best tea you can find,' he announced, raising his cup before taking a sip.

We finished our tea in silence. I waited for him to explain why he'd called me, but he simply went back to his computer.

Seriously?

He'd called me here, and now he was making me wait. Was he trying to get revenge on me or something? My patience was running out.

'You wanted to tell me something important, sir?' I asked.

'Yes. Let her come, and I'll begin.'

'Let whom come, sir?'

I was curious. Who was coming? Divya? Was this some kind of doctor-to-doctor arrangement? Was she planning to bribe me?

'I also called Ms Sarah. She'll be here soon.'

That caught me off guard. I nearly got up from my chair. A lawyer couldn't behave like this. Sarah hadn't told me the doctor had called her, just as I hadn't told her he'd called me.

'She'll be surprised to see me here,' I said with a smile.

'Actually, she knows you're here.' He smiled back.

What the fuck was this guy up to?

Sarah was setting me up. She wanted to catch me red-handed. My plan had been simple: meet the doctor first, then tell Sarah. Now he'd ruined everything.

'Oh,' I said.

He went back to work while I sat there waiting for my death.

I started preparing excuses in my head. If Sarah punched me in front of the doctor, my reputation would be ruined. Not that I had much of a reputation to begin with, but still. Sarah rarely thought about her surroundings before insulting me. She'd once made me carry her purse through a market. I swear it was the most embarrassing thing I'd ever done. And she'd made me tie her shoelaces in a garden, in front of hundreds of people.

A couple of minutes later, someone knocked.

'Come in,' the doctor called.

Sarah walked in and sat in the chair beside me.

'You were supposed to arrive at twelve. Why so early?' she asked sarcastically.

I avoided looking at her and smiled at the doctor, pretending everything was perfectly normal.

'I thought you might be tired after the journey, so I came ahead,' I explained, trying to sound convincing.

'Oh, let's discuss this later,' she said.

'That's what women do. Dominate,' Dr Anshul laughed at his own joke.

She's dominating because of you, moron, I wanted to tell him.

I had no interest in his philosophy.

'Okay, sir. Please begin,' I said, trying to relax.

'Yes, I believe Ayushi has symptoms of myasthenia gravis,' he said solemnly.

What the hell was that?

I nearly shouted the question in my head. There were already enough problems in my life, and now the doctor was adding more. And he had to use a name that sounded like it belonged in a biology textbook.

Couldn't he have started with simpler words?

That's the problem with overeducated people. They forget that not everyone understands what they do. Sometimes, the easiest way to impress people is to stop showing off what you know.

'What is it?' Sarah asked. She looked just as tense as I felt.

'It's a rare disease. It can cause weakness in different parts of the body and a lack of energy,' he explained.

That made things a little clearer.

'Is it serious?' I asked.

My heart was racing. Ayushi had already been through enough. She didn't need another problem.

'There are two possible outcomes. The best-case scenario is that she responds to medication and rest. The worst-case scenario is respiratory failure.'

He picked up a pen and began spinning it between his fingers like a pro. Then he looked me in the eyes.

'We want the best for her,' I told him.

My voice had changed. I wasn't just asking him to help her. I was warning him, too. He seemed to take it as a request.

'I promise you that,' he said with a smile.

I felt like jumping across his desk and touching his feet. All I wanted was for Ayushi to be okay. That was it.

Sarah looked relieved, but I still had a question. If the doctor was so certain about her condition, why had he kept us waiting? Was he expecting money? I wondered.

'Thank you, doctor,' I said, waiting for him to continue.

'Don't thank me just yet,' he replied with a smile.

There it was. I knew something was coming. Something about this whole conversation still didn't feel right.

'All right,' Sarah said. She seemed to have the same feeling.

'If I certify that she has myasthenia gravis and needs proper rest and supervision, she might not be transferred to jail before the next hearing. I suppose that's what you want.'

That was reassuring. Keeping Ayushi in the hospital was our backup plan.

'Does she really need supervision?' Sarah asked.

'Certainly not. She's doing fine. She got our attention when she needed it, and she's already recovering,' Dr Anshul said with a smile.

'Are you doing us a favour or not?' I asked. I wanted to know what he expected in return.

'That's why you're both here. I'm definitely going to do it,' he said emphatically.

Sarah and I exchanged confused looks.

Why was he so happy? Was he already imagining the money coming his way?

'For what?' I asked.

'What for?' He looked confused.

'I mean, what do you want in return?' I asked, keeping my eyes on him.

'Why would I want anything? I only want to help because the girl appears to be innocent. Is that not allowed?'

He looked genuinely confused, which only confused us more.

Was he doing this on purpose? Who was he, an angel?

'You really don't want anything?' Sarah asked.

That seemed to irritate him.

'Do I look that greedy?' He gave us a disappointed look.

So he really had no demands. God was actively helping us for once.

'Thank you very much, then,' I said, still confused and managing only half a smile.

Anshul burst out laughing.

That frightened me all over again.

'You're a lawyer and a reporter, and you don't trust anyone,' he said, still laughing.

So this was how he normally laughed.

'We apologise, but we thought...'

He cut me off.

'You thought I'd ask for a favour, money, or something similar. But don't worry. I'm just a regular doctor trying to help the girl. You're not the only two people who want to do something good.'

He was pulling our legs now.

'Thank you, sir. This is very helpful,' Sarah said warmly.

'You're very welcome,' Dr Anshul replied with a smile.

'You can bribe me by having breakfast with me, by the way,' he added.

We all laughed. We had to.

CHAPTER

22

'Are we going to tell Ayushi about the illness?' Sarah asked, sounding unsure. I was still worried despite the doctor's assurances. I couldn't get his words about the worst-case scenario, 'respiratory failure', out of my head. I wanted to stay optimistic, but I was worried too.

'No, she would be scared. She already has a lot on her mind,' I explained.

Sarah nodded.

'By the way, I can't wait to see her,' Sarah said. I wanted to say, 'Me neither,' but I didn't. I had no idea what was going on with me. I was keeping things from both Sarah and Ayushi. I didn't want Sarah to know what I thought of Ayushi, and I wasn't even sure what I thought of her myself. I still hadn't told Sarah about my conversation with Ayushi two days ago. I was also trying not to let Ayushi affect me so much whenever she was around. I wasn't doing any of it deliberately. It was just happening.

When we entered the room, Ayushi was reading a book. She noticed Sarah first, who was walking ahead of me. Ayushi smiled at her, and then her eyes met mine. She looked happy to see both of us.

'I'm reading this for the third time,' Ayushi said, showing us the book. She was practically announcing how bored she was.

'We'll bring you more,' Sarah said, giving her a gentle hug. She sat beside Ayushi, and I took a seat on the bed next to her.

'Was the trip a success?' Ayushi asked curiously.

The way she asked told me she'd left the responsibility to us and trusted us to handle things. There was no worry in her voice. She seemed confident in us.

'Huge success,' I said with a smile.

The smile she gave Sarah was normal, but the one she gave me was different. Something seemed to be going on between Ayushi and me, or maybe I was imagining things. Whatever it was, I didn't want Sarah to notice.

'You should have fewer regrets now. He was a drug dealer,' Sarah said, finally sharing what she'd been holding back. She wanted Ayushi to know as soon as possible.

'Seriously?' Ayushi looked shocked.

'Yes,' I replied.

She fell silent, lost in thought. Anyone would need time to process that. I knew it wouldn't make her feel any better. Murder was still murder.

Ayushi took a sip from her water bottle and passed it to Sarah, who drank a little before handing it to me.

'So, what are we doing next?' Sarah asked, looking at me for an answer.

'Him being a criminal won't make much difference, but it'll help us show that he was dangerous,' I said. I was the only lawyer in the room, and sometimes I was proud of it.

I didn't want to raise Ayushi's hopes too much. We were still in the middle of an investigation, and now that we had some time, I wanted to proceed carefully.

Sarah nodded. She seemed to understand. Since we didn't want Ayushi to worry about the case, she changed the subject.

'Leave that aside. How are you doing?' Sarah asked her.

'It's strange because most of the time I feel normal, and then suddenly my body feels drained. I'm so weak that I can't even turn over in bed,' Ayushi explained.

If she'd told us this two days ago, we might have assumed it was normal weakness. But now that we knew the reason, we were concerned.

'Don't miss your medicines,' I told her.

She nodded.

'When will they take me to jail?' she asked.

That was her worst nightmare. She wanted to avoid it for as long as she could.

'Until you're perfectly fine,' Sarah told her.

'You might be here until the next date, as you're not completely fine,' I said.

Sarah and I had agreed not to discuss it, but I couldn't stop thinking about it. I wished I could have been her judge instead of her lawyer. I wondered what decision I would have made.

'Hmm,' Ayushi replied.

Sarah was about to say something when she stopped and sneezed.

'You got a cold. That's the price,' I said before she could respond.

'Price for what?' Ayushi asked.

'For keeping the window open on the train like a seven-year-old. I shouldn't have let you do that,' I said.

'It's normal,' Sarah replied quietly, realising her mistake.

Sarah getting a cold was never easy. It usually got worse, going from a cold to a cough and then a fever. I'd taken her to the hospital several times because of it. Whenever that happened,

she became so weak that it was harder for me than it was for her. I was used to seeing her roar.

'We'll see what happens this time. The last time you got a cold, you were sick for a week,' I pointed out.

'I'm sorry, but the next time you tell me to close the window, I will,' she joked.

Sarah and Ayushi started talking, and Sarah began telling her about the past two days. I took out my phone and pretended to be busy.

I opened Instagram. I had an account, but I only used it once in a blue moon. I had to reset my password every time because I kept forgetting it.

I copied Ronny's account details from my phone's notes and pasted them into the login box. Within two seconds, I was logged into his account.

His feed began with a motivational quote. These quotes must make up half of Instagram's content. I ignored it and opened the search tab. The most recently searched person was me. Ronny had searched for my name, so I opened my profile instead of

Viraj's.

I had 87 followers, which wasn't even a tenth of Ronny's number. I made a mental note to delete my only Instagram post. It was an old selfie with poor quality and a strange angle. I wondered how I'd had the courage to post my photograph on a platform where other people could see it and react to it.

'And Adi was terrified...'

Sarah was telling Ayushi about the scene when Krishna had entered his yard and stood like a mountain in front of me. She could be so cheap sometimes. I pretended not to hear anything.

I could feel Ayushi looking at me, waiting for my reaction, but I kept a straight face while staring at my phone.

'Adi,' Ayushi called.

'Yes?' I said, turning towards her.

'Are you okay?' she asked. Hearing her say my name had become as natural as hearing Sarah's.

'Yeah, everything's fine,' I said, smiling and putting my phone down.

She smiled back and continued looking into my eyes. I believed that was her way of figuring out whether or not a person was okay.

'I was telling her about how you freaked out when you saw Krishna,' Sarah said, unable to stop laughing. It didn't bother me because she looked cute when she laughed.

'Leave that, Ayushi, and let me tell you what Ronny said,' I began.

'He said nothing and was a bothersome kid,' Sarah said, trying to defend herself.

Ayushi looked puzzled. She wanted to know what he'd said.

'He said that...'

Sarah jumped off the bed and pressed her hand against my mouth. She was so strong that I fell back onto the bed, with Sarah on top of me, still trying to stop me from speaking.

We struggled against each other while Ayushi watched and laughed. I wasn't going to give up, and getting hold of Sarah's hands wasn't difficult. I grabbed them and shouted to Ayushi, 'Ronny said Sarah looks like a villain from a TV serial.'

Sarah gave up when I finally said it. Ayushi and I burst out laughing.

Sarah stood up and went back to her place.

'Forget it, or I'll kill you both,' she said.

Sarah and I couldn't stop laughing.

'I'm more skilled at killing,' Ayushi said, pausing between bursts of laughter before starting again.

Sarah and I looked at each other, unsure whether to laugh or be concerned.

'You can laugh. It's fun to make jokes about it,' Ayushi said, laughing uncontrollably and expecting us to join her. We did, though we were only pretending.

I turned off the notifications because Ronny's account kept receiving them. We had work to do, and I didn't want to leave Ayushi alone again. But she wasn't really up to discussing everything, and talking about her difficulties in front of her might have made her feel even more uneasy.

'Sarah, we should leave,' I said.

'Where for?' Sarah asked.

'The police station. We should tell Vaishali about this,' I replied.

'We're living on help these days,' Sarah remarked. I could see she was irritated by everything. But so what? Work was work. I was irritated as well, perhaps more than she was, but I didn't react.

'Do you have a better option?' I asked.

She shook her head. There was no other choice.

'Let's go.' Sarah stood up.

As we prepared to leave, Ayushi's face fell.

'We'll be back soon. Now change that face,' I said.

Ayushi and Sarah both smiled.

'Don't forget the books!' she said.

'I won't,' I replied.

CHAPTER

23

We had decided to message Divya to see whether she knew anything about the drugs or not. We could have done it from my place, but Sarah had opted to do it in the evening at Saras Baug. Saras Baug is a picturesque area in Pune, with its major attraction being the wonderfully designed temple of Lord Ganesh. A large garden surrounds the temple, and there is also a tiny man-made pond teeming with aquatic life. Lotus plants have taken over the little water body. It features tortoises, many varieties of fish, and some crabs. One can spend hours watching the pond. The first time I visited, I was astounded. It's like heaven surrounded by a jungle of concrete buildings.

We sat down on a bench. The sun had set, and the LED lights had barely come on. I could see couples ranging in age from eighteen to seventy. People would first visit the temple and then come into the garden to relax. Children were playing while their parents stood back and watched them. The atmosphere was filled with excitement, enthusiasm, and optimism. Even the most depressed person would discover happiness simply by sitting there. And I can tell you that the best time to visit is in the evening. It's easy; just take a seat there and feel the presence of the Almighty.

'Why are we here? I don't even want to say the word "drugs" here,' I told Sara.

The slightly cold air was far easier to breathe than the air from the AC.

'You just said it,' Sarah pointed out. She laughed as she said this. I gave her a disapproving look to make her realise that she needed to improve her jokes. Her sense of humour is often good, but it can be awful at times.

'Listen, this is the best place. Whatever immoral thing we're going to do, we'll do it here, surrounded by positivity, to neutralise it, right?' she stated.

'Not at all,' I replied.

'All right, I'm scared. What if we get tracked? That's why we're here,' she explained. 'Stop being such a chicken,' I urged her, not understanding her apprehension at all.

People say trash on social media; they even say incredibly terrible things to famous and respected people. When you play a basic online game, your opponent starts saying 'shit' to you. Every day, thousands of individuals receive fraudulent messages, threats, and filthy comments, and nothing happens. How were we going to get caught? Sarah was being too sassy for no apparent reason.

'You are forgetting the line between bravery and stupidity,' she commented.

'Okay, fine. We're here, at the place you wanted and at the time you wanted. What is the reason for doing it in the evening, by the way?' I inquired.

'Stop finding reasons and logic and do what we are here for,' she said irritably.

I opened her bag and took out the spare phone I had told her to bring with her.

She had found it once when she was following the police, who were following some menacing college students. And being Sara, she did not give the phone to the police. She removed the SIM card and even the memory card, for no reason, and switched it off. It sounds so illegal, right? If we start counting every minor

illegal act she has committed, she is a potential criminal who deserves to be imprisoned.

'Don't you think you have stolen this phone?' I asked her. By the way, even if she gets into trouble, she has a lawyer who can die for her.

'No, I picked it up from the ground. That can't be a crime,' she replied with a smile.

'What was the purpose?' I asked.

'Nothing at that time, but it now serves a very important purpose,' she said proudly.

There is no pride in picking up a phone off the ground, even if it is the finest phone in the world.

'What if it is locked?' I asked.

'It's not. Krishika rebooted it back then,' she said, giggling. She knew my reaction.

'She is not normal at all,' I said, surprised by Sara's words.

Sarah went on laughing.

'By the way, it's off and completely discharged,' she said.

'Are you mad? Why are we here, then?' I asked, getting irritated in a second.

'Don't worry, I have brought the power bank,' she said, taking out the ten-thousandmilliampere-hour power bank.

'But why didn't you charge it?' I asked, still not satisfied.

I looked at the phone. It was at least six to seven years old. It didn't even have a full screen and had large bezels. There was also a crack on the primary screen. I had my doubts about whether it would work or not.

I plugged in the wire, and the red battery indicator appeared. It was charging. I attempted to switch it on, but it was fast asleep.

I shook my head as I looked at Sara, giving her the same look a doctor gives after failing to save a patient in Bollywood films.

'This is garbage,' I informed Sara, my hopes dwindling.

'No, it works. Be patient.'

She took the phone and power bank and placed them on her right side. The phone was going to take some time to turn on, and we had a few minutes to talk. There was a brief pause while Sarah and I studied our surroundings.

'Adi,' Sarah said, and I looked at her. She seemed excited about something, and it made me smile without even knowing what it was.

'Do you want kids?' she asked, and that came as a surprise to me. We had never discussed that before, not even marriage.

'What should I say? I mean, yeah, I do want kids,' I pondered.

She smiled broadly. She turned to her right, folded one leg, and placed it on the bench. Seeing so many adorable kids in the garden had piqued her interest in them.

'How many?' she inquired.

'At least a dozen!' I laughed, but Sarah didn't join in.

'Shut up, I'm serious. Answer correctly,' she said.

'But why are you asking these questions? Anyway, ask, and I will answer,' I responded.

'Good, how many?' she asked, and her grin returned. The gorgeous, joyous, nourishing, energising, life-giving grin had returned.

I said, 'Two girls or two boys.'

'Wow, now ask this to me.'

'Yes, Miss Sara, how many children do you want?'

'A boy and a girl,' she said, delighted.

'Do you think you will be able to take care of two kids?' I laughed at her.

She started thinking about it.

'You don't even know how to cook, Sara. And you are so foolish that you cleaned the dining table with my new shirt that day. Raising children isn't your cup of tea,' I continued, taunting her.

'So what? I will learn.'

'Good, get married soon,' I said, and her face transformed.

'You know what, Adi? I want children, but getting married seems like a nightmare to me. I mean, how can I put my life in the hands of someone? You know how I am; my friendships don't survive more than a month. Do you think I can be a decent wife? I don't believe so.'

She said all this in a tone that had shifted from light-hearted to serious. I assumed she needed my guidance.

'Why do you see it as placing your life in the hands of someone else? Everything will be shared,' said the adviser.

I was really interested in hearing her reaction to this, and she thought for a bit.

'I don't trust anyone. I don't believe there is a man out there who can understand me, take care of me, support me in what I want to achieve, and be prepared to spend his life with me.'

She said everything from the bottom of her heart. As soon as she said that, I began to analyse myself to see if I fit into that group or not, and I did. Not for Sara, I mean, but for whoever else.

'Hmm,' I said, having no answer.

'I know I act like I don't give a damn, but I do. Ever since my parents called to tell me about the marriage and gave me that list of people last month. To be honest, I want to marry and have

a family just like everyone else. But the question is, with whom?' she asked.

Why was she being so serious? I wanted to end the conversation.

'Matrimonial sites?' I tried suggesting something to her.

'Damn, I already have a number of portfolios; many of them are well-known. Why do I need a matrimonial site?' she explained, and she was right.

'Makes sense,' I replied.

'But you're just twenty-six. Why are you so concerned?' I asked. I didn't have any solutions to her problems, so I asked her a question instead.

'I don't know. What if I start worrying about my age when I'm thirty or older and develop some insecurities? Then I might end up with the wrong person. I want to be on time,' she said.

Sarah was suddenly becoming increasingly desperate to get married, which was amusing. She didn't want to get married just yet, but she wanted to start the process so she could marry the right guy.

'Are you mad? Don't try to control these things, Sarah. Just let them happen. Marriage should feel nice, but it should also be right. The right person, at the right time, with the right attitude. You are looking to win this game, but it's not a game,' I said, sharing all the knowledge I had about marriage.

'Wow, Mr Lawyer. You are great,' she said, clapping.

'Thank you,' I replied.

'When will you get married, by the way?' Sarah asked.

'At least not for the next five years,' I said, giving her my honest opinion.

'That will be too late. Get married soon,' she said, laughing.

'Enough, let's get to work,' I said, and she handed me the phone and the power bank.

I pressed the power button for a long time, and, to my astonishment, the phone switched on. It displayed a strange company logo that I had never heard of before. It took thirty seconds for something else to appear on the screen. I bypassed all the phone setup screens that appeared.

It was a little, five-inch phone running Android 8, and it was very sluggish. I connected it to my phone's hotspot and downloaded a fake texting app. The setup was nearly complete.

'Done,' I said, smiling at Sara.

'Okay, then proceed,' she said, putting her hand on my thigh. She was doing that more often those days, and every time she did, it electrified me.

These fake chat apps can be useful, but they can also be dangerous if used incorrectly. These messengers can send messages to whatever number you desire without revealing your actual phone details. You don't even need a SIM card in your phone. Simply enter the number you want to message and begin texting.

But these applications are quite difficult to come by. Fortunately, I knew where to look and found one.

'Her number,' I said, and Sarah read it from her phone.

It was seven in the evening, and Saras Baug closed at eight.

'Message that bit...' Sarah was about to say something, but I placed my hand over her lips.

'God is listening,' I said, pointing towards the temple.

She took back her words.

I started typing the first SMS.

Me: Divya? 7:01 PM

Sarah and I looked at the phone. Our eyes were glued to the spot where we were expecting her reply.

Two minutes passed. No reply.

Four minutes passed. Still no reply.

'People no longer check SMS messages, Adi. Nowadays, most of them are spam,' Sarah said, and that seemed valid to me.

'We should wait,' I answered, still hopeful.

There was no response after ten minutes.

'Why does this always happen to me? Every time something...' Sarah was about to start crying when I interrupted her.

'Look, look, look! She replied,' I murmured.

She snatched the phone from my grasp, and for a minute, we both read the one word on the screen.

Divya: Yes? 7:12 PM

'Don't reply right now,' Sarah whispered as I was about to start typing.

'We can't make her wait. That's when you need to impress someone, display arrogance, or demonstrate your importance, not when you're pretending to be a drug addict in desperate need of a dose,' I explained.

I don't know why, but Sarah laughed. I ignored her.

Me: Need stuff. 7:13 PM

Divya: What? 7:13 PM

'What?' was Sara's reaction.

'What is stuff?' she asked again.

'It's not chocolate, Sara. They don't text it like "I want drugs." They call it "stuff",' I explained.

'Wow, and how do you know so much? I'm developing doubts about you now. You don't look that bad, by the way.'

'Shut up. I'm just well-researched, not well-drugged,' I replied.

Me: LSD. 7:14 PM

Divya: Who are you? 7:14 PM

'Sara, please don't interrupt now. We're getting her.'

'Did I say anything?'

'No, but...'

'But your butt. Shut up and carry on,' she said, and I did as she said, like I usually do.

Me: Don't ask that. When can I get it? 7:15 PM

Divya: See, I think you have messaged the wrong person. 7:15 PM

Me: You work for Viraj, right? I'm his old buyer. 7:15 PM

Sarah continued to chuckle. Divya was terrified, and Sarah was enjoying it. Divya was definitely not involved, but she was aware of Viraj's business, and it was now time to gather some proof, or weapons, to blackmail Divya.

Am I sounding like Sara?

Divya: No, I just knew him. 7:16 PM

Me: But people have your number. 7:16 PM

Divya: Where did you get it from? 7:16 PM

Me: From another dealer. You're taking over after Viraj, right? 7:17 PM

Divya: No, no, no. I haven't even seen drugs. 7:17 PM

Me: Don't be scared. I'm a friend. 7:17 PM

She took her time responding, so I knew a longer message was on its way. Sarah was becoming impatient and biting my left hand.

Divya: I'm not scared. I don't know anything about it. Viraj was a friend, and he could have accidentally given my phone number to someone, which is how it got spread. 7:18 PM

Me: Then how do you know about drugs? 7:18 PM

Divya: I know all that, but I'm not a part of it. 7:18 PM

I read the message and looked at Sarah, who was beaming. She excitedly clutched my arm.

'Reply,' she said.

'No, we shouldn't. It'll look more realistic if we don't reply. Let her bask in the dread for a while,' I said like a mastermind.

Divya: Do not message me again, and delete this number.

Divya's message came, but I didn't reply.

Divya: I am not involved at all.

Another message came after some time, and we just looked at it.

Divya: Hello?

7:21 PM.

That was Divya's last message, and we didn't respond. She then stopped texting.

I took screenshots of the chats and saved them to the phone's SD card. I removed the SD card and handed it to Sara.

She is the best at keeping things secure. Give her a pen and ask for it after a month; she will have it safely stored somewhere.

Later, I factory-reset the phone twice and placed it in my pocket.

We thanked God before leaving the place.

'The bitch is over now,' Sarah said as she took the first step out of the temple grounds.

I didn't stop her from saying it because she had been holding it in for a long time.

We approached Sara's scooter, and Sarah realised she was hungry. Weird? Normal for me.

Saras Baug features a lovely range of eateries right beside it, where you can have anything vegetarian, from South Indian to Chinese. Sarah and I opted to have pav bhaji there, which was rather expensive. We ate until we were stuffed and then returned to our scooters.

Sarah started the scooter, and we moved towards our respective places. The clean roads of Pune looked even more beautiful under the streetlights.

'What are we going to do next?' Sarah asked.

'Why do you keep asking me that?' I said.

'Who's the lawyer?'

'Of course, me.'

'That's why I keep asking you.'

'We have the whole night to think about it,' I replied loudly.

'You have the night. I'm not thinking about it anymore. I'll sleep now.'

'That's what you do,' I replied.

I took the old phone out of my right pocket and started opening it. I opened the back cover, removed its battery, and put it back together.

Two minutes later, we were passing over the bridge across the Mula River. That was the place I'd been waiting for.

I threw the phone to the left side of the bridge and the battery to the right.

We didn't need it anymore.

'What did you throw?' Sarah asked.

'Chocolates for the fishes,' I replied.

CHAPTER

24

I was trying hard to sleep, but Sara's words kept me awake. What she had said about marriage in the garden was replaying in my head. To be honest, I despised the subject of her marriage. I realised I was the one who started it that day, and I loathed myself for doing so. This was the second time we had discussed it, and the second time I felt insecure. I resolved to be honest with myself and accept that she would marry someday, and that thought took my breath away.

She'll marry someone, a guy will become more important to her than me, I'll come after him for her, he'll be her husband, they'll live together, I'll lose my right to call her anytime I want, they'll have children, and I'm sure they'll be damn important to me. Sara's children, her husband, her home, her family, and no Adi. Our communication will dwindle with time, and there is a good risk that I will cease to exist for her. She may return to normalcy without me, but what about me? I will be left alone.

I got out of bed and began roaming around my house. My blood began to boil, my body felt heated, and my breathing became laboured. It was horrible. I walked into the kitchen and began placing things in their proper positions, then went into the living room and organised the sofa. I was trying to distract myself, but it wasn't working. Sarah holding the hand of a guy with no face was the only image that sprang to mind. I just needed to get this nonsense out of my head.

And then I picked up the phone. I knew Sarah would be up because it was just ten o'clock in the evening. She answered the phone on the first ring.

'Sarah'

'What?' she said.

'What are you doing?'

'Nothing; I was looking to see if I could get anything about Viraj from his Instagram profile. Every post is saying he was rich, but unfortunately, that's not a crime.'

'Hmm.'

'What happened, Adi? Are you okay?' She sensed the tension in my voice.

'No, I am not.'

'You want me to come there?' she asked. That was always her first reaction.

'No, no. Just wanted to talk.'

'Oh, then go ahead; I am listening.'

'Sarah'

'Yes?'

'You shouldn't get married.'

'What? Is this the thing you are not okay about?'

'Yes.'

'Then what am I supposed to do? I can't live alone for the rest of my life,' she replied.

She shouldn't have said that. It did hurt me.

'I understand, but don't think about it too soon,' I said, being as clear as I could. As her closest person, I had the right to say that much.

'But why, Adi?'

'Just listen to me, okay? You can't get married so soon; I am not ready for it,' I said. I was irritated. I was feeling angry for no reason, and the anger was directed at Sarah, again for no reason.

She burst out laughing as I said that.

'Why do you need to be ready for my marriage?'

I hated it when she chuckled. She wasn't understanding the situation. My heart was racing, my head was spinning, and I had become so weak at that moment that I would have cried if Sarah had been there. And she had no idea what was going on.

'Good night,' I replied as I hung up the phone.

Everything seemed wrong to me, so I did what I always do: I punched the wall until my knuckles hurt and the rough wall tore my skin in places. That pain provided me with satisfaction and calmed me down. Was it like punishing my inner self for being so disturbed? I need treatment, right? You're probably thinking that I should go and see Divya for a consultation first.

She called right back, but I didn't answer. I hated Sarah at that moment. I didn't turn off the phone because I wanted to see her attempts to contact me, as it made me feel important at the time. After ten minutes, I began to feel better, and the thought that Sarah must be sad gave me pleasure. I had successfully drawn her into my anxiety. I am a terrible person at times.

I turned on the television and began watching Super Strikers on YouTube. As the heat in my body dissipated, I began to feel more at ease. I began to breathe normally again, and I smiled as I watched the cartoons celebrating goals. I got some milk from the fridge, mixed in some chocolate powder, and kept watching. My rage at Sarah died down, and my emotions returned to normal.

'Sorry, Sarah,' I told myself.

I picked up the phone and decided to call her back.

'Adi, open the door.'

A familiar voice, the most familiar to my ears, reached me. Sarah lived only two kilometres away, which I had forgotten. Her enraged voice and the loud knock on the door told me how bad things were about to get. I dashed to the door and flung it open.

I looked at her from her toes to her head. She was wearing black slippers with red and black designs, and her feet were clean. Then came her black shorts, which ended just above her knees. And finally, the main content of her beautiful look, her pink hoodie. My door light was shining on her face, and Sarah was glowing. Because of her rage and the cold winter air, her face had turned pink. Pink hoodie, pink face, and pink lips. She was all pink. Her eyes, on the other hand, told a different story; they were enraged, restless, and ready to spit out whatever Sarah was holding in her heart.

She pushed me back, placed her shoes on the footwear rack, and walked into the house. I went to take her scooter because it was parked outside the gate. She had left the keys in, most likely for me. I parked her scooter beside mine and locked the main gate. I was frightened to walk into my own house. Somehow, I gathered the courage.

When I walked in, she was sitting on the sofa, finishing the remaining milk in my glass. Her gaze was fixed on the television. I strolled quietly to the opposite corner of the sofa, and she didn't even glance at me. Minutes passed, and angry Sarah didn't even say a single word. I looked at the wall clock, and the hour hand was just near eleven.

'Sarah,' I tried to initiate the conversation.

'Who do you think you are? You ignored my calls; how dare you do that?' she asked, turning her face towards me angrily.

'I was a bit agitated, and I... I'm sorry, Sarah. I shouldn't have phoned you,' I explained.

My overwrought emotions had returned to normal, and I had realised that whatever had happened was my fault. I should not have called her, should not have talked to her in that manner, and should not have ignored her calls. I took advantage of her ease. It was all my fault; I felt I didn't deserve the right to call her anytime I wanted.

'I'm not angry about it; the problem is you ignored my calls, and I had to come here to talk,' she remarked, again staring at the television.

'I should not have been so irresponsible. I am really sorry,' I whispered, and her countenance softened.

Sarah pressed the red button on the remote, and the television turned off. She got up from the single-seat sofa and sat close to me on the main couch. I had no idea what was going to happen. She held both my hands in hers and kept looking into my eyes.

She kept gazing, and I began to melt from within, her deep eyes engulfing me. I didn't know if it was perfume, powder, or whatever she had put on her body, or if it was simply the scent of Sara. It was just heavenly.

'What?' I asked, blinking.

'What happened?' she inquired, not even closing her eyes for a microsecond.

'What?' I inquired, perplexed.

She let go of my hands and turned to face the television, which she had just turned off. She took a deep breath. All of that was extremely complicated for me.

'You know what, Mr Lawyer?' she said.

'What?' I completed my hat trick of 'what's.'

'This was the third time we discussed my marriage. The first time was on the train; the second time was in the garden; and the third time was just now when you phoned me,' Sarah elaborated.

'It was frustrating every time,' I wanted to say.

'Hmm' was my reply.

'The first time we talked about it, you were uncomfortable; the second time, you lost your cool; and the third time, I presume it happened because you were thinking about the second time. Am I right?' Sarah asked.

I was stunned and didn't know what to say.

'I…' I started, with nothing to say.

'See, Adi, I know you better than you know yourself, so please don't attempt to lie,' she said, and she was right.

'I just don't feel good talking about that,' I confessed, and I decided to answer her questions honestly.

'What's the harm? Don't you think you should be glad as a friend if your friend is eager to marry? Isn't this excellent news?' Sarah questioned, her head nodding in agreement.

'Yes, I should be happy,' I replied like a kid while looking at the floor.

'Tell me the problem, then,' she asked.

'I'm not sure; I'm not feeling well. I can't imagine you marrying or being with someone else. I hate that thought,' I said, expressing my feelings and immediately questioning myself about whether I had done the right thing.

'Do you know what the emotion you're getting is called?' Sarah asked, and I had no clue where it was going.

This was the most heated and serious debate we'd ever had. Her tone changed, and she appeared enraged. All that made me feel like I was meddling with her life. I was afraid, and I wanted

her to forget everything and just be Sara, but it did not appear to be an option.

'What?' I asked, making an expressionless face. That discussion was killing me.

'INSECURITY,' she remarked.

'Hmm,' I said and nodded.

'Why are you insecure about my marriage? Do you like me?' Sarah asked, and I mistook it for a straightforward query.

'Of course,' I said.

'Not in that way. Let me ask you directly, Adi. Do you love me?' she asked in an inquisitive tone.

Her expression wasn't the prettiest as she asked it. Sitting there was getting difficult for me. Sarah was torturing me in my own home, and she seemed to be ready with a series of questions.

'What? Have you gone crazy today?' was my reaction.

I was shocked when she asked that question; I never expected it from her.

'So, you don't love me?' she asked.

'Not the way you are asking, definitely not,' I replied convincingly.

Everyone in the room except me and Sarah was convinced.

'Okay,' she said and smiled, but that wasn't the end of the discussion. The next question was coming.

'How do you know that you don't love me?'

'What is this question, Sara? And stop it right now. Don't overdo it now. It's eleven o'clock; you should return,' I stated solemnly.

'Do you mind if I sleep here tonight?' she asked.

She knew she didn't have to ask. But her demeanour had changed that day, and she was not in the mood to unwind. She had come to my house with a predetermined plan.

'no,' I replied.

'Is there a girl in your life who is more important than me?' was her next question.

I got up from the couch and headed into the kitchen, saying, 'I'm not answering your ridiculous questions. Sleep now, wherever you want.'

'I'm not going to sleep, Adi, until I have my answers,' Sarah said.

I turned back.

'This is the first time you've thought about it, but I think about it every day. Please let me get this cleared,' Sarah requested.

I could sense a storm brewing in my life. One thing was certain: our relationship was never going to be the same again, and I hated that fact.

I came back and sat on the sofa. I decided to cooperate.

'No, there is no girl more precious to me than you,' I said, and there was a beautiful smile on her face.

'Do you care for me?'

'More than I care for myself,' I replied.

'Now be honest, how will you feel if you see me marrying someone else?' she asked, and this time I decided not to hold it back.

'Jealous, destroyed, fucked,' I said, and I saw her eyes lighting up.

Sarah slid back on the couch and changed her position. She picked up her legs from the couch and placed them on me. She used the armrest of the sofa as her headrest and closed her eyes.

'You looooooooove me, Mr Lawyer. You fucking love me,' she said clearly.

She was simply taking a break before asking the next set of questions. I knew the conversation wasn't over, but she dozed off, which was the best thing for me.

I brought a pillow and positioned it under her head. I then covered her with a blanket. She had a smile on her face even though she was sleeping.

CHAPTER

25

I had spent the whole night sleeping on the chair-couch. When I woke up, Sarah was lying on the couch, looking at me.

'I'm sorry,' she said.

'What do you mean, sorry? Were you drunk last night? Do you even remember what you said?' I asked, rubbing my eyes.

'First of all, I wasn't drunk. And secondly, I'm not sorry for saying any of that. I'm sorry for falling asleep without finishing our conversation,' she clarified, resting her head against the armrest.

'OK, listen. This is no longer funny. Stop this nonsense.' I tried to sound as serious as possible.

'See? You're acting as if you're furious, but you're not.' She chuckled, and I couldn't help laughing.

'Shut up and go to the hostel,' I said, getting out of the chair and grabbing her blanket. She rolled into the cushion and buried her face in it.

'I'm not going anywhere. I've brought my clothes. Open the boot of my scooter and take out the yellow bag,' Sarah instructed.

I'd assumed she had simply fallen asleep the previous night and couldn't return to the hostel because of that. But no, everything had been planned.

'Seriously?' I asked.

'I'm in no mood to joke,' she said, her face still turned towards the back of the sofa.

I went outside and opened the dickey of her scooter. Sure enough, she had brought her clothes with her. I carried her bag into the bedroom and brushed my teeth. When I returned, Sarah was still on the couch.

'Get up, Sarah. We have a lot of work to do,' I said.

'Adi, you have no idea how good I feel right now. I'm almost certain that you love me,' she said.

Did that mean she loved me too?

'Shut the fuck up,' I said, pulling her off the couch. She stood up and gave me a cute little smile. I turned her towards the bedroom and kept pushing her like a luggage trolley until she reached the bed.

'Here's your bag. Go brush your teeth. I'm making breakfast for you,' I instructed her.

She finally moved.

I took three eggs out of the refrigerator. Since I was cooking for Sarah, I decided to make omelettes. I beat the eggs thoroughly, mixed in the filling, and set the mixture aside. Then I melted some butter in a non-stick skillet and made two excellent omelettes. I always kept bread in the refrigerator, so I added some butter to the toast, and breakfast was ready.

Sarah was singing in the bathroom, and the sound of running water told me she was taking a bath. I set the food on the table and waited for her.

Ten minutes later, she made a magnificent entrance from my bedroom. She was wearing a grey crop top and skinny black pants. Her hair was still damp, giving her a raw, gorgeous look.

'I've decided not to trouble you anymore,' she announced.

'Thank you, thank you, thank you, Sarah!' I said with a sigh of relief.

'OK, OK. Don't overact now,' she said, making a face.

Sarah was back to her usual self. Somehow, I had started to fear this loving, cute version of her. The serious, angry Sarah was far easier to deal with.

She took her seat and began eating in silence.

'You cook really well. You'll make a great husband,' she said.

I looked at her, puzzled, which made her laugh.

'In general. Don't take it the wrong way,' she said, laughing again.

We finished our breakfast in silence. Sarah was giving me a strange vibe. Something was wrong with her. No, actually, something was very right with her. She was ecstatic, practically bouncing in her seat and giggling to herself. The real tragedy was that she had completely forgotten about the case.

'What do you think we should do now?' I asked, clearing the plates from the table.

She was busy examining her nails.

'I think we should give you some time to think about it. I understand. You're shocked, and it's difficult,' she replied sympathetically.

'I'm talking about Divya, Sarah. Please stop this and focus on the case,' I said, folding my hands.

My unexpectedly loud voice caught her off guard. She sat up properly and finally looked away from her nails. I knew they were lovely, but this was hardly the time to admire them.

'OK, OK. Sorry. Yes, I think this is the right time to speak to Divya. But definitely not at her place,' Sarah suggested.

It was difficult to get the better of Divya in her clinic. She had created an artificial atmosphere there that seemed to give her complete control over everyone who walked in.

'I agree. But where should we meet her?' I asked.

Several places came to mind: the garden near Divya's clinic, a café, or a shopping mall. We had plenty of options, but I wanted to handle everything as discreetly as possible. What we were about to do wasn't exactly something people would approve of.

'The place is secondary. First, tell me why she would agree to meet us,' Sarah said.

'She might have agreed to meet us last time if you'd behaved yourself in her clinic,' I remarked.

I said it mainly to embarrass Sarah a little more. Besides, I had secretly enjoyed watching her do what she did that day.

'I have no regrets. I still remember her cutting tone,' Sarah replied.

'And I think what she said in that tone might actually help us now. She'll meet us if we tell her we're willing to lose the case in exchange for money.'

I was guessing the highest amount she might offer me to lose the very first case of my life.

'Hmm, she will,' Sarah replied, moving her eyes and lower lip in appreciation.

Thankfully, she seemed to have forgotten all about her favourite topic: love.

'OK, now think. Where should we meet her?' I asked.

Sarah got up from her chair and settled onto the couch. I stepped behind her to see what she was doing as she took out her phone. She had opened Maps and was searching for a suitable meeting place.

We needed somewhere quiet, with fewer people and no cameras. A place where we could have complete control over the situation.

After considering our options, I settled on Pureaty Café, about a kilometre from Divya's clinic. Sarah and I were regular visitors there, so it seemed like an ideal location.

'Pureaty?' I asked, standing behind her.

I leaned closer to speak, and the smell of my shampoo drifted from her hair. Somehow, it had never smelled that good before.

'No. It's too open for a conversation like that. I have a much better place in mind,' she murmured, turning her face towards me.

'And that is?' I asked, curious and expecting a genuinely clever answer.

'Here,' Sarah said, pointing down.

'My house?' I asked, unsure whether she was serious.

'Yes. We can talk properly here. And if she starts talking shit again, I can slap her right here,' Sarah said.

She began with excitement but finished with anger. Meeting Divya at my house was actually a good idea. The only problem was Sarah. If she lost control, I could end up with another murder case on my hands.

'That will work only if you're not here,' I said.

Sarah rolled her eyes. My suggestion made absolutely no sense to her. In her mind, she was the most important person in the entire plan.

'What? I can't leave you alone with that thing! She's dangerous, Adi. She can do anything. She's connected to murder and drugs, and she even offers lawyers money to lose cases. You'll need my protection. I can't take that risk,' Sarah said in a phoney tone.

She knew perfectly well that I didn't need her there.

'I'm sure you'll screw things up. Your blood will boil the moment you see her, and you'll start fighting with her. That's it. You're not going to be there,' I told her firmly.

'I promise I won't say a word. Not even a single word,' Sarah pleaded, holding my hand and making the cutest face she could manage.

I reconsidered.

'Fine. But you won't say anything, promise?'

'Promise!' she said happily.

'You always listen to me because you love me,' Sarah added, flashing her teeth at me.

I shook my head.

'Not again, Sarah,' I muttered as I walked into my bedroom.

My computer table was covered in dust. I hadn't used my PC in a long time. Life had become significantly more stressful since the case began. I'd stopped watching movies and web series, and I hadn't played basketball since the day I met Ayushi.

I'd completely lost my peace of mind. I missed the life I'd been living just a few days earlier.

I took the microfibre cloth I'd stashed in the drawer of my computer table and began cleaning the monitor, keyboard, and mouse. Then I turned on the computer and started going through my old notes and Word documents.

'Sarah!' I shouted.

'Coming!' she called back before entering my bedroom.

'Yes, Mr. Lawyer?' she asked.

The words Mr. Lawyer had started sounding different ever since she'd said, 'You love me, Mr. Lawyer.'

'Do you have the memory card?' I asked.

'Of course,' she said with a smile, pulling her phone out of the pocket of her tight jeans.

She removed the back cover and took out the memory card. I stared at her in disbelief, making a face.

'This is the most expensive thing we have right now, and you're carrying it in the back cover of your phone?' I asked.

'It's a safe place, Adi. I would have lost it if it weren't safe.'

'But, Sarah, what if it gets scratched and stops working? We'll lose all the data. What will you do then?' I scolded her.

'Then we'll message her again,' she replied, laughing.

She found her own joke so funny that she kept laughing until she fell onto the bed.

I ignored her and plugged the SD card into the connector attached to the computer. I accessed its contents and found the three screenshots. I copied them onto my phone. This time, I wasn't taking any chances by letting Sarah keep the memory card. I put it safely in the drawer instead.

'What is this?' Sarah asked.

She was sitting beside my pillow, holding a book. It was the same book Ayushi had returned to me after reading it.

Confused, I looked at her. She pulled a small piece of paper out of the book and held it up for me to see.

'What is it?' I asked.

Sarah gave me a sceptical look.

'What, Sarah? What is that?' I asked again.

I got up from the chair and took the paper from her. It was a small sheet with something written on it in beautiful handwriting.

Hii Jack,

Why are you not visiting the hospital? Is Goa that lovely? By the way, you didn't tell me about what was in the letter Jack wrote for Lily but couldn't give her.

I read it and turned towards Sarah. She was staring at me, waiting for an explanation.

'I don't know what this is,' I replied confidently, despite the fear creeping through me.

'What don't you know about? The letter itself, or what's written in it?' she asked calmly.

Her voice was low, and she was clearly disappointed.

'Sarah, calm down. It's not like that,' I tried to explain.

She stood up and came towards me until her face was barely three inches from mine.

She looked straight into my eyes.

'Then tell me what it is,' she murmured.

I took both her hands in mine and gently made her sit on the cot. Then I knelt in front of her, still holding her hands. I could see the fire in her eyes and the dryness of her lips.

She was feeling the same way I had the previous night.

'This is the first time I've seen this paper. You saw it before I did,' I explained.

'How dare she write that to you? You must have done something before this. What did you do? What is going on?' Sarah demanded.

I could see the sweat on her brow.

'It's nothing, Sarah. It's just a simple story. Jack, Lily, and all that! Ayushi is immature. Don't make an issue out of it,' I said, trying to calm her down.

'I'm making an issue out of it? You know what, Adi? You've been hiding things from me ever since she entered our lives,' Sarah said angrily.

'But, Sarah…'

'And who the fuck are Jack and Lily?' she demanded, punching the cushion.

I was still kneeling in front of her.

'Just calm down. She's much younger than us. She's childish,' I tried to explain.

'Bloody criminal,' Sarah muttered through clenched teeth.

'Shut up, Sarah,' I said.

A tear rolled down her cheek. She stood up and stormed out of the room.

I followed her towards the door. She was moving unusually fast.

'Stop, Sarah! You can't just leave like that!' I shouted.

She didn't respond. Instead, she opened the main door of my house.

'We have things to do, Sarah, and I can't do any of it without you. What about our meeting with Divya?'

By the time I finished speaking, Sarah was already putting on her slippers.

'Fuck Divya, fuck Ayushi, and fuck you, Adi!' she shouted as she walked away.

I watched her ride off on her scooter until she disappeared from sight.

'Ayushi, you should not have done that,' I screamed to no one.

ACT 4:

THE TRUTH

CHAPTER

26

Later that day, I tried calling Sarah several times, but she didn't answer. After thinking it over for an hour, I decided to meet Divya alone. I was ready to handle the conversation on my own.

I picked up my phone and called Divya, but she didn't answer either. She returned my call about thirty minutes later.

I took a deep breath. I was about to lie, and that required a certain level of mental preparation. I was a good lawyer but a terrible negotiator and an even worse blackmailer. Unfortunately, blackmailing Divya was exactly what I intended to do.

I knew it wouldn't be easy. Divya was an intelligent woman, and outsmarting her was no easy task.

Her first words were, 'Why are you calling me after everything you did at my clinic?'

She pretended to be angry, but I knew she wasn't. If she had been, she wouldn't have called me back. She wanted to talk to me too, and she wanted to close the deal.

'I want to meet. I've changed my mind,' I said.

There was a pause on the other end. I could guess what she was thinking.

'Don't worry, I'm not recording anything. Hopefully, you're not recording either,' I said.

She seemed to trust me.

'Come to my clinic. Let's clear things up,' she said.

'This time, we'll meet at my house,' I replied.

Divya paused for a few moments before responding.

'It's in an open area, it's completely safe, and I'm a lawyer, not a kidnapper or a murderer.'

My words seemed to make her trust me a little more. She paused again, taking a moment to think before continuing.

'All right, fine. But…'

She was about to say something else.

'I'm not ready for any ifs and buts, madam. Please don't,' I said honestly.

'Listen, I'll come alone, and I want you to be alone too. I don't want that girl there. She's wild,' Divya said.

Hearing her call Sarah that made me a little angry. But this wasn't the time to react.

'She won't be around, I promise,' I said.

'Done. Five in the evening,' Divya said.

Five was a little late for my liking, but I had no problem with it.

'Done,' I replied and hung up.

I opened Telegram. Sarah still hadn't read my messages.

Don't behave like a kid, Sarah. I want to talk. Call me soon.

I sent another message.

Sarah had misunderstood everything. Yes, I had spoken to Ayushi for a while, and we'd had a pleasant conversation. What was so wrong with that?

I checked my phone again. No messages, no missed calls. I decided to give Sarah some space and not call her again until the next day.

I was sitting on the bed, my chin resting in my palms, when I noticed the paper lying on the floor. I had assumed Sarah had taken it with her, but it was still there in my house.

I picked it up and read it several times.

Everything had turned a pale yellow, and the sunlight seemed to bring every little detail into focus. I stood outside, waiting for Divya's white car to appear. She'd asked me to share my location half an hour earlier, but there was still no sign of her.

I was tense. I'd spent the entire afternoon planning what I would say. My phone rang. For a second, I thought it was Sarah, but it was Divya.

'I'm almost there. Stand outside,' she said.

'I'm already out,' I replied before ending the call.

This was going to be the toughest task of the case, and I was doing it alone, without Sarah.

I spotted a white SUV turning towards my house. As it came closer, I recognised Divya behind the wheel. She stopped in front of my gate but didn't get out. Instead, my phone rang again.

'That girl isn't there, right?' she asked.

'She isn't,' I assured her.

Only then did Divya open her car door.

She was dressed entirely in yellow and looked much younger than her actual age. If I ignored the fact that she'd offered me money to lose the case, she seemed like a decent woman. She wasn't directly involved in the drug trade either. If one of my friends were a drug dealer, I might try to convince him to quit, but I wouldn't necessarily report him to the police. Divya had done exactly that.

So, I had no personal issues with her.

'Welcome,' I said with a smile.

A guest was a guest, after all. Even if you planned to blackmail them in the next few minutes, that shouldn't affect your hospitality.

Divya smiled back.

Wasn't that how corruption worked? You met someone, talked, laughed, and then they offered you money. You negotiated a little, and the deal was done.

'Nice house,' she said as she walked in.

Everyone said that when they saw my house for the first time. But Divya wasn't like everyone else. I suspected she'd already started playing her psychological games.

'Stop there,' I said.

She looked confused and froze in place.

'What happened?' she asked.

'Give me your phone.'

I held out my hand.

She laughed.

Mind games, just as I'd expected.

'Come on, you can trust me. Here, take it,' she said, pulling out her phone.

If Sarah had been there, she would probably have conducted a full-body scan to check for cameras and microphones.

I took the phone, switched it off, and gestured for Divya to sit down. I hoped everything would go smoothly.

When I offered her water, she drank the entire glass. Perhaps that was the secret behind her youthful appearance.

I sat next to her.

'Ten lakhs,' she said.

Wow! She was more than ready to pay. Probably even more so after seeing the messages.

For a brief moment, I considered accepting her offer, but that wasn't going to happen. Even if she'd offered me a crore, I would have said no.

I'm not lying.

I didn't want to drag things out, so I took out my phone, opened the screenshots, and handed it to her.

She took the phone and began reading. Her eyes widened at the first message. She went through all three screenshots, reading them over and over again.

When she finally finished, the only word that escaped her mouth was 'Moron.'

She looked at me, then at the phone, and then back at me.

She hadn't expected me to be this smart.

But I was. And I still am.

It didn't take her long to realise that she hadn't come here to negotiate a deal. She'd walked straight into a blackmail attempt.

She took a deep breath and glared at me, her eyes burning with anger.

Unfortunately for her, I was used to that look. Sarah stared at me like that all the time, and Divya's glare wasn't even half as powerful as Sarah's.

Compared to Sarah, facing Divya felt like taking a sip of beer after finishing an entire bottle of rum.

'You called me here for this?' she asked.

'Yes,' I replied calmly.

'What's the point of this? I'm not admitting to anything, even in those chats,' she stated.

'But you're admitting that you knew about it.'

'That won't make a strong case against me. People can say a hundred different things, and your screenshots are useless,' she declared.

Useless?

Did she have any idea how difficult it had been to get those screenshots?

'Madam Divya, I'm not planning to show them to the police. What if I share them with all your contacts instead? What do you think would happen?' I asked, putting on my best villainous voice.

I was doing the cruellest thing I'd ever done in my life. And, to be honest, it wasn't as difficult as I'd imagined.

'I don't care,' she said.

But her face told a different story.

If those chats became public, they could destroy both her personal and professional life.

'You can't prove those are my chats. Fake screenshots can be generated so easily nowadays,' Divya continued.

Her arguments were still strong, but her confidence was beginning to crack. She was frightened, and I suspected she was cursing herself for ever having sent those messages.

'I don't need to prove anything. All I need to do is inform the police. They'll look into Viraj, and let me tell you, the Pune police are quite sharp,' I said.

With every sentence, I sounded more and more like a villain.

'And then there's the public, madam. They don't need proof to blame someone. Society only needs a spark to start a fire. And if people do ask for proof, I have three wonderful screenshots.'

I gestured towards my phone, which was still in her hand.

Divya took a long breath and leaned back in the cushioned chair.

'So, you're blackmailing me?' she asked, forcing a smile.

'Precisely,' I replied.

'How much money do you want?' she asked, finally showing her true colours.

'So, you're afraid of those screenshots. Which means my blackmail is working,' I said with a smile.

I had no idea I could be so evil, wicked, and venomous.

'Indeed. Now name your price and put an end to this nonsense,' she grumbled.

I felt a surge of pride. I'd managed to turn the tables on a psychological expert. I'd practically taught a lion how to hunt.

Getting under Divya's skin and making her angry wasn't everyone's cup of tea.

'You know what, Mrs Batra? You're an intelligent woman. But why aren't you getting this? This isn't about money at all. The fact that you're offering me money makes me feel horrible. Do you really think I'm a corrupt person?'

I couldn't believe how convincingly I was delivering those lines. It felt as though I'd discovered my true calling as a movie villain: a cunning, clever scoundrel who always had complete control over the situation.

'Then what do you want?' she asked.

I was preparing my next thunderous line, wearing what I imagined was an evil smile. Unfortunately, Divya misunderstood it.

'You cheap pervert! Don't even think about that!' she shouted, moving further back into the sofa.

It took me a few seconds to understand what she was thinking.

'What? What the hell are you thinking? I'm blackmailing you, not trying to sleep with you!' I protested, suddenly feeling the need to defend my character.

Just like that, the entire villainous atmosphere I'd created disappeared. I'd managed to ruin my own performance by acting like an amateur.

'Oh, sorry. Tell me what you want, then,' she said.

I took a deep breath, trying to get back into character, but my dramatic flow was gone.

'The same thing you wanted. I want your side to lose the case,' I finally said.

It was the most important sentence I'd planned to deliver that evening.

Divya stared at me without the slightest expression.

'Seriously? But I heard that girl isn't paying you anything,' she said, clearly surprised.

'Everything isn't about money, madam,' I replied, sounding like an underpaid hero.

'Oh, no! You're doing this for that girl, then! You like her. You're attached to her. You love her, perhaps. You care about her. All that bullshit!'

She laughed and rested her right hand against her forehead, while her left hand still held my phone.

'It's not like that,' I tried to explain.

But why was I even trying to explain myself?

'Man! I expected more from you. You're just like all those other young people who fall into these traps. You're neither a

professional blackmailer nor a competent lawyer. You're an emotional idiot.'

She delivered the entire speech with occasional bursts of laughter.

And, annoyingly enough, her words made me think.

Still, I pulled myself together and ignored her.

'At least I'm not a drug dealer,' I replied.

'Listen, Aditya. Don't be foolish. This isn't going anywhere, and that girl will be going to jail soon. Be practical. I'll pay you whatever you want. Take the money and get on with your career.'

She leaned forward in her chair, speaking with an almost sympathetic expression.

'Getting this emotionally involved with a client is unprofessional for a lawyer. This isn't a movie. It's real life. Learn to seize opportunities instead of inviting trouble.'

If she hadn't been on the opposite side, I might actually have listened to her.

'So, you're offering free counselling now?' I asked with a smile.

She shook her head and smiled back.

'You'll regret this,' she said, pointing a finger at me.

'Don't worry about that. I'm good at living with regrets. You should accept my offer if you don't want to live with one yourself,' I replied.

The moment I said it, I realised how stupid it sounded.

But these things happen, especially on your first day of blackmailing.

'That's not going to happen. Losing that case is not an option,' she declared.

'Why? Because he's your friend? So, friendship matters to you too! Ayushi is my friend, and I won't let her go to jail.'

Divya was doing all this for Viraj. I was doing it for Ayushi. At least, that was what I believed.

'I'm not a fool like you. I have nothing to do with that girl. I don't care whether she gets the death penalty or walks free. I'm not interested in revenge. What's done is done, and I want to put an end to it,' Divya said, her gaze fixed on the floor.

'Then why are you going to such lengths?' I asked.

'Because I want to stay out of it, and you should do the same. What's the point of all this? What exactly are you trying to prove?' Divya asked.

I leaned forward.

'That Viraj had a life nobody is talking about.'

She closed her eyes and covered her face with her palms, as if she were sinking into deep thought.

Outside, Pune continued as if nothing were happening. People walked past, cars moved along the roads, and someone was selling vegetables.

Normal life.

Inside my house, I was trying to force the truth out of a woman who knew more than she wanted to admit.

'Divya, I'm not asking you to confess to a murder.'

'I know.'

'I'm asking you to tell me what you know. I'm asking you to give Ayushi another chance.'

She looked at me for a long time.

I looked at her.

Neither of us wanted to blink first.

'You wanted the truth,' she said.

'Yes.'

'You won't like it.'

'That has never stopped me before.'

She smiled faintly, looking down at her hands.

'Viraj was my friend. We studied together. He wasn't always like this.'

'Like what?'

'Whatever he became.'

'Divya, specifics.'

She sighed.

'Viraj started making money very quickly. At first, I didn't know about the drugs. Later, I realised what he was involved in.'

'Then why didn't you tell the police?'

'Because I was afraid.'

'Of Viraj?'

'No. Of the people around him.'

That changed everything. At least for me.

'Who?'

'I don't know all their names. There was a man Viraj used to meet frequently,' she said. She was struggling to explain things, probably because she wasn't in control and wasn't used to being in that position.

'Where?'

'Some village in Goa. He used to disappear there whenever he wanted. He once told me it was the only place where nobody asked questions.'

That matched what Krishna had told us.

'But six months before his death, he stopped going,' she continued. 'He said he was done with everything.'

'Did you believe him?'

'No. People like Viraj don't simply stop.'

'What happened then?'

'His behavior changed. He told me someone was threatening him, but he wouldn't say who.'

'So you knew he was in trouble, and there were problems, yet you still wanted us to let

Ayushi go to jail?'

'Because I knew what you'd find if you kept digging. People much worse than Viraj.

Nothing better. And it'll drag me into it.'

I studied her face.

'And you think Ayushi killed him?'

'I don't know. Maybe.'

It was the first time she'd said that without hiding behind another excuse.

'You were just protecting yourself, then?'

She nodded. Her face paled.

'He was already in a mess. I don't know if she killed him or not.'

My heartbeat quickened.

'Apparently, she did. And who else could it have been?' I said.

'I don't know.'

'You should.'

'I don't know.'

'You have a very impressive vocabulary,' I said, frustrated.

'I'm sorry.'

She wasn't angry. She was scared.

I leaned back into the sofa.

Ayushi had hit him.

But perhaps she hadn't been the reason he died. Perhaps she'd simply been in the wrong place at the worst possible moment.

I pulled out my phone. Still no message from Sarah.

CHAPTER

27

'Who is it?' I asked.

'Hello,' an unclear female voice replied.

I swear, network problems will never disappear. We keep advancing through internet generations without achieving the reliability users actually want.

'Whoever you are, I can't hear you,' I said before cutting the call.

I had just finished dinner after saying goodbye to Divya, and I was growing increasingly restless because Sarah still hadn't contacted me. Every five minutes, I felt tempted to visit her hostel, only to remind myself that she needed space.

Meanwhile, someone kept calling from what seemed like a no-network zone in this overconnected world.

My phone rang again.

'Hello?' I answered, hoping this time I'd hear someone clearly.

'Hey, Krishika here.'

'Oh, so it was you calling. What's up?'

'What time is it?'

'Krishika, this isn't the time to call someone just to ask the time,' I replied, laughing.

'Exactly. And this isn't the time to sit alone on a roadside bench drinking beer.'

My smile vanished.

'What?'

'Do you know where Sarah is?'

'Fuck! Is she drinking?'

'Unfortunately, yes.'

'Where are you? Stop her. Take her back to the hostel.'

'I'm not in the city, Aditya. She's at the place where you two drank together for the first time.'

My hand was already reaching for the scooter keys.

'How do you know all this?'

'She was talking about it on the phone a few minutes ago.'

'Thank you, Krishika.'

She was saying something else, but I'd already hung up.

I grabbed my phone and rushed outside. I didn't even bother locking the front door or closing the main gate. There was no time to waste.

I knew exactly where Sarah was.

Pune has benches along some popular roads, places that are usually deserted at night. You can sit there drinking beer from an open bottle, and nobody knows what you're drinking until they get close enough or you get drunk enough to start singing, dancing, or vomiting.



I spotted Sarah from a distance.

I parked my scooter in front of her and stared. She was wearing the same clothes she'd had on that morning. An empty beer bottle lay on the bench beside her, and she held another in her hand.

She was so drunk that it took her a moment to recognise me.

I approached her and took the bottle. She didn't resist.

Her scooter was nowhere in sight.

'Where's your scooter?' I asked.

'Hostel,' she mumbled.

At least she remembered where she'd left it.

'Come on. Let's go.'

She didn't move or even look at me. Instead, she kept staring at the cement blocks beneath her feet.

'Where?' she asked.

That's when I noticed the scratch on her forehead. Sarah rarely got hurt, and I'd never seen her with an injury before. It was only a minor scratch, but seeing it there made me feel an ache of my own.

I knelt in front of her, placed the bottle down, and gently held her face to examine it. There was no blood, just reddened skin.

'Where the hell did you get hurt?' I scolded her.

She pushed my hands away and looked at me with sad eyes.

I knew I was about to witness her cry for the third time in my life. The first time had been when I got COVID. The second was when her father collapsed because of his high blood pressure.

'Don't touch me. Don't talk to me. And get the fuck out of here.'

'Enough drama, Sarah. Let's go.'

I pointed towards the scooter, but she grabbed my finger and bent it with all her strength.

‘Drama? You did everything! You talked to her without telling me, you're getting letters from her, and you're hiding things from me. God knows what else you're doing!’

Her voice broke, and she burst into tears.

I held her face again, trying to calm her down.

‘It was nothing important, Sarah. Just a normal conversation.’

‘Is it wrong that I want to know everything about you?’

She was sobbing uncontrollably. Her cheeks felt freezing beneath my hands. Only then did I realise neither of us was wearing a jacket or sweater.

‘Not at all. And you do know everything about me.’

That was true. She knew practically every little thing about my life.

‘Not about the letter.’

‘First, stop calling it a letter. It was just a piece of paper.’

I wiped away her tears. Seeing Sarah cry was one of the worst things I could imagine, and I never wanted to be the reason for it.

‘I don't want to talk to you. Leave.’

She wasn't ready to listen, no matter what I said.

‘Sarah, please.’

I took her hands in mine.

‘Leave,’ she repeated, sniffling.

Her face was red, and her eyes looked exhausted.

‘I'm not leaving you here alone.’

I lifted her hands and rested my face against them.

‘Why? Because you love me?’

I was surprised she was still thinking about that. I stayed quiet.

'Actually, Adi, you were right. You don't.'

Her tears started flowing again.

I felt helpless. She wasn't listening, and I had no idea how to make things right.

'Sarah, we can talk about all this later. Please come with me now. Please. Please.'

'You leave. I'll go to my hostel.'

'Your hostel is three kilometres away. You've had almost two beers, and you can't even walk properly. You're not making it ten steps. Clearly, you don't tolerate alcohol very well.'

I picked up the bottle to make my point.

'Let me show you.'

She stood up and staggered through five unsteady steps.

I looked around. Thankfully, nobody was there to witness this disaster.

I made her sit down again and thought for a moment.

Then I picked up the bottle and took a gulp.

'You vomit after drinking,' she said.

'I know. Now you're coming with me, or I'm finishing this.'

She tried to stand and grab the bottle, but I gently pushed her back onto the bench.

'Don't be stupid! You promised me you'd never drink unless I was drinking with you!' 'And look at yourself. I'm not breaking that promise at all.'

I took another gulp.

'Adiii, I'm coming! Stop! Don't drink it!'

'Promise?'

'Yes, I promise. Now put that bottle down!'

'You won't break your promise, right?'

'I'm not like you,' she snapped.

She was furious, but it worked. She'd agreed to come with me.

I picked up the empty bottle, walked over to the blue dustbin behind the benches, and threw both bottles away.

'Let's go.'

I started the scooter.

'Bloody blackmailer,' she muttered as she climbed on.

I was, admittedly, getting better at it. I took that as a compliment.

'Sit properly.'

She wrapped her arms tightly around me and rested her face on my shoulder.

I smiled and began the slowest ride of my life.

It took us twenty-five minutes to reach my house because I drove ridiculously slowly.

Thankfully, I'd left the gate open. I parked the scooter and got off, but Sarah remained seated, her eyes half-closed.

She looked utterly exhausted.

'Come on, let's go inside.'

'I can't walk.'

'Then at least get down.'

She tried, but the alcohol made even that difficult. I helped her off the scooter, slipped one arm behind her thighs and the other around her back, and lifted her into my arms.

She simply smiled.

I carried her inside and settled her on the sofa. She immediately stretched out and closed her eyes.

After securing the scooter and locking the doors, I returned to find her exactly where I'd left her.

'Have you eaten anything?'

'Yes.'

She didn't even open her eyes.

'What?'

'Omelettes. The ones you made for me.'

'That was at nine in the morning, brainless girl.'

I somehow managed to get her to eat some noodles. She was exhausted, and I wasn't about to let her go to sleep on an empty stomach.

The two nights had been remarkably similar. The difference was that the first night she'd only pretended to be drunk. This time, she actually was.

'Adi,' Sarah whispered, her eyes still closed.

'Yes?'

'Promise me you'll tell me every little thing.'

'I promise.'

She smiled.

'You can sleep in the bedroom,' she added, turning onto her side. 'There's no need to sit here and stare at me all night.'

She pulled the blanket over her face.

I sat in the sofa chair and kept staring at her.

CHAPTER

28

Sarah wasn't in her spot when I woke up the next morning, and I panicked for a moment. I thought she'd gone out again after I'd fallen asleep. But then I heard noises coming from the kitchen and realised she was there. The image of a drunk Sarah was still fresh in my mind, so I hurried to the kitchen to see what she was up to.

'Good morning, Mister Lawyer,' she said when she saw me.

There was no hangover, just a bright and cheerful Sarah. The anger, complaints, and tears were all gone, and I was glad to see them go. She had a spatula in her hand and was stirring something in a pan.

'Good morning, you junky. Would you like wine, rum, or your favourite beer for breakfast?'

It was my turn to be angry, so I couldn't resist the sarcastic remark. How dare she drink without me?

'Nothing, just some noodles. I've learned how to prepare them properly now,' she said.

She clearly didn't want to talk about last night and was looking for a way out. That explained why she'd woken up before me, cleaned the house, and started making noodles. She probably thought she could get away with everything by keeping herself busy.

Unfortunately for her, I wasn't ready to let it go.

'I'm not interested in your noodles. How could you drink without telling me, Sarah?' I asked.

She switched off the burner and walked towards me.

'I'm sorry. I didn't intend to drink so much,' she said.

'That's why you bought two beers,' I remarked.

'I'm sorry. Don't be angry now,' she pleaded, making a face.

I wasn't going to melt that easily.

'You've made so many mistakes that I don't even know where to start,' I said.

'I'm listening,' she said, lowering her head.

'You were angry because I didn't tell you about Ayushi and that shitty conversation.

You accused me of hiding things from you.'

'I still think you were hiding things from me. Do it again, and I'll repeat all of this,' she said confidently.

She could be such a kid sometimes.

'And drinking alone on the roadside without telling me was perfectly fine?'

'Not at all, Adi. I'm really sorry about that. I was sad and angry with you, so I went back to my hostel and left my scooter there. Then I went to the bus station near my hostel, boarded a random bus, bought a day pass, and spent the entire day switching buses for no reason. Somehow, I ended up in Deccan, and by then, it was already dark. I saw a wine shop, bought two beers, and eventually ended up drinking at our usual spot.'

Sarah explained everything, finally putting my suspicion that she'd lost her mind to rest.

Seriously, who does that? Who wanders around the city all day out of anger? And on PMT buses, of all things?

'Sarah, you need treatment,' I said, leaving the kitchen.

She followed me into the hall, caught my hand, and made me sit on the sofa.

Was this something only we did, or was it normal for couples to kneel down when apologising? We weren't a couple, by the way.

'Listen, say whatever you want, but don't just walk away like that. I know I've done a lot wrong. You can scold me for it or even slap me if you want,' Sarah said.

That made me laugh. I gave her the gentlest slap imaginable. Even a baby would have laughed at it.

Sarah hid her face in my lap.

'My father will call his police friends, and they'll break your ass if I tell him about this,' she said.

Her face was still pressed against my thighs, and I could feel her laughing. I leaned forward and rested my head on hers. She stopped laughing and fell silent.

'Never do that again. I was scared,' I said.

She lifted her head and held my face in her hands. Her hands were really small and soft.

'Never again,' she promised.

We stared at each other until the doorbell rang and ruined our moment. We pulled apart, a little embarrassed, and Sarah went to answer the door.

A delivery boy stood outside with a package. He handed it to Sarah, and she thanked him.

I knew exactly what was inside.

The book. The one I'd ordered for Ayushi at the hospital the previous day.

Things were finally settling down between Sarah and me, and now this book had arrived to complicate everything.

Why so fast, Amazon? Why so fast?

'What's this?' Sarah asked, looking for the product name on the receipt.

For some reason, I wanted to tell her before she could read it herself.

'It's a book, Sarah. Ayushi asked me to order it yesterday,' I said.

Shit, shit, shit.

I wasn't deliberately hiding anything. Things just kept happening, and somehow, I kept finding myself in situations I knew Sarah wouldn't like.

'Oh,' she said.

I waited for her reaction, but she had another question.

'What's the name, by the way?'

She looked at the receipt. I froze.

'Look, Sarah, I was going to tell you about going to the hospital and the...'

Before I could finish, she hurried towards me and wrapped her arms around me.

For the first time in five years, Sarah Kolan hugged Aditya Chauhan.

She held me tightly, and I wrapped my arms around her.

'You don't have to explain everything to me. It's okay, and it's good that you ordered a book for her. Please don't explain it. I feel terrible. I shouldn't have behaved the way I did yesterday. I should have trusted you more,' she said, still holding me.

Once again, she'd reminded me that nobody understood me quite like she did.

I hugged her even tighter and said nothing.

'Sorry. It ends here,' I whispered.

'Hmm,' she murmured, resting her head on my shoulder.

We stood there for about two minutes before finally pulling apart. We were both smiling.

'Oh, my noodles! Let me finish them,' Sarah said, hurrying back to the kitchen.

I went to the bathroom and brushed my teeth, wondering if I should have drunk a little more beer the previous night. Then I took a shower and changed into a shirt and jeans. I don't wear shirts very often, by the way.

When I entered the dining room, Sarah was waiting for me at the table with a huge bowl of noodles in front of her. She handed me a spoon and a fork as I sat down.

'Where's yours?' I asked, noticing there was only one bowl on the table.

'This is ours. Why use so many utensils? Save water, save energy,' she said with a giggle.

I picked up some noodles with my fork. They were genuinely good.

That was the first time Sarah had prepared something that actually tasted this good.

'It's good,' I said.

Apparently, that wasn't enough. She'd put a lot of effort into making them.

'Just good?' she asked.

'Amazing, Sarah, amazing. I swear, I haven't eaten better noodles than these. I mean, it's unbelievable. How can someone make such good food?'

'Thank you, thank you!' she exclaimed, and we both chuckled.

She joined me in eating, eventually finishing more than sixty per cent of the bowl. She'd prepared it herself, after all.

'When are we meeting Divya?' she asked, getting back to work.

'I met her yesterday,' I said with a chuckle.

I finished my breakfast and grabbed a tissue to wipe my hands. Sarah's eyes widened, and a huge smile spread across her face. My grin had given away that the meeting had gone well.

'Really? Where?' she asked, taking the bowl to clear the table.

'Here,' I said, pointing down.

'How did it go? What did the bitch say? Did you frighten her? Oh my goodness, I've missed so much! That might have been the best moment of my life. Adi, you should have waited for me!'

Sarah hated Divya and would have loved to watch her squirm.

'Listen,' I said.

I narrated the entire meeting, conveniently skipping the part where Divya had mistaken my villainous expression for sexual interest and called me a pervert. I also exaggerated how frightened she'd been, mostly to entertain Sarah.

She listened eagerly, thoroughly enjoying the story.

'So, she's still not convinced?' Sarah asked, taking a sip of water.

She drank water by chewing it. It took her an entire minute to finish a glass, whereas I could empty one in three seconds. She kept telling me to drink more slowly, but I could never manage it.

'Not yet. She wants some time, and that's okay too,' I said.

Sarah nodded.

'By the way, Sarah, she's not a bad person. She's just in a difficult situation.'

'Ayushi is in an even worse situation. Why isn't she doing any of these things?'

Sarah was convinced that Divya was an evil woman who deserved to rot in hell.

'Because we're doing that part for her. I'm a lawyer, I'm sending fake messages, I'm lying to people, and now I'm blackmailing people too,' I said.

'You're her lawyer. What am I doing all this for?' Sarah asked, laughing.

I joined her. That was what we called laughing at destruction. We had absolutely no reason to find any of it funny.

'Where's the memory card?' Sarah asked, suddenly remembering something important.

'Safer than it was before,' I replied.

'Come on, the back cover was safe too.'

'Forget that. I think we should go to the hospital,' I suggested.

'How can we? I haven't taken a bath yet, and my clothes still smell like beer,' she said.

'Bloody drunkard,' I said, throwing a pillow at her.

'Why didn't you take a bath, then?' I asked.

'I don't have any clothes here. I should keep a couple of pairs here.'

'Exactly. So, what now?'

'Now you'll drop me at the hostel and wait until I get dressed. Then we'll go to the hospital,' Sarah said, getting up.

'No way. I'm not going to wait there with your gateman.'

She burst out laughing.

CHAPTER

29

We reached Sarah's hostel around ten in the morning. A young girl staying out all night and returning to the hostel at ten in the morning didn't meet the watchman's criteria for a good girl.

Sarah understood that too and gave no fucks about it. She got off the scooter and entered through the hostel's main gate. I was definitely not going to stand around with the gateman, so I started my scooter and headed to a nearby café. I ordered a hot chocolate and messaged Sarah, asking her to call me when she was ready.

As I took my seat, I opened Instagram on my phone. Ronny's feed was filled with red hearts. The kid had posted two more videos, but neither had the smooth lighting of a ring light. In small villages, home delivery takes a few extra days.

As I scrolled through his feed, I came across several hilarious memes. Then I glanced at the arrow icon that opened conversations. I quickly remembered that I'd promised him I wouldn't check his chats. But I couldn't stop myself and tapped the icon. It showed twenty-three new messages.

I wasn't going to open any of them, so I continued scrolling.

The first message was from a boy, the second from a girl, the third from another girl, and so on. Ronny was on fire.

I scrolled further down and discovered that he'd messaged Virat Kohli, demanding that he score a hundred international centuries as soon as possible. I laughed when I saw that. I

remembered messaging several Facebook celebrities when I was a teenager. Ronny was way ahead of me.

My phone vibrated.

'I'm done. Where are you?' Sarah asked.

'Snowballs. I'm coming in a minute,' I replied.

'No, no. Stay there. I'm coming. I badly need a coffee.'

'Cool. Come soon,' I said before she hung up.

Sarah arrived two minutes later, wearing an oversized blue T-shirt and body-hugging black leggings. Her hair was tied into a perfect ponytail with a rubber band, and she looked fabulous.

As she approached the counter to order her coffee, I caught sight of the back of her Tshirt. The word 'Weirdo' was emblazoned across it in large white letters.

She placed her order and walked towards me.

'Wow,' I said.

Sarah didn't know how to handle compliments, so she laughed in response.

'Is it looking good?' she asked, chuckling.

'Extremely good. But we're going to the hospital, and those are gym clothes,' I remarked.

'Exactly! I saw a girl going to the gym wearing something similar, so I bought a pair for myself too. Now, as you know, I don't go to the gym, so I'm wearing them today,' she said.

I laughed.

'Your coffee. Anything else?' the waitress asked, placing Sarah's coffee on the table.

I shook my head.

Sarah kept smiling at me. She was still happy about the compliment I'd given her. She held her coffee cup in both hands.

It covered half her face, and she kept looking at me over the rim as she took small sips.

'Do you hate me?' she asked, lowering her cup.

'Not at all. Why would you even ask that?' I replied, smiling and widening my eyes.

'That means you love me,' she said before bringing the cup back to her mouth.

'I don't hate anybody except your watchman,' I said.

She burst out laughing with coffee still in her mouth. And then, predictably, disaster struck. The sugary, milky caffeine went down the wrong pipe, and she started coughing.

I was behind her the very next second, one hand on her head and the other on her back, gently patting her.

She turned around, grinning widely.

'See? You love me.'

'Let's go,' I said, rolling my eyes.

Sarah was all smiles. She paid the bill and bought some doughnuts too. I raised an eyebrow, silently asking why.

'For Ayushi,' she said.

I smiled at that.

We headed to the hospital.

We arrived soon enough. I knew Ayushi would ask me about that piece of paper, and I wasn't ready for the conversation. So I decided not to give her the chance to bring it up.

I had noticed that Sarah behaved differently depending on where she was. In cafés and hotels, she walked around like a princess, looking effortlessly cool. But the moment we entered a hospital or a police station, her whole attitude changed. She'd straighten her face, take off her sunglasses with a dramatic little

flourish, and walk in as if she owned the place. She didn't seem to care what anyone thought of her.

Around elders like the Sinha couple or Ayushi's parents, though, she was a completely different person. She'd smile sweetly and speak so politely that you'd never guess she was the same girl who acted like she owned the world everywhere else.

The moment we entered the hospital, Sarah's expression changed. She put on her usual serious face and walked ahead of me, as if she'd come alone. When she spotted the constable outside the room, she took off her sunglasses and walked straight in without even greeting him.

Yes, Sarah could be arrogant at times. She hadn't even bothered to greet the constable, who was actually helping us with the case.

I greeted him, at least, before following Sarah into the room.

'Where were you?' Ayushi asked as Sarah walked in.

'Work, work, work. How are you doing?' Sarah asked with a smile.

You wouldn't have guessed anything was wrong just by looking at her. She was smiling as if everything were perfectly fine.

'Good,' Ayushi replied, turning to me with a smile. I smiled back.

Sarah then handed Ayushi the doughnuts she'd bought. Ayushi peeked inside the packet and smiled before setting it aside.

'Adi, do you think this will work?' she asked, looking at me with a mixture of hope and worry. She had been informed about the progress with Divya.

'Of course, it will. She's freaked out,' Sarah answered again.

I looked at her.

Was Sarah deliberately answering every question meant for me? I couldn't tell, but she'd done it twice already, and I was beginning to notice.

'It's been over a week, and you're still running around for me,' Ayushi said, lowering her eyes. She seemed genuinely sorry for troubling us so much.

'Oh, shut up. Don't be so formal. He's a lawyer. This is his job, and I'm his tail,' Sarah said with a smile.

What was that supposed to mean?

'I still want to thank you,' Ayushi said, smiling at her.

'This book,' I said, handing her the Amazon package.

'You have no idea how desperately I've wanted to read this,' Ayushi said, immediately getting to work on the packaging.

She attacked it with such ferocity that if we'd tried to return it, the delivery boy would probably have refused to accept it and filed a cruelty complaint against us. She tore through the plastic as if she'd been starving for days.

And inside were the dhoklas.

I used dhokla because Ayushi was Gujarati. Am I stereotyping? Possibly.

She pulled the book out and began flipping through the pages. Then she took out the invoice, folded it neatly, and used it as a bookmark. She did everything with the ease of a professional.

I turned towards Sarah.

She was staring at Ayushi without the slightest expression on her face.

Something had changed. Sarah had been perfectly normal until we'd entered the room, but now she seemed different. Perhaps seeing Ayushi had reminded her of that whole paper incident.

She was still trying to keep the conversation going, but I could tell something was bothering her. Every now and then, she'd look at me, and I knew that look.

'When was the last time you saw your parents?' Sarah asked.

Ayushi looked up from her book.

How was that even possible? How could someone get so absorbed in a book that the rest of the world simply disappeared?

'Yesterday,' she replied.

'Hmm,' Sarah said.

And that was pretty much how the conversation went after that. Someone would say something every few seconds, and the other two would try to respond. Nobody seemed to know what to talk about, and the silence between our sentences was becoming unbearable.

I wanted to get out of there.

So I took out my phone and messaged Sarah.

Let's go.

You get up first, she replied.

Tell her we're leaving.

How would I?

'You guys are messaging each other?' Ayushi asked.

She was laughing. Sarah and I, on the other hand, were thoroughly embarrassed. We'd done this hundreds of times before, but Ayushi was the first person to catch us.

'No, actually...' I started, trying to come up with an explanation.

'See, I can't give you any privacy because I can't get out of here. So, if you want to talk, go outside and talk,' she said, laughing.

That only made things worse.

‘Ayushi, we do have some work. I know we've only just arrived, but can we leave now?’ Sarah asked calmly.

Now that is how you handle an embarrassing situation. You either accept it or laugh along. Trying to cover it up only makes things worse.

‘Of course, you can. You're not useless like me,’ Ayushi said with a laugh.

Neither of us knew what to say.

‘You can laugh too,’ she added.

We tried.

‘Take care,’ Sarah said as we headed towards the door.

She was almost outside, with me right behind her, when Ayushi called out.

‘Adi, did you see that book?’

I closed my eyes.

‘I’ll wait outside,’ Sarah said.

And before I could say anything, she was gone.

My heart sank, and I turned back. Ayushi had mentioned the paper in Sarah’s presence. There was no way around it now. I had to tell her everything.

I walked back to Ayushi’s bed. She gave me a big smile, completely unaware of what I was about to tell her. I pulled a chair closer and sat down. She looked beautiful, as always, but now wasn’t the time to think about that.

‘Yes, I saw the book, and I read the chit,’ I said.

‘So, what was in the letter?’ she asked excitedly.

‘You have no idea what that chit has done, Ayushi.’

Her smile disappeared almost instantly. I felt a little bad, but she needed to understand what had happened. Otherwise, she might have kept making the same mistakes.

'What?' she asked, staring at me.

'Sarah read it before I did,' I said.

'So what?'

She barely moved her lips. The rest of her face remained still.

Is she seriously not getting it?

'She misunderstood the whole thing and thought I was hiding something from her.' I took a deep breath before continuing. It was uncomfortable explaining something like this to another girl, especially when it involved Sarah's feelings.

'What?' Ayushi asked, sounding both surprised and annoyed.

'She's just like that,' I explained.

'Then she shouldn't be. What if an air hostess talks to you on a flight? What if you have to drop a friend's girlfriend somewhere? What if all your clients are women, and they're all my age?'

She had a point, but I was expecting an apology, not a list of hypothetical situations.

'Then she'll know about it,' I replied without thinking.

'And who's going to tell her?'

I was already getting irritated. I didn't need relationship advice from Ayushi. I knew how to handle Sarah.

'Of course, I will. Who else?'

'See, Adi, it's okay to be a little apprehensive. But isn't this too much?' she asked.

I agreed with her, but I wasn't about to admit that so easily.

'No, she's just like that. And I'll do anything she asks,' I replied without thinking.

I sounded like a fifty-five-year-old mother-in-law who had decided to make her daughter-in-law's life miserable for absolutely no reason.

'Until?'

'Death,' I answered.

Ayushi covered her face with her hands. I could practically imagine her thinking, You're fucking immature.

'I know you two love each other, but...'

I stopped listening after those first few words.

Wait. What?

Was it universally accepted that Sarah and I were in love? Who was spreading these rumours?

'What?' I asked, suddenly interested in hearing the rest.

Ayushi looked at me.

'I was saying that it's obvious you two love each other. But you're both weird. Tell me, do you love her?'

'There's nothing like that. We just know each other,' I said.

'Sorry for saying this, but fuck you, Adi. Stop lying to me.'

'I'm five years older than you, and I'm your lawyer. Have some respect.'

'Forget it. I don't want to get involved in your relationship. Do whatever you want. Get married next week, or kiss each other's children at parties ten years from now.'

She picked up the book and leaned back against the wall.

I had come back to tell her how badly the whole chit incident had gone. I'd expected her to feel guilty, perhaps even cry and apologise. Instead, she was busy discussing my nonexistent relationship.

'She left my house in a rage after reading it. Then she drank until she was completely drunk,' I said.

Ayushi started laughing.

For a moment, I wanted to grab her bedsheet and stuff it into her mouth.

'That isn't funny, Ayushi. Not at all,' I said.

What I wanted to tell her was that she was a murder suspect, a team of millionaires wanted her punished, and I was her lawyer, working eighteen hours a day without getting paid. The least she could do was take me seriously when I was telling her about something that had upset someone who meant everything to me.

'I'm sorry. She loves you as much as I love books,' Ayushi said.

What a lovely comparison. That was the kind of thing only a true bibliophile could come up with.

'She doesn't,' I said.

'I'm not asking for your opinion,' she replied.

I looked down at the floor, aware that Ayushi was watching me.

'Okay, what exactly do you want me to do?'

'Nothing. I'm leaving now,' I said, getting ready to stand up.

'Wait. Do you want me to apologise to her? I will,' she offered.

'Don't. It's fine.'

'Don't make me the villain now. Call her.'

I said nothing and continued looking at her.

'Please,' she insisted.

I called Sarah.

'What?' she answered. I could tell from her voice that she was still angry.

'Come here.'

'Why?' she asked, confused. She probably thought she wasn't needed anymore.

'Please.'

She hung up.

★

Sarah entered the room a minute later, looking far less cheerful than she had earlier.

'What?' she asked me directly.

'I'll tell you everything. Come here,' Ayushi said.

Sarah looked at her, confused. I knew I was going to pay for this later.

She sat beside Ayushi's bed and stared at her without saying a word. The tension between them was almost unbearable.

'I'm sorry. We were talking about his eighth-grade crush,' Ayushi began. 'When they were separated, he wrote a letter to her and then threw it into the dustbin. I've spent my entire life reading stories, so I got curious about the letter and wanted to know what was in it. That's why I tucked the paper into the book. I should have asked him about it while you were there.'

I braced myself for disaster. I could practically imagine the hospital roof collapsing on me.

Instead, Sarah turned to look at me.

'I've never heard about this eighth-grade crush,' she said calmly.

That was the quiet before the storm.

'Oh, by the way, why did you react so strongly? Who are you, female Devdas?'

Sarah immediately realised that I'd told Ayushi about the previous day's events. I might have been in serious trouble, but her embarrassment seemed to take over before her anger could.

'What did I do?' Sarah asked Ayushi, trying to figure out how much she knew.

'You got drunk and didn't go to your hostel all day,' Ayushi replied.

Thank you very much, Ayushi. Some people have a natural talent for ruining another person's life, and she made it look effortless.

'No, no. I had some work, so I didn't go to the hostel. And I drink sometimes. That has nothing to do with the chit. He's stupid,' Sarah said, trying to smile.

'Don't worry, Sarah. I'm not going to eat him. He's completely yours,' Ayushi said.

Nobody had ever spoken about us so casually. She said it as though she were running a marriage bureau and had just finalised a match. She could probably have made an excellent matchmaker.

Sarah and I looked at each other, both searching for a response. Thankfully, Ayushi noticed our discomfort.

'Am I making you two uncomfortable?' she asked.

'A lot,' I said.

We all burst out laughing.

'Now, please tell me what was in the letter,' Ayushi said, suddenly serious again.

'Someone needs to tell me the whole story first,' Sarah said.

She walked over to me, slapped my arm, and returned to her seat.

Ayushi giggled.

'Let me tell you,' she said.

She then narrated the same story I'd told her, including the characters Lily and Jack.

Sarah listened quietly. When Ayushi finished, Sarah smiled. I wasn't entirely sure what to make of that.

Then both of them turned towards me.

'What exactly was in the letter?' Sarah asked.

I took a deep breath.

I'd replayed those words in my head a thousand times. I remembered every single one of them and could repeat the letter without missing a word.

Lily,

The last three months have been the best three months of my life. I don't think you know how happy you make me. Sometimes, I come home after seeing you and keep thinking about the things we talked about. Sometimes, I even smile for no reason, and then I realise I'm thinking about you again.

I don't know when I started feeling this way. I only know that I don't want to be just your friend anymore.

I love you, Lily. I don't know what you'll say when you read this, and I'm a little scared to find out. You don't have to love me back. I just couldn't leave without telling you.

Ayushi looked genuinely moved by the letter. Sarah's expression was harder to read, although she was smiling too.

'Wow. That's breathtakingly good for a fourteen-year-old. You understood love when you were fourteen. Some people take decades to figure it out, even after getting married,' Ayushi said, her eyes lighting up.

I smiled.

'Are you jealous again, Sarah?' Ayushi teased.

She didn't know Sarah well enough to joke with her like that. Sarah usually couldn't take such jokes, especially when they came from me. I expected her to snap at Ayushi, but surprisingly, she didn't.

'Why would I be jealous? I don't care what he does. And why would I be jealous of a fourteen-year-old witch?' Sarah replied.

'You're clearly not jealous,' Ayushi said, laughing.

Sarah tried to hold back, but she eventually laughed too.

'You guys should get married someday.'

CHAPTER

30

'I'm telling you, I'll crash the scooter somewhere if you don't stop,' I said as Sarah punched me for the eleventh time. We were on our scooter, heading to Divya's clinic. No calls, no messages. Our intention was simply to freak her out. Almost fifteen hours had passed, and we were done waiting for her to call.

'You've spoiled my image in her mind,' she said, and I counted twelve.

'I didn't know she'd say it so directly,' I replied. Thirteen.

'By the way, did you hear? Even she thinks you love me!' Sarah said.

'She's stupid, just like you,' I answered.

Why didn't I ask Sarah whether she loved me or not?



When we arrived at Divya's clinic, our confidence was at an all-time high. Sarah approached the receptionist as if we were goons demanding protection money. The receptionist recognised Sarah, and her brain immediately reminded her of how much she hated her.

'Yes?' she asked, with a tone that practically screamed, Why are you here, bitch?

Sarah was about to respond when the phone rang, and we were invited inside. Sarah flashed the receptionist a triumphant smile.

Divya had spotted us on the live CCTV feed and clearly didn't want any more trouble. There had been no cameras when we last visited. Perhaps Divya had installed them afterwards. When you're involved in dangerous situations, you tend to become overly careful, especially when your friend distributes narcotics by the kilogram.

'Why are you here? I told you I needed time to think. And why is she here?' Divya almost screamed as she stood up from her chair.

Sarah's presence irritated her. Sarah took a seat in front of Divya, and I did the same. Sarah then poured some water into a glass and handed it to Divya. The gesture looked cool and gave me that movie-gangster vibe, like one man lighting another guy's cigarette.

Divya sipped the water, closed her eyes for two seconds, and exhaled heavily.

'There's no other way. What are you thinking? And why are you still thinking?' Sarah said, making it clear that she would be leading our side of the conversation.

'Why are you even here? He's the lawyer,' Divya shot back. Her hatred for Sarah was clearly audible in her voice.

'Shut up. I'm a reporter, and it won't take me ten minutes to spread your screenshots around the city.' Sarah pointed a finger at her.

Divya's eyes widened. She groaned in annoyance, but there was nothing she could do. Instead, she settled for another glass of water. Sarah grinned, clearly enjoying herself. Divya had insulted us at this very place the last time we visited.

I watched Divya carefully. When I'd first met her, I'd never imagined I would see her this unstable someday.

'This is not right,' Divya warned.

'Thank you, madam. Any other suggestions?' Sarah replied.

Divya cupped her hands around her face and held them there for a minute. Then she picked up her iPhone from the table and dialled a number.

'Yes, Gaikwad,' she said over the phone.

Gaikwad was her lawyer, and she had finally made her decision. We were on our way to success.

'Yeah, yes, yes. All right, six at my clinic. Done.'

She ended the call. Although I'd heard only one side of the conversation, I could make perfect sense of it. She put down the phone and looked at us.

'This is a fucking risk for me. How can I trust that lawyer?' Divya said, tapping hard on her table.

'Shut him up, just like you tried to do with us. Feed him some more money,' Sarah said, getting up from her chair.

I hadn't spoken a single word during the entire meeting.

'What about the screenshots?' Divya asked.

'I've already deleted them from my phone. There's only one copy left, on the memory card. I'll destroy it the day the court declares Ayushi innocent,' I said.

'Okay, I trust you on this,' she said.

'That's what you can do,' Sarah replied, and we left the room.



'Is that it?' Sarah asked, looking at me curiously.

We were sitting in the mall's seating area, finally free to do something other than worry about the case. We decided to watch a movie. I never needed much convincing when it came to movies.

'Hopefully. Divya is now responsible for making sure the case stays with us,' I said, helping myself to another bite of Sarah's pastry.

It was an ordinary chocolate pastry, but the mall had managed to turn it into a twohundred-rupee luxury. Which meant the bite I'd just taken had cost me forty rupees. I tried not to think about it.

'Wow! We won the whole thing outright! We didn't even let her spend a single day in jail, and now you're going to win your first case. Congratulations, Mrs. Lawyer!' Sarah exclaimed, taking the cup from my hand.

'I wouldn't celebrate just yet. There's still evidence against Ayushi, and Vaishali will repeat what Ayushi told her after the murder. We're in a much better position now, but that doesn't mean we can afford to be careless in court. I'll meet Sinha and see if he can take over the case,' I explained.

'But why? The opposing lawyer will practically be ready to lose, Adi!'

'That still won't win us the case,' I said with a smile.

'Hmm,' Sarah replied, finally understanding my point.

'I'm happy for her, but I'm not happy with myself,' I admitted, my smile fading.

'Why? You did an excellent job.'

'I was supposed to handle this properly in court. I'm a lawyer, not some problemsolving expert. I took matters into my own hands and did things the wrong way.'

'You did what the situation demanded,' she said gently.

'That's not going to happen again,' I said, making a promise to myself.

'It won't,' Sarah assured me with a smile.

I smiled back. There was something different in the way she looked at me now. A kind of admiration I wasn't used to seeing in her eyes. For once, I didn't feel the need to make a joke about it.

'By the way, I'm going back to work tomorrow.'

My stomach sank.

'Why?' I asked, making no effort to hide the disappointment on my face.

She laughed. 'What do you mean, why? I've taken enough holidays. They've already started deducting my salary!'

We had spent so much time together lately that I'd almost forgotten what it was like when she was busy with work. Sometimes, we wouldn't see each other for three or four days in a row. The thought of going back to that suddenly felt worse than it should have.

'All right, fine,' I said, trying and failing to sound unaffected.

Sarah giggled and gently touched my face. We finished the pastry, stretching those last few moments together without admitting that either of us wanted them to last longer.

'So, what movie are we watching?' I asked.

She gave me a knowing smile.

'Since you love me so much, let's watch something horrifying.'

AUTHOR'S NOTE

I wrote this story when I was nineteen. A lot has changed since then, including the person who wrote it. But somewhere along the way, Aditya, Sarah, Ayushi, and the rest of this strange little world stayed with me.

Thank you for picking up this book and spending a few hours with them.

I hope you enjoyed reading it as much as I enjoyed finally putting it into your hands. This was my first story. I hope it won't be my last. There are still so many stories I want to tell, so many worlds I want to build, and I hope I'll find you in one of them someday.

— Bhaiyasaheb Ashok Aware